GI BILL

GI Bill

THE AUTOBIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH
OF
A CIVILIAN IN UNIFORM
DURING
WORLD WAR II

BY

ALBERT WILLIAM KRATZKE

To Ruth

who cajoled and coaxed,
but also supported and encouraged me.
I could not -- or would not -- have
undertaken this project without her help,
especially in editing the manuscript.
Thank you, my dear!!



Billy has gone for a soldier!

Paraphrase of a line from *Johnny Has gone for a soldier*,
an adaptation of the Irish *Shule Aroon*,
a song popular during the Revolutionary War

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Frontispiece
ALBERT WILLIAM KRATZKE IN UNIFORM

FOREWORD, pages 1-3

PAGE 4

Chapter I
PEARL HARBOR AND ME, pages 5-17

PAGE 18

Chapter II
ARMY TRAINING, pages 19-37

PAGE 38

Chapter III
DESTINATION: EUROPEAN THEATER OF OPERATIONS, pages 39-46

Chapter IV
Alsace, pages 47-50

Chapter V
High Vosges Mountain Campaign, pages 51-54

Chapter VI
BAPTISM OF FIRE, Pages 55-68

Chapter VII
Into Germany – and Back, pages 69-80

Chapter VIII
The Low Vosges Mountain Campaign, pages 81-85

PAGE 86

Chapter IX
Hatten-Rittershoffen, pages 87-97

PAGE 98

Chapter X
Defense, pages 99-111

PAGE 112

Chapter XI
Götterdämmerung, pages 113-115

PAGE 116

Chapter XII
The Final Dash, pages 117-131

PAGE 132

Chapter XIII
Occupational Duty: Töging and Fürstenfeldbruch. pages 133-144

Chapter XIV
Occupation Duty: Bad Reichenhall, pages 145-155

PAGE 156

Chapter XV
A Tale of Two Cities (and a Few More), pages 157-164

Chapter XVI
Winter in the Bavarian Alps, pages 165-170

Chapter XVII
HOME, pages 171-179

PAGE 180

Chapter XVIII
A Soldier's Return, pages 181-195

PAGE 196

APPENDICES

Appendix A
ARMY IDENTIFICATION, MEANINGS, AND ACRONYMS, pages i-ii

Appendix B
14TH ARMORED DIVISION, THE LIBERATOR DIVISION, pages iii-iv

Appendix C
INTO HELL AND OUT:
TRACING THE ROUTE OF THE 14TH ARMORED DIVISION, page v-vi

Appendix D
THE AMERICAN M4A3E8 SHERMAN MEDIUM TANK, page vii
AND
THE GERMAN PZKW VI TIGER 1 AUSFÜRUNG H HEAVY TANK, page viii

Appendix E
THE ARTICLE *CHRISTMAS EVE* AS PRINTED IN THE *LIBERATOR*
AND
BERTHE HOLTZMANN'S LETTER, pages ix-xiv

Appendix F
SALZBURG MUSIC FESTIVAL PROGRAMS, pages xv-xvi

Appendix G
CITATIONS, RIBBONS, AND MEDALS, page xvii

Appendix H
ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF PRESIDENT TRUMAN, page xviii

Appendix I
HONORABLE DISCHARGE DOCUMENT, page xix

Appendix J
SEPARATION QUALIFICATION RECORD, page xx

Appendix K
LETTER OF BRIGADIER GENERAL JOHN K. RICE, page xxi

Appendix L
ADDRESS OF BRIGADIER GENERAL JOHN K. RICE, page xxii

To Grandpa with love,
Jessica

BIBLIOGRAPHY

FOREWORD

To my children Bill, Mary, Tom, Steve, and Peter,

Your mother has already written a comprehensive history of our family starting with her nineteenth birthday on August 14, 1945, the day World War II ended.

Historians deem that war the defining event of the twentieth century. Our family's story, therefore, would be less than complete without some accounting of it, so I relate to you my remembrance of the years between the United States' entry into the War in 1941 and my return to civilian life in 1946.

I have interspersed my personal account with the impersonal big picture of the War in Europe, so you may see how my part as an individual soldier played itself out against the much larger backdrop of strategies, battles, and final victory.

I am writing shortly after the fiftieth anniversary of many of the important and decisive events of the War. The anniversary was duly noted with many solemn observations at battle sites and with much attention from the news media. Your mother and I were among the many pilgrims who paid homage both in Europe and in the South Pacific.

My childhood and early teens were like those of many other children of the Twenties and Thirties. I was secure in the bosom of my parents, my brothers, my extended family, and my church. I felt the Depression only as a time for careful stewardship of resources and conservative approach to spending, not a time of want or privation.

I spent two grade-school years, fourth grade and eighth grade, attending St. Luke's Lutheran School in St. Louis. There I stayed with my mother's sisters, my Aunts Minnie, Frieda, and Ella Hoefener. My mother's other living sister and her husband, my Aunt Emma and Uncle Frank Holbrook, lived nearby. Uncle Frank had a maiden sister Ada, who rented a house near Sportsman's Park, home of the American League St. Louis Browns and the National League

St. Louis Cardinals. With all those relatives I was surely loved and cared for -- and just as surely spoiled!

The events leading up to the War occurred during those formative years, but I have only dim recollections of the current events of the time. As a teenager I was less interested in the accounts of international diplomacy and invasions in Europe than I was in the daily baseball standing of my favored Cardinals.

I spent one more academic year living with my aunts -- when I was a freshman at Washington University in St. Louis in the fall of 1940. By then I was more aware of world happenings, but even so as a college freshman I did not spend much time poring over news articles relating events on other continents.

The citizens of our country were especially ill-informed about things that happened in Germany. Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain's assurance of *Peace in Our Time* had quieted our fears. I did not learn of incidents like the 1938 *Kristallnacht,* that night when Jewish business establishments were smashed, until after the War. The existence of concentration camps was regarded as mere rumor.

Recent historians have written much about the United States' ignoring what was going on in Germany during the late Thirties. They are especially critical of President Franklin Delano Roosevelt and of the papacy. However, other historians such as Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., maintain that Roosevelt alone among the free world leaders recognized the danger of Nazism but was powerless to act without the cooperation of Congress. Roosevelt, in fact, was the first leader to recall his country's ambassador to Berlin.

One incident worthy of note occurred towards the middle of my first semester at Washington. My German teacher was deported, sent back to Germany. There was much speculation about his activities in this country. Was he a spy or perhaps a double agent being sent to Germany by our government? We never found out, but I suspect he was just a German citizen who had taken a job in the United States. His sympathies were surely with Germany, but I doubt that he was involved in any sinister 'cloak and dagger' schemes. My postwar years, of course were different. I <u>had</u> become aware of events on the world scene. Moreover, I had been in combat, a sobering experience. It has

been said that one does not return from a war the same person as the one who went into the war. One is different -- perhaps inexplicably different -- but surely different. I experienced that change, and you may want to know something of the times and events that contributed to that change. I hope that what follows helps you to understand.

Shew me thy ways, O Lord; teach me thy paths.

Lead me in thy truth, and teach me.

... Psalm 25:4-5a, KJV

Chapter I

PEARL HARBOR AND ME

After my freshman year at Washington University, I matriculated as a sophomore at the University of Minnesota for the academic year 1941-42. There I quickly settled into a student's usual routine of classes, work, and play. My father continued to serve his parish in Height of Land, Minnesota, so I was closer to home than when I went to school in St. Louis. Everything seemed to be going very well when --

The Japanese Navy bombed Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, on December 7, 1941. On that date America's formal involvement in World War II began. The United States officially declared war on Japan on December 8 and on Japan's Axis partners, Germany and Italy, on December 11.

December 7, 1941, fell on a Sunday. I went to church that morning at the University of Minnesota Continuation Center. Gamma Delta, the Lutheran student organization, used the chapel in that facility to hold its services. On the walk back to my room I noticed that the street was very quiet. When I reached home, Joe Janecky, my roommate, was uncharacteristically somber. I then learned why there was no one on the streets. The news of the bombing of Pearl Harbor, which happened late morning central standard time, was on every radio station, and everybody was at home listening. Joe and I were excited and scared, and we talked of what the War might mean for each of us. Joe was in the Naval Reserve Officer Training Corps, so he was certain he would be called to duty. He hoped he would be able to stay in school long enough to earn a commission. I had no such commitment, so I could not even speculate as to what might happen to me.

I was working for my meals as a bus boy and dishwasher in the University hospital dining room for student nurses and other employees. It kept strict hours, so I had to hurry off to lunch. I left Joe and walked the half-mile to the hospital. For the first time after hearing the grim news I was alone.

I wondered if and when I might be called to serve. I thought about my parents and how they would react to my being so close to the age of induction -- and I prayed. I do not remember how I prayed or for what, but I know I prayed, and I prayed hard.

The next day I attended the all-University convocation. A radio broadcast of President Roosevelt's Declaration of War speech ("On December 7, a date that will live in infamy ... ") was part of the program. I was even more introspective than I had been the day before, for now I began to appreciate the gravity of our nation's position and what it might mean to me.

Our country's entry into the War silenced all who had expressed ambivalent ideas concerning world politics, especially in regard to Germany. There were many people of German extraction in the society I knew. The majority of parishioners in the congregations my father served as well as in the neighboring parishes were descendants of German immigrants. In fact, the midwest states had a large German population. Germany of the Thirties had achieved economic and political stability, so naturally some people openly expressed sympathy for the German cause and a grudging admiration for Adolph Hitler. One such person, known affectionately as Papa B---, was a pastor in the same circuit as my home congregation. He was outspokenly sympathetic towards the new Germany, so much so that his fellow ministers cautioned him to keep his opinions to himself. However, I do not think there was ever any doubt about his loyalty to the United States, were he forced to make a choice.

During Christmas break that first December of the War, everyone was quite subdued. I went back to the campus a little early to try to determine what to do. I was a pre-medical student at the time, so there was some hope that I might be deferred from the draft. (Student deferments usually went to persons in medical, dental, and divinity schools.) By then, however, I realized I was not suited for a career in medicine. I went into pre-med for the usual reasons, to do good and to earn well, and I was also subjected to some gentle

parental pressure. But I soon found that I had no great aptitude for the natural sciences and that the physical sciences and mathematics were much more interesting and certainly easier for me.

Five of my friends and acquaintances of the period are of special note. One of them was my roommate Joe. Three -- Neil Stacey, Floyd Myrick, and Joe Vranish -- were fellow employees in the nurses' dining room, and Tom Olson, the fifth member of the group, was an orderly at the University hospital. I shall write something about each of them, for each had different plans and expectations concerning the War.

Joe Janecky was from Barnesville, Minnesota. His father was a dentist. Prior to coming to the University of Minnesota, Joe lived with an uncle in New York. He was in residence there long enough to satisfy the requirements for entrance to the City College of New York (CCNY). (Later, when the college was recognized as a university, its letters changed to CUNY.) The school had (and has) a no-tuition policy for residents of New York City. While living in New York, Joe worked as a theater and concert hall usher. The job required him to own his own tuxedo. Because he already had a tux when he came to Minnesota, he became an usher for the Minneapolis Symphony, where ushers also were expected to provide their own dress clothes. The concerts were held in Northrup Auditorium on the University campus. If there were a vacant seat in the back rows, Joe often let me have it shortly after the concert began. That was a nice arrangement, and I got to hear the orchestra under several famous conductors. The resident conductor at the time was Dimitri Mitropoulos.

Neil Stacey was from Red Lodge, Floyd Myrick from Hamilton, and Joe Vranish from Roundup -- all towns in Montana. They had been fraternity brothers at Montana State University in Bozeman, and they all aspired to medical school. Montana had no state medical school, so they took advantage of the University of Minnesota medical school's policy of extending resident privileges to the citizens of Montana. Neil, Floyd, and Joe jointly owned a 1930 Model A Ford and traveled to Minneapolis in it during the summer of 1941. The Model A had the nickname *Bessie,* which on occasion became *BessiFord.* I soon

bought a share in the old car. Even though I had only part-ownership, I consider Bessie as my first automobile. I had never studied auto mechanics, but I soon learned all about a Model A Ford. I became the one who could keep Bessie going.

Neil was accepted into dental school in Chicago sometime in 1943. Dental school was a compromise; he really wanted medical school. Nonetheless, preparing to be a dentist kept him out of the Service. He married Gwen Sayers, a nurse whom he had met while working at the University student nurses' dining room. He and Gwen moved to Missoula, Montana, after the War, and they lived very nicely.[1]

Floyd, too, went to dental school as a way to avoid the draft. Because he was in a Navy program and officially in the Navy, he was required to go into active service after being graduated. Upon completion of his obligation, he still wanted to become a physician. He applied to medical school, was accepted, completed the requirements, and later specialized in orthopedic surgery. He married Delores McKinney, a nurse from the University of Minnesota. Floyd's residencies were in Ocean Lake, Oregon, and in Seattle. He also worked as a Boeing physician for a time. We saw the Myricks quite a bit during our early days in Seattle.

I even arranged a rental house for them. In 1952, I was working for T. Wilson, who later became president and chief executive officer of Boeing. T. was slated to study at Massachusetts Institute of Technology on a Sloan-Kettering fellowship for a year. That was exactly the length of time the Myricks needed housing, so I got the two parties together. After many years of marriage, Floyd and Dee were divorced, but they still maintain some kind of relationship.Joe Vranish went into the Navy and served in the Pacific Theater. He used his GI Bill benefits for an education in business administration. He married Rita,

[1] Our family was graciously entertained at breakfast in the Stacey home on our way to Boulder, Colorado, in the summer of 1960. Neil died of a heart attack some time after our visit. He was only in his forties.

a nurse from his home town, and took a position with a midwestern utility company.[2]

Tom Olson was studying to be an architect while working in the hospital. I lost all contact with Tom until after the War. One day early in my employment at Boeing, I ran into him; he was working for Boeing, too. He married after the War and moved to Moscow, Idaho, to attend the University of Idaho law school. From there he went to work for Boeing, and later still he tried hospital administration at Swedish Hospital in Seattle. We met with the Olsons socially several times during their Seattle stay. Tom was still in hospital administration when he and his family moved to Lima, Ohio. After their move we lost contact except at Christmastime. One year our card was returned, and I have been unable to contact Tom since then.

The events of the War now became very important to us students. Before the War few young people paid attention to headlines, but after the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor, all of us followed the War news daily.

The first event of great interest was the landing of American troops in Northern Ireland in January, 1942. That meant that we had a physical presence in Europe, and surely many more troops would soon be sent overseas.

In February, the country went on daylight-saving time to conserve energy. It meant that from April to October we were on double daylight-saving time: our clocks were set two hours ahead. Before the War, daylight-saving time was a local option, and no Minnesota community had ever voted to have it.[3]

In early April, 1942, Bataan and Corregidor in the Philippines fell to the Japanese. On orders from President Roosevelt, General Douglas MacArthur and his family escaped to Australia in a small boat. Before he left, he made his

---

[2] We visited the Vranishes in their home in Minot, North Dakota, in 1964. The nine children, our five and their four, got up a front yard ballgame. All the offspring slept on the Vranish rec room floor. We seemed to be a compatible group, and I have regrets that we did not make more occasions to be together.

[3] After the war, DST was still determined by local option. In 1948, our first year in Corvallis, the Zion mission festival had an afternoon speaker from another county. His county was not on the same time as ours, so he arrived about an hour late for the service.

famous pledge to the Filipino people, "I shall return!" After the fall of Corregidor, the Japanese forced the captured soldiers and civilians to march to a prison camp. General Jonathan Wainwright was the hero of the hour. In spite of his rank, the Japanese forced him to accompany the captured Americans on the infamous Bataan Death March.[4]

Shortly after the defeat in the Philippines, General James Doolittle's daring raid on Japan was the big news. The general's squadron of two-engine B-25 bombers was launched from the carrier *Hornet* cruising six hundred miles off the Japanese coast. After the mission was complete, the bombers went on and landed in China. It was thought to be almost impossible to launch an airplane as large as a B-25 from a carrier deck. I saw newsreels[5] of planes taking off and wonder still how the pilots managed. After a bomber left the edge of the carrier deck, it would drop almost to the tops of the waves before beginning its climb. The raid had no great strategic value and the bombers actually did little damage, but it was a great morale boost for the homefront. The raid lifted spirits after the devastating defeat at Bataan in the Philippines.

In late May, 1942, Reinhard Heydrich, deputy chief of the Nazi Gestapo and chief German functionary in Czechoslovakia, was assassinated by Czech partisans. The immediate reprisals were terrible. Among the atrocities committed were the murder of all the males in the village of Lidice and the razing of the town.[6] Lidice was wiped from the face of the earth. Even though my roommate Joe was a second- or third- generation American, he had Czechoslovakian roots. He may have had no relatives in Lidice, but he was

---

[4] The Rev. and Mrs. Carroll Hinderlie were missionaries in the Philippines on December 7, 1941. Consequently they were part of the Bataan Death March. They spoke of their experience at Holden Village when we visited there in 1968. It has been reported by other observers that they were a great source of inspiration and encouragement in a most trying situation.

[5] Television was not yet common, so the public's chance to see films of current events was limited to newsreels, one of which was part of every movie program. The big newsreel makers were Pathe News, Movietone News, and The March of Time.

[6] In November, 1995, we visited the Holocaust Museum in Washington, DC There we learned that the atrocity committed at Lidice was only the beginning of the reprisal for the assassination of Heydrich. In related incidents a total of 6,000 Jews and Czechs were killed.

extremely shaken and horrified nonetheless. After nine months of sharing a room, I had gotten close to Joe, so I, too, experienced a vicarious horror.

The most sensational War news late that spring was the report of the Battle of Midway, by some accounts the turning point of the naval war in the Pacific. Once more the country's morale was boosted. The Battle of Midway was a decisive victory for the Allies.

In North Africa, General Irwin Rommel -- 'The Desert Fox,' acknowledged genius in the art of armored warfare, and a German World War I hero -- was having an easy time with the English in Egypt.

A little-known general named Dwight David Eisenhower assumed command of the Allied Forces in Europe. I was to get to know much more of him later.

At the end of the school year, Joe and I moved across campus to a spacious rooming house on East River Road. We had a much bigger and brighter room than previously. At the first rooming house each of us paid ten dollars a month rent, and at the second house we paid twelve dollars a month. That's a 20% increase, but we thought the new room worth the difference. The house was across the street from a bluff overlooking the Mississippi River. Our room faced the river, so we had a nice view and felt the river breezes. We could occupy our room only for the summer, so in September Joe and I moved into a rooming house across the street, where I stayed until I went into the Army.

That summer Joe and I both went to work for E.I. duPont deNemours and Co. at Rosemount,[7] a town south of St. Paul. duPont was building a gunpowder factory, so the company needed construction workers. Each of us was hired as a rodman/chainman, lowest rung on the ladder of a survey crew. Joe, however, volunteered when we were asked if there were any typists among the new hires. Joe could not type, but he thought office work would be easier than working outdoors. The day that we hired in was cold and rainy, so the

[7] We have other connections with the town of Rosemount. Carl Friedrich, Ruth's mother's brother, served a parish there. John Volkert, Ruth's father's father's brother, and his family established a farming community nearby. When the defense plant was built, they had to sell their land and move. At a Volkert reunion in 1989, Ruth and her sisters made renewed contact with that branch of the Volkert family.

weather probably had something to do with his choice. He made out fine, typing by the 'hunt and peck' method. The irony of all this is that I could type, but I did not volunteer because I thought I probably could not type well enough. We rode to work with Al Fischer, a parishioner from St. John's in Villard.

Work at duPont was interesting and paid well. I eventually rose above my humble beginnings and was permitted to operate surveying instruments called transit and level. I felt as if I were contributing to the war effort.

The Marines landed on Guadalcanal August 7, 1942. Many tales of heroism came out of the battles waged there.

The Germans advanced east into Russia, and the city of Stalingrad was in the news a great deal.

War events made good material for films. Just as the movies of the Thirties offered escape to a country in the depths of the Depression, the films of the early Forties gave us something to cheer about. John Wayne played in *Flying Tigers,* the story of a squadron of P-40 fighter planes. General Claire Chennault led the real Flying Tigers in China and was a popular hero. Humphrey Bogart played in *Sahara,* which was about the tanks in North Africa. *Holiday Inn* with Bing Crosby was another popular movie. Its remake, also starring Bing Crosby, was called *White Christmas.*

The summer ended, and we went back to school. Joe was still in the NROTC and awaited assignment while taking classes. I was not subject to the draft until later because I was still under age.

In early October, I traveled to Brainard, Minnesota, to be the best man in the Warren Maertens-Ruth Hilpert wedding.[8] Ruth had been a good friend since

---

[8] Fifty years later, in October, 1992, Ruth and I attended the Maertens' golden wedding anniversary celebration in Worthington, Minnesota. Because I had been best man, I was asked to be the master of ceremonies, and Ruth played the piano for the assembly of family and friends.

In the spring of 1990, we also attended Ruth Hilpert Maertens' and my fiftieth anniversary of high school graduation in Frazee, Minnesota.

Also, Edward T. Hilpert, Jr., (called 'Jonesy' for as long as I can remember) lives in Seattle and has been our attorney since we moved to the Northwest.

1927. Our fathers were ministers in neighboring parishes, and the Hilperts and the Kratzkes saw each other socially almost every week. Ruth and I were in the same class and went to the same high school. Ruth probably would not have asked me to be best man for Warren (I hardly knew him!) except that his friends were all some distance from Minneapolis, where he was stationed. I did not own a conservative suit, so I borrowed one from Floyd Myrick. I rode the train to Brainard with Marie, Ruth's sister and maid-of-honor. The wedding was held in early evening because we had to be out of the church by 7:30 P.M., when members of the congregation were to have hymn practice with the new, *i.e.* 1941, hymnal. I stayed with the Hilperts that night and went back to Minneapolis the next day.

In October, the St. Louis Cardinals beat the New York Yankees four games to one in the 1942 World Series. Like my father, who was graduated from Concordia Seminary in St. Louis, I was a Cardinal fan. Furthermore, my mother was from St. Louis, and, as mentioned earlier, I had gone to school there variously myself.[9]

Joe and I went duck hunting that fall. Joe's parents owned a lodge on a lake near New Prague.[10] My recollection of the lodge is bigger than life. I remember it as a place not unlike a movie set, either for a Sonja Henie skating movie or for a Nelson Eddy/Jeanette MacDonald Canadian Rockies romance. It had a huge stone fireplace and open-beamed ceilings. Joe's dad joined us for part of our weekend stay. Joe lent me a 16-gauge double-barrel shotgun. We settled into our duck blind, set out decoys, and waited. Joe blatted away on a silly duck call. It must have attracted the birds, for a large flock came over our heads and surprised us. Joe shouted, "Shoot where they're the thickest!" I blasted away with both barrels and got nothing. Neither did Joe. We did get

---

[9] Because I was in St. Louis for the eighth grade and second year of confirmation class, I have the unusual distinction of having gone through two public confirmation examinations, one at St. Luke's in St. Louis and later another at St. John's in Height of Land. St. Luke's confirmed its class on Palm Sunday, and St. John's confirmed its class in June. After my two examinations, I was confirmed by my father at St. John's.

[10] By this time Joe's father had moved his dental practice from Barnesville, Minnesota, where Joe grew up, to New Prague. New Prague was also the home of Irmgard Meyer, who married Otto Volkert, Ruth's uncle. Ruth was s flower girl at the Meyer-Volkert wedding in 1931.

some ducks later in the day, but we had to leave them with Joe's dad. We had no way to prepare them at school.

I had to register with Selective Service when the draft age was lowered to eighteen. Villard, the town to which my family moved from Height of Land, was in Pope County. I had the choice of registering in Minneapolis, my address while attending the University, or in Glenwood, county seat of Pope County. I figured the draft board from home might be more sympathetic towards a local boy going to college. I was mistaken: they classified me 1-A. I thought they might allow me to finish a school term I had already started if my induction date came during that quarter. Again I erred: they set my induction date for May with no extension. So I volunteered!

Gas rationing started in December. Most car owners were issued an A sticker, which limited the holder to four gallons of gasoline per week. Automobiles of that vintage seldom ran more than fifteen miles to the gallon. People in preferred professions, such as clergymen and physicians, were issued C stickers, which entitled them to more gasoline. My father had a C sticker. The ration sticker also determined the number and quality[11] of tires the holder could purchase.

In mid-December, after the end of fall quarter, I went to work in the Minneapolis Post Office for the Christmas rush. I put in long hours, but I did not mind. The pay, a dollar an hour, was good, and I made enough money to do my Christmas shopping. I think I went home on December 23.

That Christmas was the second one of the War, and the country seemed more optimistic than it had in 1941. The War was going better for the Allies.

Sometime during the 1942-1943 school year, Joe J started dating Cleo. After I came back from the War, Cleo was still on the scene. Joe and Cleo eventually got married.[12]

---

[11] Recap or new.

[12] In the fall of 1994, I re-established contact with Joe. Through an unlikely set of circumstances, I met someone who knew the Janecky family. I was able to call Joe, and he and I had a long chat. Ruth and I visited Joe in May, 1996. He was living on a small goat farm in

Like many other students about to go into the Service, my attention was easily diverted from school work. (Dick Keskey, a GI friend of mine, told me that he almost flunked out of the University of Michigan just before he went into the Army.) I made occasional stops at the game room and the billiard room in the University student union. The visits were infrequent during my early days on the University of Minnesota campus, but as the time drew near for my induction, I seemed to go oftener. I particularly liked to play three-cushion billiards and bridge. Harold Hill, the *Music Man,* would probably consider any skills I have in either game as evidence of a misspent youth. *You got trouble, trouble right here in River City!*

In January, 1943, I first heard the name *Casablanca.* Franklin Roosevelt, Charles de Gaulle, and Winston Churchill met there for a conference. Even before the city's namesake movie was made, the news media endowed Casablanca with an aura of mystery and intrigue, a kind of sinister glamour.

Early in 1943, rationing of leather shoes, canned foods, sugar, meats, fats, and cheese began. I ate at the University hospital, so I did not need any ration stamps. I gave them all to my mother. I was no longer given stamps after I went into the Army.

Sometime during the winter quarter a call went out for armory guards. Joe Janecky, Joe Vranish, and I volunteered. We were given free housing in a barracks-type room in the armory. We stood guard at night about three times a week, one two-hour shift each time. As guards we also had to check for security breaches such as unlocked doors. The guard on duty made one round during his shift, which took him about twenty minutes. I usually spent the rest of my time studying or reading. That was my first exposure to military life.

Between winter and spring quarters I took the train to Villard. A late winter storm stopped all traffic between Little Falls and Villard. The Northern Pacific Railroad paid for the passengers' hotel bills and meals. The accommodations

---

Texas. Cleo, mother of his two children, had died, and Joe subsequently remarried. He had led a colorful and interesting life during the fifty years since I had last seen him!

and the meals were nice, but I wanted very much to be at home since I was certain that I would be leaving soon for the Service.

The War in Europe began on September 1, 1939, when Germany invaded Poland. England honored her treaty with Poland and was drawn into the conflict. Because of the War, general world tension, and the United States' poor state of preparedness, President Roosevelt and Congress agreed that we needed a draft of civilian personnel for our standing Army. The draft began in October, 1940. Draftees were to serve for one year. After the US entry into the War, however, the time stipulation was changed to *the duration of the War plus six months.* Immediately after the draft was initiated, my father conducted a lot of weddings. Married status was a reason for draft exemption, and getting married became a method for dodging conscription. Many marriages were only marriages of convenience. Frequently friends of a couple observed that they did not even know that the young people were going together. Most of the marriages that I remember seem to have worked out.

Things changed after Pearl Harbor. A uniform became a badge of honor. To be sure, part of the urgency to go into Service arose from the *Everybody is doing it* syndrome. When one is very young, he sometimes does a thing more for adventure than for ideals. A draft-eligible male appearing in civilian clothes frequently drew speculation from observers as to the reason for his civilian status. The homefront also joined in the War fervor. Families were proud to be associated with servicemen, although I am sure that no mother in her heart of hearts wanted to send her son into the dangerous arenas of armed conflict. Parents of servicemen displayed small banners with stars in their windows, a blue star for each serviceman and a gold star for a serviceman who gave his life for his country.

I, too, wanted to be a part of the great national War effort. On a Monday in early May, 1943, I went into the Army as a private. I spent a few days with my family before going in. I could have reported to the induction center in Glenwood, but my parents and I wanted as much time together as possible. I asked for and was granted permission to report directly to Fort Snelling, near

Minneapolis. Fort Snelling would have been my first stop anyway, had I gone into the Service from Glenwood.

The round trip from Villard to Minneapolis, a distance of about a two hundred forty miles, required fifteen to twenty gallons of precious gasoline, but Mother and Dad still wanted to take me to Minneapolis. We left early on a Monday morning. My brothers, Bob and Paul, were in school. I did not have to go directly to Fort Snelling. My mother packed a lunch, and we had a picnic at Minnehaha Falls Park, not far from Fort Snelling. After lunch and a short stroll, we could see no reason to stay on. Dad parked at the gate, and he and Mother walked down the post entrance boulevard with me as far as they were permitted to go.

I walked on alone into a world that both frightened and excited me.

Be not far from me, for trouble is near.

... Psalm 71:3, KJV

Chapter II

Army Training

Once inside Fort Snelling, I was anxious, excited, and scared! I tried not to look back to the entrance gate where Mother and Dad were still standing. Finally I did turn around for one last wave. One does not think of bravery or the British 'stiff upper lip' at such a time, but I believe that my parents had more of those qualities than I. Perhaps they were of stronger faith.

Upon arrival, I was sworn into the United States Army. That night I prayed the prayer of a frightened young man.

When a civilian was inducted into the Army in those days, he was made to suffer certain indignities. He was kept on edge by means of fear and intimidation. From the very beginning of his service he played a 'cat and mouse' game. 'How to beat the system' became an obsession. I, too, tried some of the tricks. My assignment to quarters was not yet definite that first afternoon. I was simply told to find a bunk in any one of a number of wooden-floored tents. I had no sooner done so when a non-commissioned officer poked his head through the tent opening and announced that everyone in that tent was on Kitchen Police the next morning and would report to the kitchen at 4:00 A.M. Since I had not even unpacked, I picked up my luggage and moved to another tent. One fellow told me that he had moved four times. Eventually, of course, the powers that be made definite bunk assignments, and most of us were made to do some kind of onerous duty.

My stay at Fort Snelling was one of examinations. My pre-induction physical in part determined my draft status. Now I was given another physical, and I was also given the Army General Classification Test. The results of the AGCT determined one's fate in the Army. It was like an intelligence test, so usually a person's AGCT score and his Intelligence Quotient were similar. Mine were. The importance of this AGCT was impressed upon us, but some of the fellows seemed not to take the testing seriously. If only they had known that much of what would happen to them was determined by that one several-hour test! For example, my acceptance into the Army Specialized Training Program was

determined by my AGCT score. The ASTP was a college training program designed to prepare servicemen for certain specialties.

After about four days at Fort Snelling, I was put into a group going to Camp Barkley near Abilene, Texas. Camp Barkley was the basic training center for medics. My 1-A draft classification carried with it a *limited service* qualifier[1] because I was nearsighted. Service in the Medical Corps was regarded as limited service. (Tell that to any front-line stretcher bearer!) Also I had been in a pre-med curriculum in college, so the Medical Corps assignment seemed logical. Much of basic training was the same for all branches of the Service, and I reasoned that I could work the problem of transfer later. I did <u>not</u> want to be a combat stretcher-bearer.

We boarded the Rock Island Rocket, a very fast civilian train, in St. Paul and were assigned to Pullman cars. Two men slept in each lower berth and one man in each upper. I managed to get an upper. The Army does not allow for much privacy, so I especially enjoyed my upper berth. The trip was pleasant and uneventful.

The club car had a speedometer above the bar. Going through parts of Oklahoma our speed was over ninety miles per hour. Liquor was sold by local option in Oklahoma, each county determining by vote whether to be 'wet' or 'dry.' The 'wet' and 'dry' counties must have alternated because the bartender seemed always to be opening or closing the bar.

In Dallas our cars were switched to a different rail line, and we went on to Camp Barkley. At the camp railhead we were met by commissioned officers and non-commissioned officers, all of them a part of the permanent staff of the camp.

A sergeant was then put in charge of each arriving group of recruits. As soon as my group was assembled, the sergeant marched us off to the our barracks, our home for the next three months. We were still dressed for a Minnesota spring, so we found the march in the Texas heat very uncomfortable.

---

[1] Is it not ironic than many of the soldiers with the limited service classification (myself included) eventually found themselves in some of the worst fighting of the War?!

Basic training began immediately. Many recruits complained constantly, but things were not all that bad, really. Summer in central Texas may have been hot, but it was not humid. Unless a recruit drew KP or other fatigue assignment, his day was routine. He arose at 6:00 A.M. and 'fell out' for morning roll call and calisthenics. Before breakfast he policed the area around the barracks, *i.e.* he picked up cigarette butts, bits of paper, etc. One of the drill sergeants used very colorful prose. His favorite directive was "All I want to see is asses and elbows!"[2] The recruit went to breakfast about 7:00 A.M. Drill or a field exercise followed at 8:00 A.M. An hour-long lunch break began at high noon. Afternoons were generally devoted to classes -- a merciful arrangement because summer afternoons in Texas are very hot. Retreat formation was held at 5:00 P.M. with a retreat parade scheduled for every Friday. Dinner was at 6:00 P.M., and after dinner a soldier's time was his own. Lights out came at 11:00 P.M.

Because there was inspection every Saturday morning, Friday evening was spent getting haircuts, shining shoes, pressing trousers, etc. There was only one company barber on the post, so he was very busy on Friday evenings. A poor showing at the Saturday inspection meant extra duty or loss of time off. Such things as Sunday KP, extra drill or extra calisthenics were common punishments. The platoon leader, a lieutenant, usually conducted the inspection, although sometimes the company commander did the job himself. The inspecting officer was accompanied by a drill sergeant. The officer wore white gloves and ran his gloved fingers into out-of-the-way places in an attempt to find dust. He might also toss a quarter onto a randomly-chosen bed to see if it would bounce, a sign the bed was made properly. One time he checked all the beds. (I quickly learned to make a very tight bed with very taut square corners!) The inspector paid special attention to personal grooming. Shoes were to be shined to a high polish. A 'blitz' cloth was used to polish brass belt buckles. Keeping a cotton uniform looking good in hot weather was hard. Sometimes our drill sergeant conducted a pre-inspection inspection. If

---

[2] One of the jokes that circulated through the company concerned a crusty drill sergeant, who divided his people into groups according to their educational levels. The college men were assigned the hardest and dirtiest work, the high school group the next worst, etc. Those with a minimum education were told to stand and watch the others so as to learn from them.

someone had not shaved to the sergeant's satisfaction, he was made to take a quick shave with cold water. Bloody nicks and raw skin didn't help get the poor guy through inspection either!

Failure at inspection was a minor infraction. For more serious breaches of the rules such as failure to answer morning or evening roll call (tantamount to being Absent Without Leave) or insubordination, the training cadre convened and then meted out more severe punishment such as standing at attention or parade rest with full field pack for a long period of time in the Texas heat. Such a punishment today would be considered cruel and unusual. I never experienced anything like that.

We had several GIs who seemed to invite negative attention. In particular there were some professionals from New York -- accountants, attorneys, stock brokers, and such -- who did not take to training in west central Texas very well. A walk in Central Park was their version of 'roughing it.' They had a Regular Army drill sergeant, a country boy from the South, training them, and they seemed to incur his ire more than any of the other soldiers.

We spent our evenings at the movies, swimming pool, or post canteen. The canteen had a soda fountain, a juke box, a dance floor, a magazine reading room, a game room for ping pong and pool, and a place with a record player for listening to the records in the modest library. Sometimes we even had live music. There was always someone who could play the piano, and many of the players were very good. My basic training period lasted through the summer, so for most of us in that recruit class the swimming pool was the most popular after-work spot.

The Army barracks scene taught me much about life outside my own sheltered world. We had no incidents of pilfering, nor were there any fights. The main vice was gambling. Every payday there was a blackjack game and a craps game. Blackjack looked easy and fascinating, so I tried my hand at it and lost most of my first month's pay. I seldom lost after that. I watched games, and I especially studied the players. I learned a lot and fared much better in later games.[3]

After a prescribed time of good behavior, we were given weekend passes. A pass was good from noon on Saturday or immediately after Saturday morning inspection until sometime late on Sunday. The time limit gave the pass-holder too little time to go anywhere but Abilene, the camp's nearest town. On my first pass I did not go into Abilene until Sunday morning. I suppose I was unsure about where I would stay. Upon arrival I went to church, my first Lutheran service since arriving in camp. (The post Protestant services were interdenominational.) I then visited Abilene Christian College. The campus was nice, but those of us who wandered around there found no social outlet, *i.e.* girls, so we went back into town. Several of us ate dinner in the dining room of the Grace Hotel, the best eating place in Abilene. I had filet mignon. It tasted especially good to me because I was so tired of the food on the base.

Some of the officers lived with their families in Abilene; thus it was not uncommon to see an officer and his wife in town shopping. Enlisted men on pass sometimes strung themselves out in a line so that an officer coming toward them would be saluted by each of them in turn. Military courtesy dictated that the officer being saluted must return the salute. This ploy was especially effective if the officer were carrying grocery bags in both arms. (It would be better, however, not to do the saluting routine if the officer were from one's own unit. He would surely find a way to make each prankster regret that one salute!)

That summer I also learned a little about cock-fighting,[4] an illegal sport (if you wish to call it a *sport)* practiced semi-openly in the back country of central Texas. A member of my platoon was from Sweetwater, Texas, and he took a few of us to a fighting pit near his home town. A contest that is just a fight between two birds has little interest for anyone, not even for the owners, but the

---

[3] On another occasion I met and played poker with a professional actuary whose civilian job was with the Prudential Insurance Company. He approached the game unemotionally and analytically. He knew all of the probabilities of card combinations. He never lost, but he never won much either. A profitable but uninteresting experience for me!

[4] In April, 1991, Ruth and I attended a one-week Elderhostel on Appalachian culture near Abington, Virginia. The dormitories were all occupied when we arrived, so we stayed at a motel in town. The road from our motel to the camp passed a tract of land with many small enclosures. We were told that each of them housed a cock specially bred for fighting. The fighting itself was illegal in Virginia, but raising the birds was not.

excitement mounts dramatically when there is gambling on the outcome. We visitors did not bet but watched bug-eyed as the action outside the ring was almost as furious as that which went on inside.

Weekly we had a one-, two-, or four-hour hike with full field pack. One of the hardest parts of the hikes was self-enforced water discipline. We were allowed only one canteen of water for each hike. A canteen holds one quart, and a quart of water was not very much for a soldier in the hot Texas sun. We got a ten-minute break every hour, and we tended to gulp water as soon as the break began. I soon learned to ration mine. The training staff built up our stamina and hiking abilities carefully so that near the end of basic training we were ready for an eight-hour hike.

A goldbrick is a malingerer or goof-off. On hike day, the goldbricks appeared in great numbers as volunteers for supply room duty, for KP, etc. Sick call always brought out a number of them as well. Of course the drill sergeants knew what was going on, but they were powerless to stop the goldbrickers' practices completely. However, the sergeants were determined that everyone go on the final eight-hour march.

There was one extremely successful goldbrick, a likable older GI affectionately called *Pop.* He seemed always to be able to avoid difficult or tiring duty. Pop's platoon sergeant was a particularly loud and obnoxious Regular Army man, and he made it known that he would see to it that all of his platoon went on the march and that he would march next to Pop. Early in the march, the sergeant got blisters on his heels, and he was in real distress. Pop taunted him continuously: "Carry your pack, Sarge?" "Here, lean on me, Sarge!" "Hang in there, Sarge. Only twenty miles to go!" The sergeant finally had to get into the 'meat wagon,' the ambulance that followed the column of troops. At day's end the sergeant limped around the compound, and Pop announced that he might go to a dance that evening. Pop later confided to his barracks-mates that all he wanted to do was take a shower, go to bed, and sleep for twelve hours.

We had one four-day field bivouac in early August. The air was so hot and dusty that I was certain we were training for desert warfare.

A part of the training routine was learning the proper use of gas masks. We were made to walk through a room into which tear gas had been introduced. Except that a gas mask is uncomfortable, especially so in hot weather, the drill was easy. A soldier tends to get careless: when I was overseas, I rarely knew for sure where my gas mask was. Non-combatants such as cooks and truck drivers were even more remiss: they did not always know where their weapons were.

Another exercise in basic training was running the infiltration course. Machine guns at one end of the course fired live ammunition about eighteen inches off the ground all over the course. We crawled under the hail of bullets for about a hundred yards. One had to keep his head down or he would lose it. No accident was ever reported from our camp.

The last of the special training exercises was the obstacle course. We swung across water on ropes Tarzan style, and we came down cargo nets with full field packs in simulated amphibious landings. These are only two of the challenges conjured up by the course designer.

At the end of three months of basic training we were reassigned. I was offered the opportunity to go back to school in ASTP. I was also invited to apply for admission to Officer Candidate School. I probably would have fared better had I chosen OCS instead of ASTP, but the life expectancy for second lieutenants in front line units --whether medics, infantry, or any other branch -- was much less than that of privates. For whatever the reason, I chose ASTP and was sent to Oklahoma A&M (later called Oklahoma State University) for further testing and eventual school assignment. The bus trip to Stillwater, Oklahoma, site of the college, was hot and long, but we passengers were in good spirits because we were being sent to school.

Isn't it ironic?! When I was at the University of Minnesota and classified 1-A, I was anxious to end the suspense and go into Service. Now I was pleased to have the chance to go back to school, courtesy of Uncle Sam.

My group's quarters at OAM were disappointing. Because we were on a college campus, I expected to be housed in a dormitory. Instead we were put into barracks not much different from the ones we had just left. We were close to the campus and town, however, and even the Lutheran church was convenient.

The town and the campus were quiet when we arrived because the fall term had not yet begun. We were encouraged to take advantage of whatever campus activities there were. I took several classes that were offered without credit. In one of them, a class in physical education, I learned a little about fencing.

Again the Yankees and Cardinals played in the World Series. There was a firehall on the edge of campus, and anytime the firemen were idle, they had their radio tuned to the game. There were no fire calls during the Series, so I hung around the firehall and listened to the games. The Yanks won in five games.

I went to a sorority open house for servicemen. I suppose that we young men were in great demand, for we were treated very nicely.

One day I was summoned to the orderly room to take a phone call. My mother was calling from St. Louis. She was at her sisters' home and hoped I could get away long enough to visit her. St. Louis is about five hundred miles from Stillwater, and the most likely means of getting from one to the other at the time was by bus. The longest I could be gone was a weekend, and I could not go a thousand miles by bus in two days. I had to disappoint my mother -- and myself. Had I known some of the things I learned later and had I been a little more resourceful, I probably could have worked the problem.

There was a very interesting musician in my hut. He would take a chair into the shower room and sit and play his clarinet in there because the floor, ceiling, and walls were hard. He was a very good player, and the effect was wonderful. Much of what he did was bluesy, but he also played some Mozart. Fifty years later our son Peter makes sounds that remind me of a GI playing in a shower room -- music haunting and beautiful.

We received our school assignments early enough to begin classes with the fall quarter or semester. I was sent to Ohio State University (OSU)[5] in Columbus, Ohio.

Heretofore when I traveled by rail in the Army, I had always been in a regular railroad car, either coach or Pullman. This time I was to ride in a troop

---

[5] Not to be confused with Oregon State University, which would later play an important part in my life.

railroad car, which was quite different. Unlike Pullman cars in which berths ran parallel to the sides of the car, the troop car's bunks were perpendicular to the sides of the car. Three small bunks made up each tier with precious little space between tiers. The only aisle ran along the left wall of the car as one faced the direction of travel.

Troop cars for all their special appointments were still part of regularly-scheduled passenger trains. The car in front of ours was a coach crowded with civilians. Wartime travel was always difficult. Passengers were never guaranteed a seat, and many stood or sat on the floor.

We opened the door to a civilian car and talked to some of the people. We were forbidden to enter the coaches, so we talked from the doorway. I read a lot and played some cards. Trains were slow during the War, and the trip from Stillwater to Columbus seemed especially long.

Unlike the Army barracks in Stillwater which were built to house soldiers, our quarters at Ohio State were converted from peacetime student dormitories. Neal Hall, to which we were assigned, had been a girls' dorm until it was taken over by the Army for the ASTP program.

My roommate was married. Married men were given a housing allowance and were permitted to maintain living quarters off-campus. I am not sure why my roommate was also given dormitory space. He was rarely around, so I practically had a private room.

The course work was engineering-oriented.[6] We took courses in physics, mathematics, and other subjects. Our only reminder that we were still in the Army was a series of lectures on mine-laying, mine-removal, and enemy vehicle and aircraft identification.

Columbus, Ohio, was not a great service town. It had the usual theaters, night clubs, bars, etc., that any town its size has, but it had only one United Service Organization. Fort Hayes, a Regular Army base just outside the city, had several service clubs, so Columbus was thought to need only one USO. Obviously it

---

[6] Technically, we students were in the Corps of Engineers. I was thus classified for only a short time, but during that period I had my only formal picture taken. Thus my insignia on the frontispiece picture is that of the Corps of Engineers.

was the favorite hangout for those servicemen not stationed at Fort Hayes. Local young ladies acted as hostesses and served coffee and doughnuts. There were ping pong tables, music for dancing, etc.

On December 20, my Grandma Kratzke died. Six days later Grandpa died.[7] Grandma was eighty-five years old, and Grandpa was eighty-one. I was informed by telegram. My parents and I agreed that I would not try to go to Waconia for the funeral because with the slowness of train or bus travel I probably could not get there on time anyway.

We were given a few days off over Christmas, and I went to St. Louis. Had I been able to get a full week I would have gone home. I traveled by train and thus learned of a local time convention that was confusing. The city and the railroads observed different time zones, the former running on central time and the latter on eastern. Missing a train departure or connection was a common occurrence.

I met Harvey Sabinson,[8] Tom Bryant,[9] and Don Caldwell at OSU. Harvey had the room next to mine, and I think that Tom was his roommate. The four of us were to remain friends and stay in contact with each other for the rest of our Stateside service. Harvey was the only one I ever saw overseas.

---

[7] Minnesota was very cold that December. One night shortly after my Grandma's death, Grandpa was found wandering around in his garden, ostensibly looking for some non-existent horses. He contracted pneumonia and died a few days later.

[8] Harvey received a battlefield commission at Hatten-Rittershoffen, a battle to be considered in detail later. After the War, officers had to stay in the Army longer than enlisted men, so he and Sarah, married by that time, moved to Tacoma -- near Fort Lewis where he was stationed. Their housing was less than adequate for the climate, so they hated their stay. After his discharge, Harvey went to work as a New York theater publicity agent. He has been very successful: he was awarded a Tony for his efforts on Broadway. He and Sarah have two sons.

We saw the Sabinsons when we lived in Connecticut and several other times when we were in the New York area. They visited us in Bellevue on their way to Alaska.

[9] Tom Bryant became an attorney and lived in New York, Washington, DC, and Denver. One of Tom's sons was asthmatic, and his physician recommended Tom and his wife move him to a western climate. Tom's wife did not like the west, and eventually Tom and she were divorced. He then married Carol and moved to Bend, Oregon. He related to me how difficult it was to take the Oregon bar examination in mid-life. He did pass and set up practice in Bend. When our son Bill was working for a legal research firm in Olympia, Tom engaged Bill to do some work for him. After inquiries, Tom learned that his consultant was our son. He and I made contact and have kept in touch ever since.

In February or early March, 1944, the ASTP was closed because there was need for troops to replace front line casualties. At the time we did not know that the invasion of the European continent would begin on June 6 and that many line divisions were not fully manned. An untapped source of manpower was the ASTP, so in the spring of 1944, I found myself on a troop train bound for Camp Campbell, Kentucky.[10] All of the ASTP GIs from Ohio State University were assigned to the 14th Armored Division stationed there.

An armored division consisted of three tank battalions, three armored infantry battalions, three field artillery battalions, one armored engineer battalion, one armored signal battalion, one armored ordinance battalion, one cavalry reconnaissance battalion, one armored medical battalion, one armored military police platoon, and some other headquarters and service organizations. There was a great deal of difference in the skills required and in the exposure to danger among the various units of the division. We were very anxious about our assignments, and because the Army did little to accommodate the preference of any individual, each of us was sure that he would wind up as 'cannon fodder' in some front line organization. For most of us that turned out to be true.

I was assigned to Headquarters Company of the 25th Tank Battalion. The only worse assignment would have been the infantry. I think that Don Caldwell went to the engineers. Both Harvey and Tom were assigned to the 94th Cavalry. The cavalry was about as bad as the infantry. Cavalrymen no longer rode horses, but they were still used as the reconnaissance force, the 'eyes of the Army.' Their vehicles were fast armored cars and Jeeps, and neither offered much protection.

Generally, we ASTP soldiers were given a cool reception by the Army regulars. We had to prove ourselves to the troops who had been in the division for awhile. There were many references to those 'smart-ass college kids.' We seemed to get more KP and other odious chores than the others. Essentially we went through a hazing period. I remember no unpleasant incidents such as fights, and eventually most of us were accepted.

---

[10] In November, 1995, Ruth and I visited Fort Campbell. The barracks are still there. They are now being used as an academy for non-commissioned officers. The 101st Airborne Division is also stationed at the Fort, so it is a very active place.

Camp Campbell was built on barren Kentucky and Tennessee land. The place seemed always to be either rainy and muddy or hot and dusty.

We ASTP soldiers had a lot of catching up to do, so we spent an inordinate amount of time on the firing range and in the motor pool. I qualified on all of the required weapons in target shooting: I was rated *expert* in the sub-machine gun, *sharpshooter* in the carbine, and *marksman* in the M1 rifle. These ratings just happened to be in the descending order of skills: *expert* was the highest that one could attain, *sharpshooter* the next highest, and *marksman* the lowest. I was never a particularly good shot before I went into the Service: in fact, I had done very little shooting!

The targets on the firing range were arranged over a long pit. (The pit was below ground level, so there was little danger that anyone in the pit could be hit.) The target was mounted on a track so that it could be pulled down for examination after each shot. A GI in the pit was assigned to each target. His job was to score the target shooting and patch the hole in the target after each firing -- in a way much like a pin-boy's duties in a bowling alley before there were automatic pin-setters. After each firing, the GI in the pit would patch the hole, return the target to its position, and denote the spot the firer had hit by pointing it out with a colored disc mounted on a long pole. If the firer completely missed the target, the target tender waved a large tattered red flag across the target area. The flag was called *Maggie's drawers,* and having Maggie's drawers waved at one was considered ignominious. I had a few Maggie's drawers waved at me.

In the motor pool we were supposed to become acquainted with armored vehicles such as tanks, half-tracks, etc. Learning about them was dirty work and not much fun. In addition to our accelerated training program, we did the usual close-order drill and other activities carried on by the rest of the company.

I was assigned to the Assault Gun Platoon. An assault gun is a 105mm howitzer mounted in a Sherman tank. A tank crew has a tank commander, a gunner, a loader, a bow gunner, and a driver. The commander, the gunner, and the loader rode in the turret, and the bow gunner and the driver stayed down in the bow of the tank, the driver on the left and the gunner on the right. I began

as a loader, and I would remain the loader with the same crew until we suffered casualties. Eventually I would also serve as both gunner and commander.

The food in our company was very good. The mess sergeant had worked for a baking company in Chicago, and the chief cook had been a chef before being called into Service. Officers had their own mess, but many of them ate in the enlisted men's because the food was so much better than in their own. On Easter Sunday, the entire officer contingent ate with the enlisted men. We had baked ham and pineapple pie. I am sure that having the officers eat with us did not make the sergeant and staff of the officers mess[11] feel very good, even though they got the day off.

I spent most of my off-duty time with Harvey, Tom, or Don. I also began to have friends within the company. There were ASTP fellows from other schools, too, and we had a special bond. I became close to the members of my tank crew, especially so with Carl Phillips, the gunner.

Our leisure time on the post was spent drinking beer at the Post Exchange, playing games in the company day room, writing letters, or going to the movies. Movies were first-run and cheap -- and therefore very popular. War movies were great favorites.

One war movie that deserves especial mention was *Chetnicks.* It was about the exploits of a guerrilla army who harassed the Germans in Yugoslavia. The movie was exciting, and (of course) the good guys, the Chetnicks, outwitted the evil Nazis in the end. There must have been some element of truth in the story, but it was surely exaggerated. The Chetnick guerrilla band was made up of Serbian patriots led by Colonel Draja Mikhailovich. When Marshall Tito went into the hills in 1941 to organize an underground resistance to the occupying Germans, he found the Chetnicks already there. For a time he cooperated with Col. Mikhailovich. In 1944, the United States and Great

---

[11] The officers mess was an unusual institution. The officers paid for their meals and had a private club, so no enlisted man ever had to do KP in the officers' mess. However, if one were called upon for KP there, he was well advised to cooperate. Technically one could register a protest, but he would probably regret doing so. I personally was never asked to do KP in the officers mess.

Britain switched their support to Tito. In 1946, Tito's men captured Mikhailovich in a Yugoslav cave. Tito had Mikhailovich executed for collaborating with the enemy. The Chetnicks may not have been so heroic as the picture portrayed them, but we moviegoers of 1943 were none the wiser.[12]

There were several good ping pong players in our company. Most of them were young and lean, but one was an older, somewhat fat fellow named Louie Brill. He seemed a most unlikely type to excel at anything athletic. But Louie could beat everyone in the company. His style was strictly defensive: he stood very close to the table and was able to return any ball driven at him. It was maddening for some of the fellows who tried hard to win. I, too, lost to Louie.

The arrangement of the buildings at Camp Campbell was such that several rows of barracks were separated from the next group of barracks by a large field. The open area was great for throwing a baseball or football around. Sometimes we played pick-up games of touch football or baseball. The post had only one swimming pool. It was usually crowded, but I went swimming often during the hot weather anyway. Our platoon leader arranged for an outing one Saturday in early summer. We went to a park that had a lake, a few row boats, a swimming beach, and a diving tower. No one had a swimming suit. I cut off my oldest fatigue pants and used them as swimtrunks. We had a nice day, but we missed having girls at the party. In *South Pacific,* Luther sings, "What ain't we got? We ain't got dames!" We knew just how he felt!

In the spring, the battalion baseball team was organized. I went out for the team but did not make the starting lineup. I wanted to catch, but the platoon sergeant for the mortar platoon already had the position. He held it already the previous season. I did get to play the infield sometimes. We won about half of our games.

It was during our Camp Campbell duty that Harvey approached me with an offer to invest in a Broadway musical show that his brother was producing.

---

[12] In March, 1994, Ruth and I attended an end-of-the-term party for students of a short course about cities of the Mediterranean. The host and hostess were Serb-Americans. They had come to this country in the 1950s. I observed that as a young soldier I had been impressed by a movie about Serbian patriots, who were called *Chetnicks.* Our host then identified himself as a former Chetnick. He showed us a picture of himself as a Red Cross courier, his 'cover' at the time.

Harvey assured me that it was going to be a big hit. I asked him about the play and about his brother's record in show business. His brother had never produced a successful play, and the new play was by an unknown composer and writer. In spite of Harvey's insistence and enthusiasm, I did not take him up on his offer. I could not have invested much money anyway because I had very little. The musical was *Finian's Rainbow,* and the return to the investors was huge.

Camp Campbell was between Hopkinsville, Kentucky, and Clarksville, Tennessee. Shortly after arriving at Camp Campbell, I went to Hopkinsville *(Hoptown* to the GIs) on a Sunday pass. I attended a Missouri Synod church[13] in the morning, but I remember little else of the day. Another time I went to Clarksville and found it no more exciting than Hopkinsville. When we (usually Don Caldwell and I) had enough time, we went into Nashville. We could get to Clarksville by bus, and we hitchhiked from there to Nashville, a distance of about forty miles. Ride-sharing, even hitchhiking, was encouraged during the War. Because travel used fuel, advertising campaigns showed every empty seat in an automobile occupied by a Japanese soldier. Some soldier hitchhikers would shout to any passing car with empty seats, "You've got four (or however many) Japs riding with you." I doubt the drivers heard the taunts, but perhaps the shouters felt better for having blown off a little steam.

Visits to Nashville were entertaining -- if only because we were off the post. We stayed at the Maxwell House the first time we went there. A popular radio program of the time was the Edgar Bergen-Charlie McCarthy Show. It was sponsored by Maxwell House coffee, a company that advertised that its coffee was served at the gracious old Maxwell House in Nashville. A colorful old ante-bellum hostelry it may have been, but it surely was not nearly so comfortable as the more modern hotel across the street. Air conditioning was not common in the Forties, and the Maxwell House rooms were hot and stuffy. The furnishings, however, were genuine antiques, and the place was both picturesque and charming.

---

[13] The Missouri Synod churches that I attended in Abilene TX, Stillwater OK, Hopkinsville KY, and Clarksville TN were all small. I was unprepared for small congregations because all my life until then I had lived in the Midwest, where Lutheranism is much stronger than in the South.

In Nashville we ate at fine restaurants. Unlike the camp movie houses with wooden benches, the Nashville theaters had seats with cushions and backs. The first movie that I saw there was *Two Girls and a Sailor.* Centennial Park has a full-scale replica of the Parthenon on the Athens Acropolis, the only such replica in the world. The city's permanent art collection is housed there. The Parthenon also contains an impressive 42-foot-high sculpture of the goddess Athena. Don and I spent considerable time in the park because it was so very interesting and different.

The invasion of the European continent, which began on June 6, 1944, was of great interest to our camp. In the days following the June 6 landings, the talk in camp was about nothing else. "Would the 14th be going soon?" "Might the War in Europe be over even before we had a chance to fight?" "Did the invasion mean that we would be going to the Pacific?" We speculated on the possibilities.

The Missouri Synod Convention was held in St. Louis that summer, and my father attended. Unlike my failed effort to visit my mother in St. Louis when I was in Oklahoma, I managed to obtain a three-day pass to go see him. My Uncle Frank's sister Ada, whom many of my generation called *Aunt* Ada even though she was not a blood relative, lived near the stadium in which the St. Louis Cardinals and the St. Louis Browns played. Dad went to a ballgame with some other ministers, and afterwards he stopped at Aunt Ada's house. I met him there. Our time together was far too short. I wished my mother could have been with us. I missed her.

Aunt Ada was Catholic, and she gave me a St. Christopher Medal.[14] She told me that she knew I probably did not believe that it would offer me any protection -- but she believed it would. She also said she would consider it a great personal favor to her if I carried it. I assured her that I would keep it with me. I did not wear it on a chain around my neck, but I did indeed have it with me throughout the War.

The entire division went on maneuvers in late summer. The 2nd Army Tennessee Maneuvers were the largest war games ever conducted. We were

---

[14] In the Roman Catholic tradition, St. Christopher is the patron saint of travelers.

divided into the Red Army and the Blue Army. The simulated warfare was preparation for the real thing, of course, and we all sensed that we would be shipped to some combat zone soon. I think that our battalion was in the Red Army, but it really made little difference. I never knew or cared who won. I suppose the generals cared. We felt a little foolish doing some of the things required, not unlike kids playing war and shouting *Bang! You're dead!* Mostly we just tried to stay comfortable. Several of us slept in hammocks. I chose to sleep in a hammock for two reasons: I was afraid of snakes, and I thought that by being elevated I might catch some of the evening breezes. The back country of northern Tennessee is extremely hot and dusty in August. Once we managed to find a country store and bought some cold soft drinks. Another time we came upon a real hill-billy farm that had a well with cool water. The owner's dog was not friendly, and the owner himself eyed us suspiciously. I do not know why he was surly. Dressed in khaki and arriving in a US Army tank, we could hardly be mistaken for bandits or revenue agents. He probably had a still on the property, and to him we represented government authority. Anyway we got our water.

After the August maneuvers, we were given concentrated instructions by means of lectures and training films. Everyone was tested to check his being ready to perform duties in accordance with his assigned Military Occupational Specialty number. Still the training went on. We were given pop quizzes in things like aircraft and vehicle identification. The airplanes and vehicles were shown only in silhouette, just black forms, and we were to identify them quickly. In combat we would have little time to decide *friend or foe!* I did very well in the identification tests, but I never used any of the information. We always knew whose planes were overhead, and it would be pretty hard to mistake an American tank for a German *Panzer!*

Every man who had not had a furlough during the previous six months was given one in late August or early September. We had to be back in camp before September 20 because we were to go overseas shortly thereafter. I was given a two-week furlough in early September. I went directly home without stopping to visit relatives or friends along the way. I did not do anything special while in Minnesota, but even so the time seemed to pass very quickly.

I had to be back on base only a few days before September 17, my twenty-first birthday.

Before leaving Camp Campbell, the division was responsible for repairing the barracks and grounds. The camp was supposed to be in A-Number-1 shape for the next occupants. We scrubbed walls, scoured out grease traps in the kitchen, and painted buildings -- just like spring housecleaning!

Finally the division left Tennessee. We boarded troop trains on a railroad siding of the Louisville and Nashville Railroad.[15] Our destination was Camp Shanks, New York. Upon arrival we were assigned to barracks that could only be regarded as temporary. It was now early October, and the weather was turning cold. Each structure had one pot-bellied stove. My bunk was at one end of the building, and the stove was at the other.

We were instructed to discard or send home anything white. We were then issued the same items in olive drab.[16] We were also encouraged to send home as much of our personal effects as possible. Aside from the usual toiletries, I took good dress uniforms, including low-cut shoes (not boots) and some books. My Prayer Book and New Testament kit supplied by the Armed Forces Commission of the Lutheran Church-Missouri Synod was especially important.

After three days in camp, I was given a pass to go into New York City. Anyone leaving camp was instructed to remove all patches and other division markings, and he was to do no talking about his unit.

Harvey Sabinson invited me to his home in Queens. He and I went into New York by commuter train and transferred to the subway in Grand Central Station. Riding the subway was a new experience for me. Harvey was engaged to Sarah, and she arranged for me to go out with a friend of hers. At the end of the evening, Harvey told me to drive his brother's Willys[17] back from Sarah's

---

[15] I had used the L&N every time I traveled by train. I would take the L&N north to Evansville, Indiana, and transfer to the Pennsylvania to go to St. Louis -- or I could take the L&N through to Chicago if I wanted to go to Minnesota.

[16] When I got married, I still had some GI underwear. The shorts were secured by two khaki shoestring-like ties drawn through eyelets on the side of the waist. In a moment of frivolity, Ruth replaced the ties with pink satin ribbons.

[17] A small car of the Thirties. It was about the size of a Volkswagon 'bug' and a predecessor to the compacts of today.

house to his parents' apartment. I do not remember any details of the evening or where I was in Queens when I was sent packing, but I do remember driving to the Sabinsons' in the dark. I marvel that I found my way without any great trouble.

A New York theater company put on *Porgy and Bess* in the camp theater. Attending the production turned out to be a rare opportunity for us GIs because William Warfield played Porgy. The consensus among critics at the time was that his characterization defined the role.[18] I did not fully appreciate how good the presentation was, but I certainly enjoyed seeing the play!

The 1944 World Series was played during my Port of Embarkation stay. We had a radio in the barracks and listened as much as we could. All the games were day games, and all were played in St. Louis. The lowly St. Louis Browns won in the American League and the St. Louis Cardinals in the National League. Neither team was very good: too many of the players had been drafted into the Armed Forces. The Cardinals won in six games.

There was a lot of letter writing going on in the barracks, and I experienced my first mail censorship. All outgoing mail was read by an officer, and any hint of where we were or where we might be going was carefully removed with a razor blade. We were not even supposed to indicate that we were at an East Coast Port Of Embarkation. I wrote home several times. I had little to say except that I missed everybody. I wondered what my parents suspected. They surely must have known that I was going overseas.

The few days in Camp Shanks ended my Stateside service. My next stop would be someplace in Europe.

---

[18] Paul Robson was another great Porgy.

Preserve my life from fear of the enemy.

... Psalm 64:1, KJV

Chapter III

DESTINATION:
EUROPEAN THEATER OF OPERATIONS

We sailed on the *USS Santa Rosa.* For the superstitious the departure seemed ominous: the date was *Friday,* October *13,* 1944. From Camp Shanks, New York, we went by truck to the ferryboat that would take us to Staten Island. At the dock an Army band played *On Wisconsin, On Brave Old Army Team,* and *The Notre Dame Victory March.* Red Cross ladies dispensed coffee, candy bars, and doughnuts. The *Santa Rosa* had been a South American cruise ship before being pressed into service transporting troops. If anyone expected her accommodations to be posh, he was in for a disappointment, for she had been stripped of her fancy appointments and refitted to accommodate as many men as possible. Our battalion's quarters were deep in the hold and far up in the bow of the ship.[1] In rough seas the bow went up like an express elevator and slammed down just as fast. Our bunks -- really hammocks -- were in tiers of four. I managed to get a bottom bunk. Usually it was very hot in the top bunk, and climbing up to it was always difficult. In addition to his hammock, each soldier was allotted floor space for his duffel bag. A packed duffel bag is about three or four feet long and fifteen to eighteen inches in diameter. Thus each bag used a lot of space, and we were very crowded. We had no fresh water for personal hygiene: we took saltwater showers and shaves, and the water was almost always cold.

Sailing day was cool and clear. After we passed the Statue of Liberty, the call *All military personnel clear the decks!* came over the public address system. I risked being reprimanded by staying on deck until the ship entered the open sea; I wanted to see what the ocean was like. I got seasick, but just this once. I was glad I had risked being caught topside because those below got very seasick.

---

[1] In civilian parlance that means *inside, below deck, in the fore part of the vessel.*

The ships in our convoy assembled soon after leaving New York. A full armored division requires about thirty-five ships. The convoy had a number of destroyers as a protective escort. The German U-boat (submarine) threat had been neutralized by 1944, but we were still glad to have the Navy escort ships with us. We could see the constantly-moving destroyers weaving through the convoy like skiers running a slalom course,[2] and we found them reassuring.

Along with the coffee and doughnuts, the Red Cross gave each GI a kit containing a razor, a toothbrush, a tube of toothpaste, a bar of toilet soap, a candy bar, and a paperback novel. My book was *Forever Amber;* it told the story of Amber St. Claire, mistress of England's Charles II. It was not very steamy by today's standards, but it was considered racy then. Other than reading, the most popular pastime was playing games -- poker, bridge, and craps. I won a little money playing poker. There were a few harmonica players in our section of the hold. They usually played sad and plaintive songs, and sometimes other GIs would sing along. Movies were shown every night in the mess hall.

The division band was on our ship, so in good weather we had band concerts on the open deck. We had a burial at sea. We never learned how the young officer died. We had several boat drills. My lifeboat assignment happened to be close to our deck assembly area.

There was a rumor that one of the ships in the convoy carried a contingent from the Women's Army Corps. Every pair of field glasses was put to use, but no one ever saw a girl. I am almost certain that no ship in the convoy had any WACs aboard and that all the ships carried only combat troops.

During daylight hours most GIs spent as much time as possible on deck. Our convoy sailed a southern route, so the weather was mild. (We did not know where we were, of course, nor did we know where we were going.) I often stood at the rail at night and watched the phosphorescence of the waves.

---

[2] Carl Sealander, a friend of mine at Boeing, served on a destroyer. He said that destroyers were fast and maneuverable and that their motion induced a lot of seasickness for all aboard. Son Tom, as a civilian scientist, went to sea on a destroyer out of Hawaii in 1992. He, too, attested to a destroyer's rough ride.

I found the new phenomenon mesmerizing, quite like a native of equatorial latitudes seeing the Northern Lights for the first time.

We ate meals standing up at counter-like tables. The mess hall had been a balloom when the *Santa Rosa* was a cruise ship. A piano bolted to the floor was a relic of another time. We ate only two meals a day, but we did not mind because the food was so terrible. Breakfast was served for five hours, and the unpleasant smell of powdered eggs permeated the mess hall, the passageways,[3] and even some sleeping quarters. Efficiency foods were not yet well-developed in 1944. Even the soluble coffee[4] was pretty bad. I bought twenty-four bars of candy at the ship's Post Exchange, and they helped sustain me.

Just before our ship entered the Strait of Gibraltar, a pod of porpoises came along side. They acted as if they were performing for spectators -- just like the porpoises and whales in the famous aquaria of Baltimore and Vancouver. Most of the soldiers, myself included, had never seen a porpoise, so the playful and somewhat hammy aquatic mammals enjoyed a large and appreciative audience.

Seeing the Rock of Gibraltar for the first time was very exiting. The African side of the strait was arid and featureless, the city of Tangier gleaming white. The rock was more than a tourist attraction to us, of course: it meant we were going either to France or to Italy.

The Mediterranean was much rougher than the Atlantic had been. Almost all the GIs got seasick. Fortunately I managed to weather the storm without that terrible scourge. The seas were so rough that when the stern rose out of the water, I could see the propellers turning. There was no water to resist them, so they turned very fast and set up an horrendous vibration. I felt as if the ship were going to shake apart.

---

[3] *Passageway* is the nautical term for hall. A ceiling aboard ship is referred to as an *overhead,* a wall as a *bulkhead,* etc.

[4] Nescafe was the only brand then.

After a few days in the Mediterranean, we approached the coast of France. By then we had determined that Marseilles would be our destination. We passed the gray pile of rock of the Chateau d'If.[5] In the distance we could see a huge cathedral, a common feature of French skylines. Very carefully our convoy followed the channel that was marked through the mines. I don't recall seeing any other ships from our division's convoy. Marseilles as a pre-War port could surely have accommodated all the ships of our convoy, but the city had been severely bombed and now offered only limited facilities. Moreover, thirty-five Allied ships in one place would have made a good target for the German *Luftwaffe.*

Barrage balloons were tethered all over the port facilities and parts of the city. Masts and funnels of sunken ships showed above the harbor's waterline. The waterfront warehouses were badly damaged. We soon had our first glimpse of the War's impact on the civilian populace. An apartment building had been hit by a bomb: its outer wall was completely gone, so we could look directly into the units. In one of the apartments, a table teetered on the edge of an exposed floor, and a sink dangled out over empty space.

The *Santa Rosa* docked beside a ship that had been sunk, and our engineers quickly built a passageway through its wreckage. We did not go down a gangplank to reach the receiving dock; instead we went along a path through the tangled equipment on the deck of the sunken ship. Because the deck was not level, walking while carrying a duffel bag and whatever other gear each of us had was precarious. Also, staggering across that tilted deck induced seasickness in many of us, even without the deck's being in motion.[6] Many of the fellows did not know one can become nauseous from taking his eyes off some frame of reference (such as the horizon), and some were embarrassed to find themselves feeling sick on a motionless deck.

---

[5] The prison from which Edmond Dantès, the hero of Alexander Dumas' novel *Count of Monte Crisco,* escaped.

[6] I once experienced seasickness on the tilted deck of a wrecked ship at Ocean Shores.

After docking and disembarking, the *Santa Rosa* passengers began the long march to the staging area. We had been told that the march would be a short one. It turned out to be eight miles long, all of it uphill. On the way we encountered children soliciting anything that they thought they could get. *"Cigarette pour papa,?" "Bon bons?" "Chocolat?"*

Without the War, I might have been fascinated by the novelty of a foreign city. There were sidewalk cafes, unusual houses, the ever-present *pissoirs* (men's toilets), etc. I found it strange to see a man in his fifties, dressed in a business suit and black hat, riding a bicycle with a fishing creel and rod tied to the handle bars.

The Delta Base Bivouac Area near the town of La Malle was our next destination. It was almost dark when we arrived there. An advance party had already put up our tents, so we could get into our quarters immediately.

In contrast to the awful food aboard the *Santa Rosa,* our first food in France was very good. Major William E. Shedd, III, our battalion S-2[7] officer, was fond of pancakes and maple syrup. He brought with him enough bottles of Mapleine extract to last a long time, to make many gallons of imitation maple syrup. The directions were simple: heat white refined sugar and water over low heat and add the extract. The results were not exactly Vermont maple syrup, but what the heck?! We didn't have a Larry's Market[8] handy. Our mess sergeant obliged us and the major by serving pancakes and maple(ine) syrup the very next morning.

Major Shedd learned of the birth of his first child, a boy, during our stay at the staging area. He was told that the little fellow's first step would have to be on his left foot because in military drill a soldier always steps off on his left foot.

---

[7] Intelligence.

[8] Larry's is a chain of gourmet grocery stores in the Seattle area.

That day we had our first fresh-water showers since leaving Camp Shanks. The shower room was a portable affair rigged up in a large tent -- much like the showers in M*A*S*H. A shower was a real luxury!

Our toilet facilities seemed strange to us, to say the least. They were built by local laborers and were not unusual by French standards. The accommodations were nothing more than a row of outhouses without walls, right out in the open. The row of box-like things was placed in a line beside a path used by the local citizenry. A friend of mine told me that during his first use of the open-air latrine, a middle-aged lady appeared on the path and tried to engage him in conversation. He said he was so embarrassed that all he could do was look at his shoes and mumble. Thus informed, I managed to find ways to avoid similar incidents. *Forewarned is forearmed!*

The equipment for the division arrived in bits and pieces. When our tank was delivered, we had to make it combat-ready. The guns, including the tank's main 105mm howitzer, were protected from the elements with a coat of something called *Cosmoline.* Even the gun barrels were filled with it. Cosmoline is the messiest, greasiest gunk I have ever come across, and removing it was a dirty, tiring job.

After all the preparation, each tank was supposed to proceed to a designated area for weapon testing. (In the States we would have called the place a *firing range,* and great care would have been taken to keep people away. In France it was just a space civilians had vacated -- at least we hoped they had!) The route to our test firing area went through the lovely town of Aix-en-Provence. Unlike Marseilles, which was bustling and dirty, Aix-en-Provence was southern France at its most charming. The town center with a stone fountain and cobblestone street was very pretty. It was autumn and cool, but even so old men sat around outside and talked politics or commented on the arrival of more American troops. Unfortunately there was also a grimness about the place. Someone who collaborated with the Nazis had been hanged in the town square shortly before our arrival. Though we did not witness the incident, we were

told that the people sat at sidewalk cafes and watched the body slowly twisting in the breeze.

After a week in the staging area, each tank crew took its tank to a railroad siding near Septemes, a nearby village, where we loaded the tanks onto flatcars. Driving one tank or half-track onto a flatcar does not take long, but all the vehicles were to be loaded before any train could leave. Though somewhat restricted during this period, we did manage to spend time in both Septemes and in Marseilles.

It was in a small Septemes cafe that I had my first *vin ordinaire* or cheap table wine. It wasn't to be my last! The barkeep complimented me on my French pronunciation. Very likely he was only trying to be nice, or perhaps he considered it advantageous to flatter any soldier in his bar, no matter what his uniform. My only French came from a Berlitz book I studied during the long Atlantic crossing.

One day four of us went into Marseilles. We hopped a very crowded streetcar; some passengers even hung onto the outside of the car. We could not buy anything, but we found the sights interesting. American Military Police were all over. Two of us were content to stay out of trouble, but Eddie B---, our driver, and Ray 'Shorty' F---, the driver of another tank -- both married men -- wanted to find the red light district. If the MPs caught a GI patronizing a house of ill repute, the GI was arrested and subject to summary court martial. Besides not actually wanting to go into a 'house,' I was scared to death of being found anywhere in the neighborhood of one. The four of us had to stick together to get back to Septemes, so Carl Phillips and I agreed to wait in a bar across the street -- actually an alley. Before we left, we went as far as the front door of the 'establishment' so that Eddie and Shorty could consult with the madam and confirm that there were indeed girls available. All I could see was a smoky, dimly-lit room, and yes, it was done in red. Pretty unimpressive! Carl and I were extremely nervous while waiting. Eventually the other two rejoined us, and we left the alley without MP notice. So much for Marseilles! I did not visit a single cathedral or museum -- but I did see the inside of a French whorehouse.

The crews were split up when the time came for our railway trip up the Rhone Valley. Two men from each crew were assigned to accompany their crew's vehicle on the flatcar. Carl and Eddie, our gunner and driver, were assigned to go with our tank. Theirs was a lousy deal. It was much colder riding outside with the vehicles than it was traveling inside the boxcars, and those on the noisy flatcars were much more lonesome than the rest of us, who could talk to each other.

Our short stay on the railroad siding near Septemes marked the end of our easy duty in France. From then on, until the end of the War, we were always conscious of enemy presence and the nearness of battle.

Chapter IV

Alsace

The corner of eastern France known as Alsace was very important for both the Allied and the Axis forces in 1944 and 1945. The Germans' attempt to break through the Allied lines in the Ardennes, known as the Battle of the Bulge, had failed. The German High Command then made the decision to try a breakthrough via the Wissembourg Gap in Alsace. The Germans called the second offensive action *Nordwind.*

The Allies had to counter the German offensive and protect Strasbourg, a city known as the *Jewel of Alsace.* Strasbourg had been won by the Allies, and to abandon her would have meant terrible reprisals on the civilian population. French General Charles de Gaulle convinced General Dwight D. Eisenhower, Supreme Commander of the Allied Forces, that the city had to be protected.

So for both strategic and political reasons, the campaign in Alsace took on great importance. Moreover, Alsace has always been a controversial piece of ground, lying as it does on the borders of two neighboring powers, France and Germany.

The 14th Armored Division landed at Marseilles in October, 1944, and proceeded up the Rhone Valley towards the western foothills of the Vosges Mountains. Elements of the Seventh Army had already made the march during the summer of 1944, so resistance was relatively light when the 14th AD followed in the fall. The troops called the engagement *The Champagne Campaign.* Besides being a facetious or clever label for a troop movement, the name indicated that the Army traveled through the Champagne region of France.

When the 14th AD reached the mountains, conditions changed drastically. Now part of the Seventh Army, the division faced battle conditions seldom -- if ever -- encountered before. The history, the terrain, the weather, and the people all favored the enemy.

Military historians divide the action from the approach to the Vosges Mountains in October, 1944, to the crossing of the Rhine in April, 1945, into two battles -- the battle of the High Vosges and the battle of the Low Vosges.

In times of war, the Vosges Mountains have always been a refuge and a great defensive bastion. They rise dramatically from the Rhine Valley near Belfort to peaks over four thousand feet in elevation. The mountain chain runs parallel to the Rhine and is separated from it by the broad Alsatian plain, which is about thirty miles across and ninety miles long. It descends to its northern terminus near the Lauter River. The southern part is called the High Vosges[1] because it has a greater elevation than the northern section. The northern

[1] Many Germans refer to the southern Vosges as the Hardt Mountains.

part, though not quite so elevated as the southern, is more rugged and difficult to traverse.

During the dim pre-history of Alsace (several hundred years B.C.), an unidentified Celtic people who inhabited the Vosges constructed a wall three meters high and ten kilometers long around the mountain peak Fliehburg, which is near the modern town of Obernai. Known as the *Heidenmauer*,[2] it is one of the earliest-known fortifications in the Vosges Mountains. The Vosges cordillera has been regarded as nearly impenetrable ever since.

In medieval times the Vosges became an barrier between empires. In 843, the Treaty of Verdun divided the Frankish Empire among the three sons of Charlemagne -- Louis the German, Charles the Bold, and Lothair. Louis the German took the lands to the east, Charles the Bold the lands to the west. Lothair's portion lay in between and included the Vosges and all of modern-day Alsace and Lorraine. As with many 'middle' lands throughout history, Lotharingia (from which *Lorraine* is derived) became a battleground for the armies of subsequent neighboring rulers. The Vosges region was never crossed by force of arms during the medieval period. By 925 the Vosges region and all of Alsace and Lorraine had become part of the German duchy of Swabia and were thus integrated into the Holy Roman Empire.

The politics of the time were very complicated. Alsace was far away from the Houses of Hohenstaufen and Hapsburg, the main seats of power. To the Hohenstaufens and Hapsburgs, Alsace seemed a distant border region, and they paid scant attention to it. There were frequent conflicts between local landowners, however, but no outsider ever conquered Alsace -- much less crossed the Vosges.

The Peasants' War of 1524-25 added several pages to the chronicles of armed conflict in the Vosges. A religious war in its inception, the Peasants' War became a political and social conflict as well. The Reformation in Saxony[3] fueled the flame of religious dissent among the Alsatian peasants, and the craggy contour of the mountains carved the region into a strange mosaic of Lutheran, Calvinist, and Roman Catholic enclaves, which were often separated by only a single ridge or valley. The region remained a bloody battleground for the forces of religious reaction for many years.

Throughout the Middle Ages, the ruling parties of the area built mountain fortresses similar to the castles along the Rhine. These fortresses effectively blocked east-west passage through the mountains except by permission of their inhabitants, and there was also no easy transit from west to east, from France into the lands of the Holy Roman Empire.

---

[2] *Heidenmauer* means heathen wall. It was named for its pre-Christian origins. The site became a shrine to St. Odilia, patron saint of Alsace.

[3] Martin Luther nailed his 95 theses to the door of the castle church in Wittenberg in 1517. The incident is considered the beginning of the Reformation.

For almost seven centuries Alsace remained under German domination. With the Peace of Westphalia, which ended the Thirty Years' War in 1648, Alsace became French. Alsace actually became part of France with the Treaty of Ryswick in 1697. Louis XIV, then ruler of France, had his military engineers restore and improve the mountain fortifications of this border region.[4] From the end his reign in 1715 until the time of the French Revolution, Alsace enjoyed a long period of peace. During the Revolution and the Napoleonic Wars, Alsace provided France with some of her bravest and best soldiers. After German domination for so long, the people continued to speak German, much to the consternation of the French. Napoleon once said of the Alsatians, "Let them speak German so long as they fight in French."

Following the Napoleonic Wars, the next conflict involving Alsace and the Vosges Mountains was the Franco-Prussian War in 1870-71. The Vosges continued to be impenetrable. The French strengthened their fortresses, and the attacking Germans wisely chose to avoid the mountains and their fortifications and drove into France farther north. Both Alsace and Lorraine were ceded to the Germans after 1871.

Although some fighting took place in the Vosges mountains during World War I, the region was spared much bloodshed because neither side seriously tried to force its way through the passes. However, the relatively static nature of trench warfare in the rest of France spread into Alsace.

Alsace and Lorraine reverted to the French at the end of World War I. Not long after the Treaty of Versailles, the French government decided to take strong defensive measures to insure that the provinces of Alsace and Lorraine would remain part of France. In the 1930s under the leadership of André Maginot, an Alsatian-born World War I veteran and war minister, France embarked on the most ambitious project of permanent fortification in modern times.

The Maginot Line was a series of state-of-the-art emplacements that included underground living quarters, a hospital, supply arsenals, etc. This system guarded the Franco-German frontier for 192 miles, beginning at the Swiss border and running north along the west bank of the Rhine. Just north of Strasbourg it veered northwest toward Hatten. (Mark the name!) It then went on through Alsace and passed the northern end of the Vosges. The heavy fortifications continued past the mountains, and an irregular series of lighter pill-box defensive works ran all the way to the English Channel.

In World War II, the Vosges terrain favored the German defensive forces. Gen. Eisenhower's broad front strategy gave the Seventh Army the task of crossing the entire Vosges chain, not just the Low Vosges. This unprecedented feat would have to be followed by a penetration of the formidable German-held Maginot fortifications and a Rhine River crossing, all in the worst of winter. The Vosges mountain vegetation compounded the American's difficulties

---

[4] In 1985, Ruth and I stayed at an inn in Obernai that had been the quarters for the region's Governeur-General, Louis' representative in Alsace.

because the coniferous evergreens offered concealment to enemy gun emplacements and snipers.

Even communication favored the Germans, who used amplitude modulation radios. American soldiers used frequency modulation radios, which were line-of-sight devices with limited range.

In closing, a word about the Alsatian people in 1945 --

The Alsatian people lived under different flags over the centuries, so one never knew where an Alsatian's allegiance lay. Most Alsatians seemed cooperative, but their demeanor varied. Sometimes they would be animated and pleasant, and at other times they seemed taciturn and impassive -- but always they were enigmatic.

Chapter V

The High Vosges Mountain Campaign

November, 1944

In the summer of 1944, the Allied troops landed on the Normandy beaches and fought their way toward Belgium, Luxembourg, and eastern France. Other Allied troops, mostly American Army units, landed in southern France and moved up the Rhone Valley. The two forces met and held a continuous line from the Alps to the North Sea. The southern end of the Allied line was held by elements of the VI Corps, which included the Seventh Army. One of the divisions of the Seventh Army was the 14th Armored Division.

The German West Wall lay ahead and barred the way into the German Fatherland. The West Wall was made up of the Rhine River and, west of the river, the Siegfried Line. The Siegfried Line consisted of pillboxes, concrete bunkers with machine guns and cannons. Rows of dragon's teeth, cement structures built on bases about four feet square and four feet high, were further deterrents to invading Germany. The Siegfried Line faced the Maginot Line along the French frontier and continued northward along the Belgian-German and Dutch-German borders. The Maginot Line, built as a French defense but held by the Germans in 1944, was a chain of underground fortifications and ground-level gun ports.

East of the Vosges Mountains and just north of the Swiss border was the Colmar Pocket. The Germans were entrenched there and had a clear path to the northeast, should they want to escape to the West Wall.

The mission of the 14th AD was to cross the Vosges Mountains and cut off any German units moving northeast towards the Maginot Line.

The 25th Tank Battalion was part of Combat Command A. The combat command's assignment was to move into the Vosges Mountains on two nearly parallel roads. The Germans occupied fortified positions in the Vosges, and the terrain gave them a decided advantage. The movement of armor through mountainous country had never been attempted in modern warfare because it was considered too hazardous.

Selected elements of the 25th Tank Battalion were split off from the main body at several junctures. The Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon was given the mission of reconnoitering (surveying) routes to St. Die. A company of tanks was sent to protect the flank of Battalion Trains, the unit of trucks that carried personal duffel bags, extra supplies, etc. A platoon of tanks from D Company was dispersed to provide security for a part of Division Trains.

On the second day of travel into the mountains, the mission was changed, and the 14th AD was transferred from VI Corps to XV Corps. The new mission was to capture the town of Barenbach. The I and R Platoon took off immediately on reconnaissance. Their mission was to find the best route to the town.

During much of the march through the mountains, the 14th AD shared the roads with the 3rd and 103rd Infantry Divisions. Those divisions had road priority, so movement was slow and sometimes frustrating. Idle division vehicles were like sitting ducks for enemy snipers and anti-tank weapons.

At St. Quiren, the head of the column encountered a roadblock. A roadblock in the mountains was especially troublesome because there were no alternate roads for detour. With no choice but to blast through the block, the column, after still another encounter with the enemy, continued on its way.

Thanksgiving fell on November 23 in 1944. The troops fighting through the mountains had C rations for their Thanksgiving dinner.

While the 14th AD was fighting its way through the mountains, the French 1st Armored Division struck north and captured Strasbourg. The taking of Strasbourg was important to French morale. With this fortuitous turn of events, the Allied High Command considered turning Combat Command A loose and having it head straight for the Rhine. The element of risk was too great, however, and an alternate plan had to be devised.

On Friday, November 25, the 25th Tank Battalion arrived at Le Donon on the eastern side of the Vosges. At nearby Schirmeck, all units of the 25th rejoined the main body, and the battalion was off on its own. The column wound down the foothills of the mountains onto the Alsatian plain.

On Monday, November 27, CCA turned south and headed for its immediate objective -- to seize and hold a fifteen-mile line running roughly north and south, four miles from the Rhine and parallel to it. The line of battle was in three columns, the westernmost led by the 25th Tank Battalion.

The western column moved out before dawn. The day was clear, and the sunrise out of Germany was pink. A reconnaissance platoon of armored cars and Jeeps led the column.

As the column entered the town of Obernai, the Recon Platoon learned that the enemy was in Goxwiller, the next village.

Several tanks had to destroy a roadblock at the outskirts of Goxwiller while under heavy machine-gun and mortar fire.

Gertwiller was the next village on the march south. Elements of the supporting 500th Field Artillery fired on that village to cut off the retreating Germans.

A few hundred yards before entering Gertwiller, the lead vehicles encountered another roadblock, this one covered by machine guns. The 76mm guns of the lead tanks could not reduce the obstacle, so the Assault Gun Platoon with its 105mm howitzers was called upon to do the job.

The infantrymen dismounted and moved slowly and cautiously into Gertwiller. They continued down the main street until they reached the far end of the town. Except for intermittent artillery and mortar fire, they met little resistance from the Germans.

Night was falling, but still the tank column continued into town, each tank firing as it went. A blown bridge over a canal barred the way, and an alternate route, suggested by the mayor, proved to be a trap. A camouflaged German 88mm anti-tank gun fired at the lead tanks at almost point-blank range.

After the gun was silenced, no resistance was encountered by the remaining tanks in their one- or two-block movement down to the canal. Engineers from the 125th Engineer Battalion erected a foot bridge while under fire so the tank crew members could escape.

Soon all of Gertwiller erupted into flame. Infantrymen from B-62 ran from house to house, tossing grenades through windows and doors as they went. Tanks roared incessantly. The Germans, hiding in houses and cellars, waited for an opportune time to come out. Enemy snipers fired from second story windows.

After an hour or two, the furious action stopped, and the town became eerily quiet. Lieutenant Morris Wax of the 25th's Service Company began to direct his supply trucks into town. The tanks were low on both gas and ammunition. The Battalion Command Post was set up in a tavern on the main street of town.

Lieutenant Lloyd Sexton, battalion surgeon, set up an aid station in the cellar of an Obernai house, but he had to move to larger quarters in the town schoolhouse because the number of casualties became too large for him to handle in the cellar.

The quiet was only temporary. At 3:30 A.M. on November 27, the Germans began their counter-attack with a huge artillery barrage. German infantry had infiltrated the outposts around the town.

One soldier related how he learned of their presence. He went out into the street to fetch a gas can and drew machine-gun fire from a direction he thought to be occupied by his own troops.

After some furious street fighting, the Americans were ordered to withdraw.

The infantrymen of B-62 found that withdrawal was more easily ordered than accomplished. Germans were everywhere. Prone men would wait for a burp gun to stop and then rise and shoot in the direction from which the muzzle flashes came.

Ammunition handlers crawled into town with ammo and helped medics evacuate the wounded on their return.

The men of the 1st Infantry Platoon of B-62 were pinned down and faced annihilation. The last order they received was *Hold at all costs!* The daring and heroic action of one man saved them. His name was Kenesaw Goheen. For his bravery he received the Distinguished Service Cross.

Private Goheen was a rifleman in the 1st Platoon, the platoon to be hit first by the Germans in their counter-attack. During the night Goheen took it upon himself to knock out the German machine gun emplacement that was keeping his platoon pinned down. Without asking any questions, he emerged from the relative safety of his secured position and advanced toward the gun. The

Germans spotted him and fired at him with all they had. He crawled through a continuous shower of heavy machine gun, burp gun, and rifle fire as bullets kicked up dirt all around him. He crawled on, and eventually he knocked out the machine gun nest with a hand grenade.

Goheen was not even touched. His grenade killed two of the Germans, and he took the third one prisoner. Goheen made the prisoner crawl back to his platoon ahead of him.

Then another machine gun began to fire at the 1st Platoon, and again Goheen crawled toward it. On his way, he encountered a man from the anti-tank platoon who was wounded and in great pain. Goheen half carried, half dragged him back through heavy fire. According to the 62nd Battalion surgeon, Goheen saved the man's life.

Later that night, Goheen worked his way through more heavy fire to get ammunition. He returned just as the platoon was about to run out of ammo.

The next morning, November 28, Goheen learned that the 1st Platoon was completely cut off. Three messengers had returned after trying to get through to the isolated platoon, but murderous enemy fire prevented their accomplishing the mission. Goheen and a lieutenant from his platoon volunteered to go. They had to cross open terrain, and the enemy had a clear field of fire. They crawled, ran, dodged -- whatever -- to get through, and they made it without a scratch. Then they led the 1st Platoon out of the town.

Among the Americans left in the town were some men of the 25th Tank Battalion. They got out about the same time as the 1st Platoon of B-62. The battalion commander of the 25th left his Command Post and made it out of town in the early dawn. The last men of the 25th to leave were the stragglers from the AG platoon. They had to fend for themselves.

After renewed attacks and more bitter fighting, all elements of the 14th AD escaped. The mortar platoon from the 25th continued to shell Gertwiller from a position north of town. Men from the 25th Tank, the 125th Engineers, the 94th Cavalry, and the 62nd Infantry set up a defensive position in Goxwiller. The infantry dug in, and the armored vehicles set up tactical positions with their hulls hidden by terrain. The defensive preparations were unnecessary. The attack never came.

The 25th then renewed its attack on Gertwiller. Captain John J. Scanlon, battalion intelligence officer, and Lieutenant John W. Day of the I and R Platoon succeeded in getting into town in a Jeep. They found some wounded men from B-62 and helped them to the rear.

In the ensuing action, several tanks were knocked out, and the 25th pulled back in order to concentrate artillery fire on the town. After an extremely heavy barrage, the 25th again moved into Gertwiller. The 125th erected a bridge over the canal, and finally the town was declared clear of the enemy.

Having broken out onto the broad Alsatian plain, the 14th AD and attached units turned to the northeast. The general movement was west of Strasbourg, toward the corner of Alsace where the Lauter and Rhine Rivers meet.

Chapter VI

BAPTISM OF FIRE

After loading the tanks and half-tracks onto flatcars, the crews -- except for the men assigned to ride on the flatcars with the vehicles -- boarded the unheated train, but we were comfortable enough anyway. We had warm clothing and sleeping bags. We prepared our meals over portable Coleman burners. The train made some bathroom stops, but not enough. We never knew when the French engineer would start moving after a stop, so some guys got left behind. A backup train picked up stragglers.

We first saw evidence of combat on the trip up the Rhone Valley. We had seen bombed warehouses, docks, even homes and businesses -- but no actual battlefields. Grim reminders of what had happened were burned-out tanks and dead horses. No modern army had mounted cavalry, but the Germans still used horses as draft animals to pull artillery pieces and supply wagons. The burned-out tanks had a sobering effect on everyone.

The 14th Armored Division, part of the Seventh Army commanded by General Alexander M. Patch, Jr., was to join the Seventh Army in the Vosges Mountains of Alsace. The name *Alsace* or *Alsace-Lorraine* rang a bell with me and probably for every GI who remembered his high school history lessons. In those almost-forgotten classes we learned that the region along the west bank of the Rhine immediately north of Switzerland had been contested in many wars and that the region flew the flag of its most recent conqueror. Now I was to become a part of Alsatian history: it would be for my fellow soldiers and me to change the flag of Alsace from a German Swastika to the French Tri-Color.

After three days' travel in the *40 et 8* cars, we arrived in Charmes, a small town near Epinal and Dijon.[1] It was rainy and cold. We spent a miserable first night in the field. We made our tarp into a half-tent. As the rain came down outside, the water came up under our tarp, and our sleeping bags got wet. We all

[1] Dijon is famous for its mustard.

caught colds, and several of the guys had the GIs.[2] Because the fields were so wet, we had to build corduroy roads with logs cut from the local forests. Officials from the French villages or townships counted every log and submitted a bill of damages to the Army. One GI expressed his reaction with the expletive *The gall of some Gauls!!* -- or to put it another way, *That's some Gallic gall!* We were annoyed with the French officials, of course, but even so we took delight in the alliterative expressions of disdain.

The 14th AD became part of VI Corps, Seventh Army, which was fighting its way through the Vosges Mountains.[3] Some of its peaks are over four thousand feet high. The roads were typical mountain roads of that time:[4] they were narrow with steep cliffs rising on one side and deep ravines plunging away on the other. We were afraid they might crumble under the weight of our heavy equipment. The terrain favored defense, and the Germans used their advantage well. The woods were full of their snipers and fortified dug-in gun emplacements.

Somewhere along the way, a tank from A Company hit a mine. Several of the crew members were injured, and the tank was immobilized. The column that followed was held up while Service Company retrieved the tank. It could have been pushed over the side into the canyon, but Service Company chose to salvage it.

Another time one of our tanks hit a mine, and the results were grim. The tank commander, an officer, became a mental case and was sent back to the States. Previously he had been one of a small group who shot and killed some enemy prisoners. The happening, terrible in itself, actually endangered everyone in his division -- perhaps in the entire Seventh Army -- for if the Germans learned of the incident and could identify the killer's unit, they would mete out similar treatment to anyone they captured. (As noted previously, we removed our

---

[2] An Army euphemism for diarrhea.

[3] Fighting with armor in the mountains was not common because it was considered too difficult. Hannibal crossed the Alps with forty elephants already in the third century B.C., but in modern warfare mountain fighting is generally avoided.

[4] Ruth and I drove through the same mountains in 1985. By then the road had been replaced by a multi-lane toll expressway.

division shoulder patches before embarking in New York, but the enemy had other ways of determining what unit he faced.)

The weather turned cold in the mountains. I wore my combat suit all the time, even while sleeping. A tanker combat suit had a heavy wool bib-overall, jacket, and helmet. We stayed with our tanks day and night. Carl Phillips and I slept on the floor of the turret; the other three members of the crew slept on the back deck over the engine compartment. They would crawl into their sleeping bags and pull the canvas tarp over all of the bags. They stayed dry, and the engine compartment was always warm for the first part of the night if the tank had been run recently. We kept this sleeping arrangement throughout the time we stayed together.

Mostly we ate individual C and K rations. Each C or K ration provided a meal for one soldier. When we had more time for food preparation, we used five-in-one or ten-in-one rations. These rations provided meals for five or ten soldiers, and they allowed much more variety. We had a small one-burner Coleman stove. We always tried to scrounge a few onions from a local family. We would slice the onions and throw them in with whatever we were cooking at the time. The onions added a lot of flavor and made Army rations much more palatable.

The first of many stops was in the mountain village of Cirey. I knocked on the door of a house next to our tank just to be able to go indoors and get warmed up. My German was much better then than it is now, so I could communicate with the people who lived there. They had some potatoes on the stove and offered us some. We accepted and gave them several packages of cigarettes in return. Cigarettes, sugar, and coffee were in great demand and a common means of barter.

We finally got through the mountains and out onto the broad Alsatian plain. In Obernai I went into a bakery and bought some pumpernickel. We had no local currency, so I don't know what I used for money. Perhaps I traded with cigarettes again. The coarse dark bread was a change from the field rations we had been living on, and besides, it was very good pumpernickel. Some of our crew had never eaten bread that heavy and crusty, so not everyone liked it.

We learned by experience, common sense, or having been told that church steeples make very good observation posts for enemy artillery forward observers. In Obernai, we fired on both the highest church steeple and the tower of the town hall.[5]

Some Obernai townspeople warned the Reconnaissance Squadron of the 94th Cavalry Battalion[6] that there were Germans in Goxwiller, a town directly in our line of march. The Germans had built a roadblock at the edge of Goxwiller and covered it with machine gun emplacements. A platoon of tanks from A Company blew up the roadblock and the machine guns. Our platoon, the Assault Gun Platoon, was about a block behind the point, *i.e.* the lead vehicle.[7] The column proceeded toward Gertwiller, the next town, but it was stopped by another roadblock about a quarter mile from the town's edge. The 76mm guns of the line company tanks could not remove the roadblock, and the tanks were under heavy mortar and machine gun fire. Our AG Platoon had 105mm cannons, so we were called upon to do the job. We were also under heavy fire, but because of our gunner's expert marksmanship and our commander's coolness under fire, we managed to remove the roadblock.

Following that short action, Lieutenant John R. Martin, our platoon leader, got into our tank; his being in the turret made it extremely crowded. Sergeant John Donges, the commander of our tank, was a short stocky man, who in spite of his ample girth managed to crouch behind Carl's seat. Having finished the job of blowing up the roadblock, we proceeded with the lead vehicles into Gertwiller.[8] Had it not been for our blowing up the Gertwiller roadblock, I would likely not have been involved in the action that followed.

---

[5] Both towers had been nicely restored by the time I saw them again in 1985.

[6] My friend Harvey Sabinson, who was in the 94th Cavalry, was not in the area at the time.

[7] The point can be any vehicle -- tank, half-track, armored car, Jeep, whatever. For some, including me, riding point created almost unbearable tension that produced cold sweaty palms as nothing else can. The apprehension was worse than the fighting itself. You and your crew were the most exposed and vulnerable people in your world. Whenever and wherever the enemy decided to attack, you would be the first in line to meet his charge. He might be lying in wait in any woods, over any bridge, around any turn, behind any building. If you were lucky, you might get a warning -- a spit of flame from a dug-in gun replacement -- and you might get away and not be killed. Or you could be lucky and never know what hit you. But always you waited!

Our tank had been moved from a position of relative safety into place with the first tanks in the column. We had 'buttoned up,' *i.e.* closed the hatches used for getting into and out of the tank. (We did not always secure the hatches. If a tank were hit by an artillery shell or if it detonated a land-mine, the pressure change inside the tank could well burst eardrums and/or cause concussions. Closed but unsecured hatches acted like escape valves: the hatches would fly open violently if the tank were hit.) A small port about eight inches by eight inches by the loader's place can be opened and fixed in an open position; the port is intended to be used for disposal of used shell-casings, called *brass.* Because there was no periscope on the loader's (my) side of the turret,[9] I opened the port and took up a viewing position. We were moving slowly enough for any German infantryman to fire into the open port or, if he were daring enough, to rush the tank and jam a hand grenade through the opening. I did not think of those possibilities, and I was lucky that nothing happened.

We could not get through Gertwiller because the Germans has blown the main bridge that made the town accessible. The *Burgermeister*[10] directed our column to an alternate route, which turned out to be a trap. By the time we had negotiated the narrow streets to the other side of town, it was getting dark. Suddenly a camouflaged 88mm[11] anti-tank gun knocked out our lead tank. Lieutenant Jesse Tomey[12] was the tank commander, and I witnessed his trying to escape the burning tank. As he emerged from the hatch, I thought I saw the tracer bullets both enter and leave his body. Perhaps what I saw was a stream

---

[8] In June, 1997, I received a letter from Frederic Bossert in response to an article I wrote for the *Liberator,* the 14th Armored Division's newspaper. Mr. Bossert lives in Canada now, but during the War he lived in Barr, a neighboring town to Gertwiller. He was fourteen years old in 1944. He recalled that a tank commanded by Sergeant Howard Knapp of the 48th Tank Battalion, 14th Armored Division burned in front of his parents' house. Mr. Bossert wanted to know more about the action in the area around his home town. I have been in correspondence with him since our initial contact.

[9] Later models of the M-4 tank had a loader's periscope.

[10] Mayor.

[11] The German 88 was, arguably, the most famous gun of the war. It was originally designed as an anti-aircraft weapon, but the Germans soon learned that it was extremely effective as an anti-tank and anti-personnel weapon as well.

[12] Lieut. Tomey was a well-educated, friendly American Indian, who had to live under the cloud of prejudice. Indians were not allowed to buy liquor, and the only way he could obtain any spirits was through his friends.

of tracers passing *behind* the lieutenant, but the scene is one I shall never forget! Lieut. Tomey and one other member of that tank crew were killed. The second tank was also hit. Two of the crew suffered severe concussions. While still under enemy fire, the other three members of the crew pulled the injured men to safety. The third tank, too, was hit, but all of the crew scrambled to safety.

At the same time, we were maneuvering into a position to fire at the hidden gun. From the sound of the gun and the direction of the tracer bullets, we had some idea of the gun's whereabouts. The German 88 (and later our 76mm and 90mm) had a muzzle brake, which partially hid the flash when the gun was fired. Because of the muzzle brake, we could not determine the gun's position visibly, so we had to rely on sound and guessing. The 88 was in front of us, and the flooded street was behind us. We received no radio-transmitted instructions from any level of command above us, so Sgt. Donges chose to stay and fight. An AG tank carried high explosive rounds, anti-tank rounds, and smoke rounds. We had already used some 105mm ammo to reduce the roadblock that afternoon, so there were about fifty rounds remaining when Sgt. Donges said *Fire everything!* I was the loader, and I had my work cut out for me. I threw rounds into the gun breech so fast that my arms ached. The hot brass was piling up at my feet, but I could not stop to throw it out the port. The gun barrel got very hot, but it continued to fire.

After we had exhausted our ammunition, the 88 and the machine guns were silent. We speculated that our fire put the 88 out of action early in our barrage. If it had not, we would have taken return fire -- but we received none. During the firing, I wondered when our tank would be hit. The prospect of having our tank burst into flames was horrible to contemplate, but we were too busy to dwell on the possibility very much. When our ammunition was expended, Eddie backed the tank to the edge of the flooded street. It was a difficult maneuver and John had to guide him. I crawled out of the tank and took up a position on the back deck, where I manned the 50-caliber machine gun. My job was to watch the darkened windows on both sides of the street. If there were any sign of Germans, I was to use the 50-caliber gun immediately. All these years later I question the wisdom of

such a tactic. It would have been easy for snipers to kill John and me before I could use the machine gun. I was fortunate that the Germans in the houses along that street chose not to reveal their positions just then. The town became deathly quiet, and I did not fire a shot.

When Eddie stopped the tank, everyone got out, each taking his personal effects with him. I untied the tarp covering the sleeping bags on the tank's back deck and kicked the bags onto the ground; each of the crew then grabbed his bag. While under enemy fire, the engineers had thrown up a treadway foot-bridge across the stream, and we hurried to use it. I went back to the tank to render the radio inoperative. (We were certain that the Germans would take our tank, and we did not want them to be able to listen to our radio messages.) The trip was necessary, and I did my job quickly. George Johnson, our bow gunner, also returned to the tank -- but for a more prosaic reason. He wanted to fetch his football! When I asked him later just why he had gone back at such great risk to himself, he replied that the War had to end sometime and he wanted his football for that day. Both George and I got back across the bridge and sought a place under cover. We found the tavern that the battalion commander was using for his Command Post. There were quite a few of us in the taproom. A fire was burning in the fireplace, and we warmed ourselves and prepared to sweat out the night.

Our action of the previous night provided cover for the medics to evacuate the dead and wounded from the tanks that were hit. Not only did we provide cover, but we also silenced the machine gun and the 88. My riding the outside of the tank ready to fire the 50-caliber machine gun further helped the medics get the wounded out. (I do not actually *know* that the threat of machine gun fire intimidated the Germans in the buildings along our path, but something kept them from firing at the medics. Perhaps they realized that the medics were evacuating wounded and honored the Geneva Convention, which allows immunity of wounded combatants -- but I doubt it!)

For our actions, our entire crew was recommended for the Bronze Star. Nothing came of the recommendation immediately, but the medics and the guys in the A Company Platoon who were helped did not forget us.

The night in the tavern was not without incident. A big rangy first sergeant from the B-62 came in, muttering to himself. He informed the assembled company that a German sniper had fired at him and caused him to step into a puddle. He slowly took off his boots and socks, dried them by the open fire, and allowed that as soon as his feet were dry he was going to go out and get the SOB that made him get wet feet. After he had gone outside, we heard just one shot. The sergeant came back in and said quietly, "Got the bastard!" I wondered if he really did.

Sometime around midnight I lay down on a tavern table and went to sleep. Early the next morning, the Germans opened a counter-attack. Enemy artillery and rifle fire increased, and our tavern no longer felt secure. The orders came to withdraw. Just how we were to do that was not told us at that point. We came to learn that the order implied *Every man for himself!* The Germans seemed to be everywhere, and there was a lot of activity in the street outside of the tavern. Our battalion tanks were covering the infantry as the soldiers attempted to get out of town on foot. I should have jumped onto a passing tank and tried to get out the same way, but instead I chose to take my chances and wait until later when there would be daylight. I went back to sleep on the tavern table. When I awoke, it was already light, and I realized that I had probably made a wrong decision!! The battalion commander was leaving with his driver. His Jeep was at the tavern door, and the two of them were going to make a run for it. George and I threw our sleeping bags and musette bags into the back of their Jeep. It was so full of stuff that there was no room for any passengers. They made it out of town just fine.

After they left, only George and I remained in the tavern. I do not know how or when the other members of our crew -- John, Carl, and Eddie -- got away. There was a garden wall about eight feet high on the other side of street. We thought we would be safer on the other side of the wall. I am not sure why we thought that: there was fighting going on all through the town, and the Germans were as likely to be there as anywhere else. George and I decided that I would make a dash for the wall while George covered me. Then I was to cover him while he tried to cross the street. All went well at first, but when George made his dash, halfway through his crossing the cartridge clip fell out

of his submachine gun. When he realized that his ammunition clip had dropped out of his gun, he turned around to retrieve it! First his football and then an ammunition clip! George would not leave anything behind! I shouted to him to forget it, but his instinct took over and he picked up his clip. All the while the Germans were spraying the street with machine-gun fire, and I was returning their fire with my weapon. George made it across the street, and we vaulted the wall one at a time. The other side offered no better protection, unfortunately: there were Germans in the all the houses surrounding the courtyard.

George and I then parted company. I do not know where George went, but he disappeared and I was on my own. I managed to get back to the main street through an alley. Once on the street, I dodged from one doorway to the next. At the entrance to one of the houses, a German hit me with his rifle butt. He was probably out of ammunition so used his rifle as a club. I went down, and someone else shot the German. I was stunned but got up and continued on my way. My head hurt! I began to run. I had to keep watching for snipers in second-story windows on both sides of the street. Some of them were dimly visible in the recesses of the upstairs rooms. After more running and dodging, I caught up with a truck moving so slowly that I could run along side it. It protected me from the left, so I had only to watch for snipers on my right. I noted that no one else used the truck as a shield, and I remember thinking how strange it was that I should be alone. Was I the only one smart enough to use the truck for protection? When I reached the relative safety of the town's outskirts, I hurried forward to the cab; I wanted to thank the driver for the favor he did not know he had rendered. He shouted to me, "Move away from my truck! It's loaded with high explosives! Any stray bullet could blow us both to Kingdom Come!" I got out of the way, but I still thanked him.

Maj. Shedd from Battalion HeadQuarters was the first familiar face I saw. He wanted to know everything that I could tell him about what was going on in Gertwiller. What I knew was limited to my own experience, so I was not much help to him. The next person I met was Eugene 'Pancho' Nieri.[13] He was

a half-track driver who had spent the night in his vehicle with the radio on. He was trying to find out where his buddies were and smoked two packs of cigarettes in the process. I thought he was going to kiss me.

Eventually all the members of our tank crew were accounted for, and we got back together. In the afternoon someone from our field kitchen brought us cold turkey sandwiches, some cranberry relish, pumpkin pie, and coffee. We missed Thanksgiving dinner, but the cooks took care of their own in fine style. That night we slept in a farmer's shed, and the next morning we had a hot breakfast, the first meal served from the field kitchen in a long time.

The second day of fighting in Gertwiller was less fierce than the first, and by late morning our forces had the situation well in hand. The town was not fully cleared of Germans, but barring a concentrated counter-attack we were confident we could go back into the town to recover our tank -- if it were still parked where we left it.

Of course it was not! The Germans had driven it away with their other vehicles. After that I always wondered whether enemy fire might be coming from our old tank! After checking to see if our tank were still in Gertwiller, we set out to pick up another tank from a supply depot somewhere in the rear.

The first night of our trip to the depot, we found ourselves in a mountain town some miles behind the front. It was in a canyon, and our billet for the night was a house on the side of one of the canyon walls. Sound carried very well, and we could hear firing all night. It seemed to be very close, so we did not get much sleep. Several months later the night sounds would not have bothered us, but we were all new to combat and our nerves were still on edge from the events in Gertwiller. We had no tank, so we posted no guard and all went to bed. That was a mistake that could have been disastrous because there were so many Germans in the area. After that, from 8:00 P.M. until 6:00 A.M. -- 2000 hours until 0600 hours in Army talk -- we kept one person standing guard at the tank. Each watch lasted two hours. I liked least the 2:00 A.M. to 4:00 A.M.

---

[13] Ruth and I looked up Pancho while on our honeymoon in 1948. He lived in Palo Alto, California, where he ran a dry-cleaning establishment. I have tried to find him on more recent visits to Palo Alto but without success.

shift, best the one from eight until ten in the evening. We usually drew straws for the order of standing watch.

We picked up our new tank at the supply depot and were told where to go to rejoin the battalion. Each of us had lost some personal gear, which we were able to replace from our company supply. Fortunately, most of our belongings were kept in personal duffel bags which were stored with Battalion Trains; thus our things remained untouched.

The trip back to our company was uneventful. We were alone for the entire time. There were few Americans on the roads, and we did not trust the local populace. We always ate very well: as mealtime approached, we would look for an American Army field kitchen. No matter what the unit, the cooks always fed itinerant GIs.

It took only a few days to get back, and we did have to spend at least one night completely isolated. We didn't know whether or not there might be Germans around, so we had to be very cautious. Sgt. Donges chose a barn in which to stay the first night. There were no other buildings around it. We took the tank right inside the barn and slept in the hay on the second floor. We settled down with the usual guard assignments. The hay was warm and soft, and I was completely dry. Getting up for my two hours of guard duty was hard, but I had a good shift that night. The choice of an isolated building in the middle of an open field was actually a poor one. Any local civilians or German soldiers could surely see us. One incendiary artillery round into the barn would have set it ablaze. Our guardian angels worked hard that night.

We rejoined our platoon and company at St. Pierre on December 2 or 3. The division had been placed in Corps Reserve but was alerted to be ready to move on a half-hour notice. We welcomed the hot meals: for almost two weeks many of the troops had eaten more field rations than kitchen-prepared food.

From St. Pierre the battalion moved north to Riedheim, a village about twenty miles northwest of Strasbourg. There we had a few days' respite. Our tank was brand new, so it needed little day-to-day maintenance. The other tank crews in the platoon had to do some work on their vehicles, and we pitched in to help

wherever we could. Our Service Company welded racks onto the sides of the tanks to hold sand bags. The bags added a measure of protection against the dreaded German 88, but their added weight reduced the top speed. Sometime later, Gen. Patton dressed down a tank commander for using sand bags. In forceful and colorful language, he ordered the sand bags off because they reduced a tank's speed and maneuverability and gave the impression of cowardice. I do not know how the Germans could capitalize on sand bags, but Patton thought they were sending the wrong message. Our thought was *Better a slow live coward than a fast dead hero!* The bags came off.

We had to sleep in the open or in tanks during our first weeks in combat, and we soon learned that our sleeping bags were not warm enough to keep us comfortable. We improved them by stuffing them with German Army blankets. Although they were not wool,[14] they added warmth. We came across a lot of abandoned German equipment, so finding extra blankets was not difficult. I was always reluctant to use them because of what might happen if I were captured and had German equipment among my personal effects. I tried to get another US Army blanket from supply but was told that I had all the equipment that I was entitled to. Eventually I solved the problem by taking some Army blankets from a burned-out American tank. (Their owners had been killed.) I gave my German blankets to a farmer, who was very happy to have them.

Whenever we stopped for the night in a village, we sought indoor lodging unless we thought we would be safer close to our tank. The usual approach was to find a likely looking house, knock, and ask *Haben Sie ein Zimmer für fünf Soldaten?* (Have you a room for five soldiers?). We were never turned away. Put yourself in the place of an Alsatian villager. Would you refuse five armed foreigners knocking at your door?

The homes were very much the same -- a half-timbered, functional farm house and farm buildings surrounding a barnyard. The barnyard had a manure pile, which would be used for fertilizer the following spring. We often noted that if we had to be in rural Alsace at all, we were glad our time came in the winter.

---

[14] Synthetics such as dacron, which is frequently used to fill sleeping bags now, were not yet developed in 1944.

One of the buildings usually contained a potato distillery. At one of our village stops, I witnessed a farmer test his Schnapps. He drained about a half a cup from the spigot at the bottom of the still and poured it over the domed top. Then he touched a lighted match to the dome. If the liquid burned, he considered the batch finished. I think alcohol burns at about 100 proof. We had ample opportunity to test the strength of home-made Alsatian Schnapps.

Because our battalion was in the same place for a few days, we had hot meals. The mess kitchen was in the back of a truck, and another truck carried the mess sergeant and the cooks. Our kitchen staff was very good, and the meals they served during our brief stay in Riedheim were most welcome. The cooks did some interesting things apart from preparing food -- like distilling their own spirits. They tried grapefruit juice, but it did not work. After using several kinds of dried fruit, they finally got something to ferment: their batch of raisin jack really took off! I never got to taste it; it was consumed before I had a chance.

Riedhiem was typical of the villages in Alsace, but the house in which we were billeted had a special distinction. The farmer owned a bull for breeding. The first morning we were there, several neighboring farmers brought their cows to be serviced. The word got out, and soon the breeding stall had GIs lining the fence to watch the procedure. I am not sure what vicarious sex kick they *(we* -- for I was there, too!) got out of watching, but it was a diversion.

During the few days of respite from the fighting, we were all given Post Exchange rations. Each daily ration contained a pack of cigarettes, a small Hershey bar, and a package of gum. PX rations were extra and available only about once a month. The PX truck stopped at each unit, and we could buy a certain number of cans of beer or pop -- probably a six-pack -- and other things, but the beer and soft drinks were always the favorites.

An Army dentist visited our outfit as part of his regular rounds. I had a small cavity and elected to have him fill it. The equipment was primitive. The chair was a simple metal one. The drill was run by a maze of wires and pulleys powered by a foot treadle, much the way my mother's sewing machine was operated. An assistant, the dentist's driver, manned the treadle. The speed of

the drill depended on how fast he ran it. He must have been tired or he was having a bad day when I was in the chair because he did not make the drill go very fast. My cavity was small, so the dentist decided not to use Novocain. A slow drill hurts.

On December 9, the battalion was put on forty-five minute alert. We knew that we were going on the attack soon, and we became ever more grim and sober. Our stay at Riedheim was about to end, and we were going into engagements that later became known as the Battle of the Lower Vosges Mountains.

Chapter VII

Into Germany -- and Back

In December, 1944, the 14th Armored Division entered Germany for the first time. GIs in the line knew nothing about grand strategy or even local tactics, so we were unaware of our goal from one attack to the next. We left the relative comfort of Riedheim and once again had to live in the open or in the tanks. The immediate objective for our battalion was Wissembourg, a beautiful city on the German-French border.

Early in the month, the division was deployed along a southeast-northwest line, the southeastern end of which began just north and west of Strasbourg. The line was about eighty miles long, much too long a front for one division to cover. Those units of the division that were to move toward the German frontier had to regroup for the attack to the northeast. The division moved in several parallel columns. Our battalion was divided into two columns. Our tank went with the eastern column. The western column supposedly had the more difficult route, but both columns encountered stiff enemy resistance. Our eastern group was to advance to the German border along the Lauter River because Wissembourg is on the Lauter.

We moved out on December 13. Our tank was far back in the column. The light tank platoon of Lieutenant Paul M. 'Smiley' Klinefelter was the first unit in the line of march. 'Smiley' himself rode the point vehicle. Light tanks are smaller and have thinner skin (armor) than the M-4 Sherman medium tanks, but they have greater maneuverability and speed than the mediums -- not necessarily a comforting thought when riding the point. The weather was gray and overcast. We moved through Hagenau and then the Hagenau Forest. The woods were dark and forbidding, and mist hung in the trees. We expected to draw some 88mm fire while going through the woods, but the Germans did not shoot. We suspected a trap.

The division had been in France only a few months, but we had all learned to be cautious. Those of us in the tanks had our own special fears. German tanks or dug-in anti-tank pieces were always a fearsome threat to us, especially when we had to move through dense cover. Any time of low visibility, the German

infantryman was as threatening as a *Panzer.* It seemed strange that a single foot soldier armed with a *Panzerfaust* or Molotov cocktail[1] could create so much havoc for our big tanks. Five trained and alert American soldiers -- each with his own weapon, moving in a 32-ton armored vehicle powered by a 500-horsepower engine capable of driving it to speeds up to fifty-five miles an hour, armed with a cannon and three machine guns -- should have been more than a match for a single enemy soldier. But such was not always the case! Obviously we had great respect for the German infantry!

We arrived in Surbourg without incident, and the next day we went through the neighboring town of Soultz, where we first saw Maginot Line fortifications.[2] When I saw the gun emplacements, I expected a massive artillery bombardment, but there was none. Our division, however, was engaged in fierce fighting not long after leaving the Maginot Line. Even then, our Assault Gun Platoon was used as artillery, so we were not in direct contact with the enemy. From Soultz we moved northeast toward Seebach. On the way, our lead tank encountered a blown bridge. The engineers quickly put up a temporary bridge, and we were back on track very soon. We spent the night near a railroad station, which served as a Battalion Command Post. The next day we proceeded through Seebach. Lieut. Klinefelter's tank was hit while rounding a curve approaching a railroad bridge. The tank burst into flames, and almost immediately the second tank was hit. Sergeant Bill Winslow of our Assault Gun Platoon was called upon to fire where he had seen flashes and where he thought the 88 might be.[3] In response to the Winslow tank's barrage,

---

[1] A *Panzerfaust* was the German version of our bazooka. Its charge burned its way through thick armor and then exploded inside of its target, presumably a tank. A Molotov cocktail was a simple bottle of gasoline with a rag wick. The wick was lighted and the whole thing thrown onto the target. When the bottle broke, releasing the gasoline, the 'cocktail' acted like an incendiary bomb. Germans frequently tossed Molotov cocktails on the rear deck of a tank so that the gasoline would run down into the engine compartment and blow up the whole engine.

[2] Ruth and I stopped at the same Maginot Line fortification in 1985. There a North Atlantic Treaty Organization officer acted as our guide. He had served in the German Army during the War, and when captured by the American forces, he was sent to a prison camp in North Carolina.

[3] My friend Dick Keskey was a crew member in the Winslow tank. He later told me he remembered our action in Gertwiller because we fired at noises, not at targets we could actually see.

we came under heavy artillery and mortar fire.[4] The fire was coming from the general direction of Wissembourg. While all this was going on, Sergeant Preston Rensch of the battalion medical detachment evacuated the wounded from the burning light tanks. He did this in broad daylight and under enemy fire. I did not witness the rescue, but I was told that his was an act of real bravery. The western column, by now also given the mission of taking Wissembourg, moved to the outskirts of the town. There the lead tank was stopped because of a road block. The tank commander ordered his gunner to destroy it with the tank's big gun. After firing a few rounds into the roadblock, the tank commander went forward on foot to examine the results of his crew's efforts. To his amazement and chagrin, there stood our battalion S-2 officer and his driver. They had rushed past the point of the eastern column and entered the city before anyone else. They were credited with being the first 14th Armored Division men into the city -- but in a Jeep!

When our platoon reached Wissembourg, we parked our tank next to German Army barracks, where we learned something of German Army practices regarding Venereal Disease prevention. A prisoner told us that the building next door to the barracks was occupied by women especially recruited to serve the German soldiers. Upon entering the 'house,' a soldier surrendered his dog tags and could not retrieve them until he gave evidence of having been to the dispensary for a prophylactic treatment. Supposedly, the procedure controlled VD.

We had to stay in Wissembourg while a bridge was repaired and some roadblocks removed, so Carl and I took a walk. Not too smart! Later we learned that the town had not been completely cleared of Germans. A sniper could have shot us while we were acting like tourists. One inn built around a courtyard particularly impressed me.[5]

Our entry into Wissembourg took place on December 16, the day the Germans attacked in force in the Ardennes. The date marks the beginning of the Battle

---

[4] Known as counter-battery.

[5] Ruth and I had a delicious lunch in the restaurant of that inn in 1985. The courtyard had not changed when we passed through Wissembourg again in 1995.

of the Bulge, which would have serious consequences for us in Alsace. The Third Army commanded by Gen. Patton was sent to relieve the divisions encircled in Belgium and Luxembourg, so our forces were spread very thin over a long front.

The battalion's next objective was in Germany. We were to cross the Lauter River, but the main bridge was blown. A by-pass route took us east toward Schweighofen, Germany. When we crossed the Lauter, most of us entered Germany proper for the first time.

We met resistance in late afternoon, and the AG Platoon immediately went into action. We fired many rounds of ammunition in an effort to knock out the German artillery positions. Darkness falls early in December, so the column closed[6] for the night. Sentries were instructed to be extra alert and vigilant: we were in Germany, and the enemy had the advantage of being on familiar ground. German patrols might easily infiltrate our lines. Nothing happened.

Fighting resumed the next day, and the town was cleared of the enemy before noon. The battalion moved on towards Kapsweyer, the next town. We could not enter it immediately: the division had orders to withdraw because the 12th Tactical Air Force had a bombing mission in the area. Somehow this information did not reach all of the troops, and I was caught in the open when the planes started bombing. I saw the B-26 bombers[7] clearly and assumed that their targets were farther east in the Siegfried Line. I stood out there and watched with awe and fascination. I even waved, knowing full well the bomber crews could not see me. But I felt good! Then I noticed: they were bombing the town I was in! I thought to myself, "Either the bombardiers have done a poor job, or they were assigned the wrong town!" I was standing right in the middle of their target! I headed for a German pillbox, hoping, of course,

---

[6] Similar to *circling the wagons,* the term *to close* means to shut down.

[7] The B-26 airplane was a 'hot plane.' It was very fast but tricky to fly. It was used extensively in support of ground troops in Normandy. There it earned the sobriquet *The Widow Maker.* It was also called *The Baltimore Whore* because it had no visible means of support. I met a B-26 bomber crew member in the Samena spa. He confirmed the plane's reputation. He was in the 9th Tactical Air Force, so he could not have been on the Kapsweyer-Steinfeld mission.

According to a newscast on September 29, 1995, the last B-26 crashed.

that there were no Germans in it. There were none! I dove in and stayed there until the bombing mission was over. The time I spent in the pillbox seemed an eternity, but actually it was only a few minutes. To be on the receiving end of an American bombing mission is a noisy and scary experience. The planes missed my pillbox, so I was okay -- if a little shaken!

After that debacle we entered Kapsweyer. We encountered some fighting to get into the town, but not much. In Kapsweyer we caught our first glimpse of the vaunted Seigfried Line. I did not see the pillboxes and dragon's teeth right away because the ground wasn't high enough, but we could see the whole front line from the second floor of the Battalion Command Post. We would see much more soon enough! Lieut. Martin, our platoon leader, was a *gung ho type*, and he immediately placed the AG Platoon right out in the open so that we could fire directly onto the pillboxes and casements. He wanted to see what effect Anti-Tank and High-Explosive shells (called AT and HE shells, respectively) had on pillboxes. Every time that we fired we received direct fire in return. In direct firing the gunner actually sees his target, as in rifle fire. The Germans were looking right down our throats. We must have had a lot of luck or guardian angel protection that day, for not a single tank in the platoon was hit. The battalion also had support from the 501st Field Artillery. The artillery forward observers took up positions in a church steeple, and the steeple was almost immediately fired upon by the Germans. The observers escaped unharmed. As night fell, the enemy artillery and mortar fire increased. The town was being demolished around us.

A terrible thing happened late on the afternoon of our first day in Kapsweyer. Colonel Ernest C. Watson, Lieutenant Hilliard F. Kirby, and some members of the Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon were caught in the open near the Battalion Command Post. An artillery shell grazed the front brim of Lieut. Kirby's steel helmet and blinded him for life.[8] No one else in the group was even touched.

I remember an incident that had nothing to do with the battle going on all around us. Kapsweyer was a small village, and most of the houses and public buildings had no indoor plumbing. The 'facility' for the house that our tank

---

[8] I read of the Lieut. Kirby's return to civilian life in the *Liberator.*

crew was using as a billet and place to get out of the cold had a primitive outhouse. Upon opening the door of the privy, we found a dead German occupying the seat. Attaching an explosive device to a body was one means of setting a booby-trap, and we had been warned about such procedures in training films. We left the body alone and later saw the outhouse blown up by a mortar shell. A dead German may have saved someone's life, perhaps mine.

Sometime after midnight a patrol went out to examine the dragon's teeth because the engineer platoon needed information. The men found seven rows of teeth. At 2:00 A.M. the engineers moved out to blow a path through the dragon's teeth. They carried 700 pounds of dynamite. As they reached the last row, they were pinned down by sniper fire and forced to withdraw. They returned *with* the dynamite and a captured German sentry. I happened to be on guard at our tank when the engineers came back, and because our tank was at the edge of town, I was the first person to see the returning patrol. At first I thought the men were Germans, but they knew the password for the night and I held my fire. They frightened me, though.[9] The next morning we resumed firing at emplacements in the Siegfried Line. Our artillery barrage was joined by big guns, the 155mm rifles and 8-inch howitzers from Corps Artillery. The return fire was immediate. The roar of outgoing shells accompanied by the explosions of incoming shells made a horrible din.

Fighting continued throughout that day and into the night. The following day the battalion was relieved by the 48th Tank Battalion. Soon after that, all elements of the 14th were pulled back to straighten the lines, for we had gone too far and exposed ourselves to attack on our flanks. Perhaps if Gen. Patton's Third Army had not been moved north to relieve the troops at Bastogne, we could have continued our offensive deeper into Germany.

The withdrawal did not take long. The Battalion Command Post and Headquarters Company including the AG Platoon were assigned to the village

---

[9] I met one John Copes on our 1985 trip. When I told him that I was the first person to make contact with the returning patrol, he immediately asked if I was the one that had taken his watch. He was wounded on a patrol into Steinfeld during the last week of March, 1945, and was helped back by buddies. The first person he saw was a medic who relieved him of his watch. I assured him that I was referring to a different incident and that I did not take his watch.

of Schleithal. Other companies were in two neighboring towns. All the towns were near the German border.

Upon arrival at our assigned area, we were told by some departing GIs that the Germans had infiltrated the lines and had killed some American troops with bayonets while they slept. We did not take the rumor too seriously but felt apprehensive for awhile, nonetheless. The guards were especially alert that first night.

The battalion then enjoyed a few days' rest. During that time I cleaned some of my woolen clothes with gasoline.[10] Our crew had an extra Jerri-can[11] of gas delivered when Service Company dropped off our fuel for the tank. My clothes did not smell much after hanging on a line for several hours.

The time of our respite came during the season of Advent. Division Chaplain Hollister conducted services several times to accommodate everyone. His driver played the portable organ. We sang Christmas songs, and there were some wet cheeks under our tin hats!

We were going from the offensive to the defensive, but we did not know that. Gen. Eisenhower never consulted us on the 'big picture' strategy.

News trickling in told us that all was not going well with the First Army in the Ardennes. The Germans under Field Marshall Rudolf Gerd von Rundstedt were attempting a massive incursion through Belgium, Luxembourg, and into France, and this potential thrust by the German lines gave the action which followed the name *Battle of the Bulge.* Gen. Patton's Third Army went north into Belgium, and the Seventh Army was left to defend a very long front. At the same time, a large enemy force was being assembled on the west bank of the Rhine, opposite the First French Army. If the Germans were successful in the Bulge and if they broke through the French, the Seventh Army would be trapped. The battalion wandered around northeastern Alsace for several days, always reinforcing weak spots in the line. Nothing made much sense to the

---

[10] I am almost embarrassed to report the incident of cleaning my clothes with gasoline because most civilians could purchase no more than four gallons of gasoline a week.

[11] A five-gallon container.

front line troops. We knew just enough of the strategic situation to be uneasy. We had only occasional direct contact with the enemy, but we engaged in many indirect fire missions in which we used tanks as artillery. Security was especially tight. At Christmastime we found ourselves in Rittershoffen, a village of less than a thousand people. Rittershoffen was to become very important to me -- several times that winter and again in 1985 and 1995.

Our first billet in Rittershoffen was the on the second floor of a house close to the *Evangelische* (Lutheran) church. I do not remember the family who lived there, but the church was very important to us while we were with them. Protestant services were held several times. One afternoon in the churchyard, there was a retreat ceremony for presentation of awards to our battalion. There was a little bitterness among some of the enlisted men, for the citations seemed to go mostly to officers. Members of our tank crew half-expected to receive commendation for our action at Gertwiller. The rancor did not last: one cannot afford to let personal feelings get in the way of common sense when one is in the front line.

The battalion command thought that the tanks were too close to one another and the concentration of armor made an attractive target. German intelligence may have been observing us. We were ordered to disperse. On Christmas Eve our tank crew slept in the home of Berthe Holzmann. We followed the usual procedure of knocking on the door of the house nearest to the tank's parking place and asking for quarters for five soldiers. Berthe admitted us. She had three children, two boys about twelve and ten years old and a little girl about five. We had seen very few trees in the Alsatian homes and churches that Advent season, but Berthe had a Christmas tree. She had little else with which to celebrate Christmas, but her tree was decorated with ornaments and real candles. We shared some Christmas goodies that we had received from home and sang some German carols. I know that Berthe was uneasy,[12] but I think she enjoyed sharing Christmas with people who believed as she in the birth of a Savior. I did not remember either the boys' or Berthe's names, but I did recall

[12] In 1985, Berthe told me she was especially afraid of George (of the retrieved football incident). George was teddy-bear of a fellow who wouldn't hurt a flea -- but he was big and dark, and he scared her.

that the little girl's name was Annelies many years later when I needed to know. (See Appendix E for the complete story.)

On Christmas Day we moved our tank to another part of the town. In keeping with our practice of sleeping near the tank, we moved to new quarters, though I wished we could have stayed with the Holzmann family a while longer.

Christmas Day was quiet but tense. Seventh Army Headquarters reported that enemy paratroops were landing in the area. We could look south across an open field to where a dense forest might well conceal infantry and tanks. Many of our fellows imagined all manner of enemy activity in the woods. Still nothing happened, and our cooks prepared a turkey dinner with all the trimmings. What they could do in a field kitchen was amazing!

The battalion remained in Rittershoffen until December 30. Chaplains conducted both Protestant and Catholic services a few days after Christmas. We did routine tank maintenance, washed our dirty clothes, bathed when we could -- in general, we took care of the tank and personal housekeeping chores. All the while we were on edge because we did not know our position relative to the enemy's.

The Battle of the Bulge was essentially over. The skies cleared on Christmas Day, and Allied bombers flew many missions in the Bulge sector. Still German troops were being brought south, and we were in a constant state of readiness.

Our battalion finally moved west on December 30. We were to reinforce Task Force Hudelson. The task force, formed on December 21 and named for the colonel who led it, was made up of elements of our division. Its mission was to establish defensive positions in the lower Vosges mountain passes. The departure of most of Patton's Third Army to the Bulge had left the passes undefended, and thus our forces along the Rhine were vulnerable. Our movement was yet one more complication in the cat-and-mouse game we were playing with the enemy. The strategists must have been burning a lot of midnight oil.

Early New Year's Eve, our crew was standing around a small fire drinking coffee when 'Bed-Check Charlie' made one of his visits. 'Bed-Check Charlie' was a German pilot who flew a small reconnaissance plane over the front lines

in an attempt to draw fire. Sometimes a GI would take a pot shot at Charlie just for the heck of it. The chances of hitting him were slim; shooting was just a way of relieving tension. I doubt the pilot ever saw much of any real interest. Anyway, we quickly doused our fire and thought that Charlie would go away. But he stayed longer than usual, so we became cautious and uneasy. The Germans were up to something.

I went to church in the German *Evangelische* church New Year's Eve. I also looked in on the Catholic services. (The two churches were across the street from one another.) I was impressed with the fact that a little Alsatian village had two such large churches. Neither church was heated that winter night. The Lutherans sat on pews, but the Catholics stood throughout their worship. The singing was better in the Lutheran service. I did not go alone; I think Carl Phillips was my companion. We slept in an extremely nice house that night. It must have belonged to a prosperous person. Our New Year's Day, turkey dinner was a hurried affair because the battalion was on constant alert. After dinner we moved to Uhrwiller, a village in one of the lower Vosges mountain passes.

Operation *Nordwind*, the last great German offensive, began January 1, 1945.

Just after midnight, the Germans launched an assault on the American forces manning the long east-west part of the front line. That line ran from the Rhine River to a point 84 miles west. Task Force Hudelson held about 10 miles of the front. The Germans' initial attack was swift and costly to the Americans, especially to Hudelson. We were not officially part of the task force, but we might as well have been. Our function was to plug holes in the line, block the mountain passes, and help as much as we could as often as we could.

Our days in the villages of the lower Vosges Mountains were strange. Sometimes we engaged in furious action. Other times everything was very quiet.

In one of the villages we had time to clean and repair our equipment. We parked our tank in the courtyard owned by one of the farmers of the village and slept in his barn. The house had no bathroom, so I asked the farmer if I might use his kitchen to take a sponge bath. He heated water on the kitchen

stove and gave me a basin. Our Battalion Trains just happened to be in the same village as our platoon, so I had access to my duffel bag and all my personal effects. I used my own soap, towel, toothpaste, toothbrush, and shaving gear, and I put on a complete set of clean clothes -- underwear, socks, shirt, and pants. It felt so-o-o good to be clean! The other fellows in the crew soon followed suit, and for a while ours was the cleanest tank crew in town!

That night we saw a movie in a barn. A generator operated by a gasoline engine provided electricity. The generator, projector, and film came from Special Services, but I never knew how they got them up to the front. The movie was *The Bridge of San Luis Rey* from the book by Thornton Wilder. The movie came out in 1944, so it was a recent release at the time. I remember little about it except that I enjoyed it. Years later I read the book and liked it, too.

On one clear day we saw a great number of US Air Force bombers fly overhead. They were quite a sight, and we watched, waved, and cheered. The bombers were heading for targets in Germany, so their proposed raid had nothing to do with the ground tactics in Alsace. Even so, I felt good seeing American planes in the air. Because of the bad weather in December, the troops in the Ardennes did not have air support during the Battle of the Bulge. We did not want a repeat of their situation!

Once I got into a little trouble with Lieut. Martin, my platoon leader. I was standing guard between midnight and 2:00 A.M. Our tank was parked near another tank, so I went over to it and talked to its guard. The night was cold and clear, so sound traveled well. Lieut. Martin was out doing a routine check around the town when he heard us. He immediately informed us that, had he been a German, we would either be dead or prisoners. I took guard duty more seriously after that.

Most of the news of strategic moves on our front came from *Stars and Stripes*, the soldiers' newspaper. We learned a little from our officers, but usually they did not know much more than the enlisted men. Somehow we learned that the German offensive in the Ardennes, the Battle of the Bulge, had been contained.

Now the Germans, in Operation *Nordwind*,[13] would attempt breaking through the Wissembourg Gap. The towns of Hatten and Rittershoffen lay in their path.

For about ten days, beginning on January 5, intelligence reported large concentrations of armor and infantry near Rittershoffen and Hatten and the neighboring towns of Buhl and Stundwiller. On January 10, our battalion moved to an assembly area in the vicinity of Woerth.[14] There we prepared for the Battle of Hatten-Rittershoffen. We did not know what, but we knew that something terrible was about to happen!

---

[13] Operation *Nordwind* began in the Bitche Sector, where the Germans attempted to probe the Seventh Army front.

[14] We had electricity in our Woerth billet, the first since we arrived in Alsace. The town had maintained its power source throughout the fighting.

Chapter VIII

The Low Vosges Mountain Campaign

December, 1944 - January, 1945

This account is taken from two sources. One is an article by David Colley in the January, 1995, issue of the *Veterans of Foreign Wars* magazine. The side-bar to that article reads, "Hitler's final offensive on the Western Front in January, 1945, devastated the French province of Alsace. Yet, the U.S. Seventh Army's desperate battle there is among the least known of the European War." The other source is an account of the actions of the U.S. Seventh Army under the command of Gen. Patch from December 15, 1944, until January 25, 1945, as prepared at the Seventh Army Headquarters at the request of the Army and Navy Journal.

In early December, 1944, the American Seventh Army broke through the southern Vosges Mountains and faced the German border across the broad Alsatian plain to the east and the lower Vosges Mountains to the north. The Army's objective was to move into Germany. The way seemed clear.

American troops moved steadily north and northeast during the first part of the month. On December 15, elements of the Seventh Army crossed into Germany. On December 17, the 25th Tank Battalion of the 14th Armored Division moved from Wissembourg in Alsace across the Lauter River into German villages, where they came up against the Siegfried Line fortifications. The incursion was one of the deepest penetrations into the Fatherland ever.

Shortly thereafter, the 14th AD troops were ordered to withdraw for tactical reasons. Intelligence reports, air reconnaissance, and infantry patrols all indicated that the Seventh Army would be hit hard in late December. All along the frozen, snowbound front in northeastern France, troops of Gen. Patch's Seventh Army braced for an attack.

The Battle of the Bulge began on December 16. The Germans needed a diversion to relieve pressure on their divisions in the Ardennes, where the US First Army had regained its balance and was beginning to push them back. The US Third Army under Gen. Patton relinquished ground to the adjacent Seventh Army as the Third dispatched divisions to the Bulge, thus leaving Patch's units stretched perilously thin.

The geography of the front rendered the Seventh Army vulnerable. The front line formed a V-shaped salient, which was dubbed the *Lauterbourg Bulge*. Its northern edge stretched more than 84 miles from west to east, from a point near Saarbrucken to Lauterbourg, a town near the Rhine River and the German border. The front then ran south along the Rhine for 42 miles to a point south of Strasbourg.

Hitler considered the Lauterbourg Bulge a ripe fruit waiting to be plucked, so he ordered his generals to concentrate on the Alsatian sector of his Western Front. The meeting of Hitler and his generals took place on December 28 in a castle east of the Rhine. There they devised a plan, which they called

Operation *Nordwind.* It was to be put into force on January 1. Marshal von Runstedt was to lead the German High Command West.

Operation *Nordwind* began just after midnight on New Year's Day, 1945, when two corps from the German First Army attacked southward in the lower Vosges Mountains. Their objective was to reach the Saverne Gap and split the US XV and VI Corps, thus isolating the VI Corps on the Alsatian plain with its back to the Rhine. The VI Corps included the 14th AD, the only armored division in the eastern sector.

The weather was bitterly cold in the Vosges Mountains that January. Snow was knee-deep, and water froze in canteens. Infantrymen could not dig foxholes because the ground was frozen. Tank and half-track drivers had difficulty keeping their vehicles on the roads because they were sheets of ice.

Task Force Harris, one of the several hastily assembled commands, met the initial attack by the German XIII Corps. The Germans had not counted on the determination of the American troops, and their attack faltered.

The German LXXXIX Corps from Bitche fared better. The Germans surprised the Americans in Task Force Hudelson.[1] The fight between the German LXXXIX Corps and the American Task Force lasted three weeks. Other elements of the 14th AD, including the 25th Tank Battalion, became involved later.

The 100th Infantry Division and two recently assembled task forces assisted Task Force Hudelson in turning back the German attack. The fighting was furious, and the outcome was in doubt for three or four days. Had the Germans broken out behind the VI Corps, the corps would have been trapped.

By January 5, the German attacks of Operation *Nordwind* began to wane.

But these assaults were only the first in a series launched by the Germans in Alsace. Most of the attacks were against the Seventh Army. The French First Army under General Jean de Lattre de Tassigney was engaged farther south – but to a lesser degree.

The next German offensive was Operation *Sonnenwinde* (Winter Solstice). On January 5, Heinrich Himmler, head of the SS[2] and commander of an Army group, launched an attack across the Rhine at Gambsheim, a town ten miles north of Strasbourg. He was headed directly into the VI Corps right flank. Two days later, the German 19th Army crossed the Rhine south of Strasbourg. The Germans were making yet another attempt to cut off the Seventh Army.

Task Force Linden, another American *ad hoc* unit made up of troops from the newly-arrived 42nd 'Rainbow' Infantry Division failed to contain the two bridgeheads. Elements of the 14th AD, a few battalions from the 79th Division, and the inexperienced 12th AD then began to deploy against the bridgeheads.

---

[1] The task force was made up of elements of the 117th Cavalry Squadron, the 94th Cavalry Squadron, and the 62nd Armored Infantry Battalion. The last two units were from the 14th AD.

[2] *Schutzstaffel* or Stormtroopers, also known as *Blackshirts.*

Gen. de Lattre threw in elements of the French 5th Armored Division and the French 1st Infantry Division against the Germans south of Strasbourg.

Operation *Sonnenwinde* made few gains for the Germans, but it highlighted the importance of Strasbourg to the Allies, especially to the French.

Even before the New Year's attacks, Gen. Eisenhower had ordered General Jacob Devers to straighten the Seventh Army's front line and to withdraw to more defensible positions in the foothills of the Lower Vosges Mountains. The entire Western Front, from the North Sea to Switzerland, was adopting a defensive posture. Many units were removed from Alsace and sent to the Ardennes, thus weakening the forces in Alsace.

Gen. Devers was reluctant to give up ground won with his troops' blood. He also knew withdrawal meant giving up Strasbourg. Gen. Charles de Gaulle, leader of the Free French, criticized Eisenhower's plan to abandon the city and threatened to remove French forces from the Allied Command and defend the city with them. Strasbourg is the symbol of the French presence in an area often claimed or annexed by Germany and holding the city was imperative for reasons of morale and for the safety of the citizenry.

Eisenhower relented and agreed to protect Strasbourg, and Devers agreed to prepare for a series of staged withdrawals -- if necessary.

The Germans had a distinct advantage in Alsace during the early days of 1945. They kept the pressure on Allied Forces in at least three main areas. The Bitche Salient in the West became extremely troublesome after the initial New Year's attack. By January 4, elements of four German divisions were known to be in the area. On January 6, the Germans began to probe into the Seventh Army's vulnerable, lightly-held Rhine River flank, which extended 26 miles north and south of Strasbourg.

The VI Corps had great cause for concern. The enemy was intent on keeping the initiative and continued to push from the north through the Wissembourg Gap. To meet the threat from the north, Combat Command A of the 14th AD was attached to the 79th Infantry Division, and on January 6, the division began moving to an assembly area north of Hagenau.

The VI Corps was threatened not only from the front and flank but also from the rear. The Germans had been building up forces in the Colmar Pocket to the south in preparation for a drive north on Strasbourg. It was said that Heinrich Himmler, Commandant of the German Forces both in the Gambsheim Pocket and in the Colmar Pocket, promised Strasbourg to Hitler as a commemorative gift by the thirtieth of January, the twelfth anniversary of Hitler's rise to power.

On January 7, the Germans attacked the French First Army. Their attack was coordinated with the attacks in the Gambsheim Pocket north of Strasbourg. The enemy brought much armor into play in these attacks.

The culmination of the German pincer-like movement was the battle at Rittershoffen and Hatten. On January 5, the German XXXIX *Panzer* Corps, made up of the 21st *Panzer* and the 25th *Panzer* Grenadier Divisions, began

moving south toward the two villages. More German troops would be engaged later. All of the enemy forces in the battle were under the command of Lieutenant General Arnold Burmeister.[3]

On January 8, the Germans drove viciously into the VI Corps Maginot Line positions. Shortly thereafter, the 25th *Panzer* Grenadier Division began an attack on the American positions in Hatten.

By all indications the Germans were attempting a quick breakthrough to Hagenau, a large town on the edge of the vast Hagenau Forest south of Hatten and Rittershoffen and a vital communications center. There the Germans could effect a juncture for their troops crossing the Rhine and their troops breaking out of the Bitche Salient.

If, indeed, such were the German strategy, the battle at Hatten-Rittershoffen would be the key to the whole plan. So far as the Americans[4] were concerned, Hatten-Rittershoffen would be a fight for personal survival and a battle to save Strasbourg.

For three weeks the fighting in Hatten-Rittershoffen was extremely fierce. Both of the German divisions suffered heavy losses in armor and infantry. On January 13, the German 20th Parachute Division arrived from Holland to reinforce the enemy position at Rittershoffen.

Elsewhere, the enemy drive to take Strasbourg was growing in intensity. Troops of the French First Army met German infantry and armor only ten miles from the city's outskirts. The French asked to have the 2nd French Armored Division and the XV Corps, in reserve west of the Vosges Mountains, released to aid in the defense of Strasbourg. The request was denied: keeping armor in reserve in the west was deemed essential. North of Strasbourg, Combat Command B of the 12th Armored Division continued to hold its ground.

On January 20, the American troops in Hatten and Rittershoffen were ordered to withdraw to the Moder River. The move reduced the 36-mile corps front to 26 miles. The Germans were left swinging at air, and the American positions became more favorably disposed for the defense of Strasbourg.

Fighting raged in small pockets and villages all through Alsace as the Americans withdrew. One soldier recalls, "It was a weird battle scene. One time you were surrounded, the next time you surrounded the enemy. Often we took refuge in villages where the Germans were upstairs and we were downstairs -- in the same house. We heard them, and they heard us. If they made no move, we left. If we made no move, they left."

The Germans made a final attack over the Moder River the night of January 24-25. Six German divisions struck. "The Germans had shot their last bolt in

---

[3] For a later encounter with Gen. Burmeister, see Chapter XVIII, *A Soldier's Return,* page 181.

[4] Most GIs did not know that the Seventh Army was in danger of being cut off and annihilated.

France," wrote Charles Whiting in *Operation Northwind, the Other Battle of the Bulge.* The Seventh Army, though tired and extended, was still intact. In early February, 125,000 Americans, at a cost of 6,400 casualties, did its part in reducing the Colmar Pocket. The last German fortress to fall west of the Rhine was at Neuf-Brisach, southeast of Colmar.

Nordwind was costly for both sides. VI Corps losses for the period are listed as 14,716 battle casualties. German forces sustained losses of 23,000 men killed, wounded, or missing in action. Americans processed 5,985 prisoners.

Nordwind engagements clearly showed the quality of American arms. Often outnumbered, the American troops, many of them inductees,[5] fought the German Army to a standstill. Gen. Devers said that the VI Corps fought one the greatest defensive battles of all times with very little.

But Devers himself must also be given credit. His brilliant tactics held off full-scale German attacks with almost no reinforcements or reserve troops. Devers is all but forgotten today, for history has cast him into the shadow of the more popular Patton and Bradley[6] and the controversial Montgomery.[7]

Yet it was the Sixth Army Group under Devers, the 'orphan' of the Allied Armies, who first reached the Rhine and the German border in late 1944. With virtually no opposition, Devers was prepared to cross the river immediately and strike into the heart of the German industrial area.

But Eisenhower overruled Devers. Eisenhower ordered Devers to proceed north to support Patton's Third Army, which had bogged down in its offensive.

Historians can only speculate about the outcome of the War in Europe had Devers been allowed to attack across the Rhine in December, 1944. The ramifications are endless. Quite possibly, Operation *Nordwind* might have remained on Hitler's drawing board.

---

[5] Citizen soldiers.

[6] General Omar Bradley, Commander of all American troops in Europe, second in command only to Gen. Eisenhower, and later Commander of the Twelfth Army.

[7] General Bernard Montgomery, Commander of all English and Canadian troops in Europe.

Why go I mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?

... Psalm 42:9, KJV

Chapter IX

Hatten-Rittershoffen

This chapter is about the battle of Hatten-Rittershoffen. Much has been written about that engagement, and some of the articles go into great detail. Veterans of the 14th Armored Division take great pride in the records of their individual units in that fierce and bloody fight. The stories of personal experiences that appear regularly in the *Liberator* are hair-raising, tragic, miraculous, dramatic, and sometimes even humorous. My own recollections are hazy, for the entire engagement is something of a blur to me. I recall some incidents and impressions, but I have only a vague sense of the chronology and of the tactics employed.

Our first assault on the villages of Hatten and Rittershoffen began in the late morning of January 11, 1945. The 62nd Armored Infantry Battalion, with Company C, 25th Tank attached, led the attack. The Assault Gun Platoon, with our tank in the lead, followed about a quarter-of-a-mile behind. Our mission was to seize the high ground north and east of Hatten. We had to go across fields, not on roads. The ground was covered with snow, and the tanks slid around a lot. We were in open country, and our tanks stood out against the snow. We should have had some white camouflage.

I was acting as tank commander when we first engaged the enemy. John Donges, our regular tank commander, was away getting instructions from Lieut. Martin at the Company Command Post. Normally Carl Phillips would have taken over, I would have become gunner, and someone would have been brought in to act as loader. However, Carl was the most experienced and skilled gunner in the crew, and since our very lives might well depend on the gunner's skills, I took over as commander. I expected that most of what I was to do would be directed by radio from the outside: I would relay messages to the driver and gunner. But that is not how things worked out that day.

The crest of the ridge overlooking Rittershoffen was especially icy. When our platoon moved over the ridge, we saw German tanks several hundred yards in front of us. As soon as we were exposed, we drew fire from them. One of the C Company tanks was hit three times and started to burn. Several of the crew

were wounded but managed to get away. Another tank was hit right after that, and the tank commander was killed.

I was standing in the turret of the tank with both of my hands resting on the outside of the tank when a piece of shrapnel whistled by. I heard it coming but could do nothing to avoid being hit. A fragment creased my thumb. I managed to stop the bleeding and stayed with the tank.[1] Immediately, an anti-tank shell hit our tank at the top of the turret where the armor curves from the side to the top. The shell struck a glancing blow and gouged out a piece of steel from the tank; the hole looked as if it had been made with an over-sized ice cream scoop.

Because we were being fired upon, I ordered Eddie, our driver, to back up. He had to turn a little, and we started to slide down the hill sideways. Other tanks were sliding down the hill, too. I heard about a tank that slid into a German tank. The two tanks were side by side, pointing in opposite directions. After some maneuvering, the American tank managed to disentangle itself and fire upon the German tank. Later, the American crew looked into the blown-up tank and found it to be empty. It had been harmless all the time!

All of the tanks, American and German, had trouble. Had the situation not been so serious, it would have been comical -- all those tanks from both sides sliding around like clumsy comedians in an ice show!

It was difficult for any tank to get into position to fire on the enemy. The American tanks had an advantage. The turret on a Sherman tank could traverse through 360 degrees and was power driven,[2] whereas the turret on a German tank was limited to 30 degrees and had to be moved with a hand crank system.

Somehow we managed to find some protection. The Germans, too, were scrambling for cover, and some of their tanks were knocked out. In the

---

[1] I had my hand treated later at an aid station.

[2] We heard of a gunner who knocked a German infantryman off of his tank by moving the turret very fast. The speed of the turret and the length of the gun barrel allowed him to hit the intruder behind his knees and send him flying.

confusion of trying to maneuver on icy ground and keep alive at the same time, I lost all sense of time and direction. I shouted a lot of orders into the mike, and Eddie did a superb job of getting us out of a sticky situation.

The commander of C Company used an innovative approach to the ice problem. His company, approaching Hatten from the west, was to assist the 94th Cavalry and elements of the 79th Division trapped in the town. Going either on the roads or across open fields was almost impossible because of the ice. The company commander noticed on his maps that the railroad serving the two towns ran south of both of them and in a straight east-west line. He managed to get his company of tanks, 17 in number, to the railroad. He then led them in his command Jeep for several miles by bouncing along on the railroad ties. Theirs was a rough ride, and always there was the possibility that the railroad bed had been mined. But the company made it to Hatten without incident and without any of the tanks sliding off into some ditch.

After our platoon reassembled, it was given the mission of firing at sectors of Rittershoffen. Our specific assignment was to fire on a part of the town that included the home of the people with whom we spent Christmas Eve. I asked for and was granted a different mission.[3] Sgt. Donges returned, so I resumed my position as loader.

The platoon soon had another assignment. We were to fire indirectly on two neighboring villages, Buhl and Stundwiller. All the rest of that day and into the night we were engaged in an artillery duel. Many times we could hear the rattle of shrapnel against the outside of the tank, but we never received a direct hit. That day our platoon discharged 1270 rounds of artillery shells in almost continuous firing. Of those 1270 rounds, our tank fired 260. I have forgotten the weight of a shell, but I remember I was very tired after slamming 260 of them into the breech of the big gun. Our tank carried about sixty 105mm shells. In order to fire 260 of them, we had to restock the tank several times under enemy fire. The Service Company truck drivers and other members of

---

[3] Years later, I learned how that family fared during the battle. Berthe Holzmann wrote me a long letter in which she described in detail that terrible time and the months that followed. The text of her letter is included in Appendix E.

our crew helped me, but I still had to handle every round of ammunition that was restocked. My hand throbbed, and sometime towards the middle of our fire mission I dropped a shell onto my big toe. I still have the marks, both on my toe and on my thumb.

While all this was going on north of town, other elements of the division were attacking from the south. Soon Hatten and Rittershoffen were infernos.[4] The civilians that lived in the two towns suffered terribly, and there were many casualties.[5] A man and woman and their young daughter were seen trudging alongside an ox-drawn cart that carried a few of their most precious belongings. They were leaving Rittershoffen to go to Hatten -- Heaven only knows why! -- when a mortar shell landed on the cart and killed them all. Another incident involved a German soldier who fired a flame-thrower through a basement door because he thought Americans were hiding on the premises. The basement was full of civilians. Their screams could be heard above the noise of the shooting.

We retained our position on the ridge north of Rittershoffen for most of the battle. On a few occasions we were sent into the village. We were to cover infantry troops advancing into the town, shell the town directly, and bombard nearby enemy positions with indirect fire. When firing directly, we were often engaged in tank duels. When firing indirectly, we received counter-fire almost constantly. Artillery duels are very scary and noisy. I do not know how much damage we inflicted on the enemy.

Nights were bitterly cold. The infantrymen of the 62nd Armored Infantry Battalion around us almost always had to sleep in foxholes. On rare occasions they slept in houses, but being in a house was considerably more dangerous than being out in the open.

---

[4] In 1995, we learned that the two villages were 80% destroyed.

[5] The fiftieth anniversary observation in 1995 began with a memorial service for the 80 civilians who died.

I was not involved in the house-to-house fighting as I had been in Gertwiller, but I was told of many incidents that happened in the villages. One involved a group of soldiers congregated in one room on the lower floor of a house. A German soldier appeared in the doorway. His hands were up, and he shouted *Komrad!* The Americans were taken off guard momentarily. The German then stepped aside and his companion behind him sprayed the room with machine-gun fire.

On most nights tankers slept in or on their tanks. The metal was very cold, and the cold penetrated through sleeping bags. On a few nights we slept in a barn located a short distance behind the ridge position we maintained. On the first night in the barn, I was warm and comfortable in some hay. My guard shift was hours away, and I looked forward to some much-needed sleep. I was soon awakened by an artillery barrage. Looking straight up towards the top of the barn, I could see bright flashes through the cracks in the ridge-line of the roof. I knew that if I could see the shells going over the barn, sooner or later they would hit the barn. I quickly put my boots on and was about to get out of the building when John Donges, who was already up, shouted for me to join him in a small room with walls and ceiling made of concrete. There was a cow in the room; she had been put there by the farmer-owner for the same reason that we were in the room -- for protection. The room was in a corner of the barn; during peacetime it was probably used to store stools, pails, and other milking paraphernalia.

We stayed in our concrete bunker for a time, but it was very crowded. I don't know how many people -- and one cow -- were in the bunker, but we had little room to move around. I decided I might be safer in the tank, which was about fifty yards from the barn, and determined to make a run for it. I picked up my outer garments from my sleeping place and watched from the door for a lull in the artillery barrage. No such pause came, so I ran for the tank. Just as I got to it, the shelling seemed to increase. Rather than expose myself even more by climbing up to the turret hatch, I crawled under the tank and waited for a chance to get into the tank. To complicate matters further, I could not see our guard. I certainly did not want him to mistake me for an infiltrating German! In truth, the guard had climbed into the tank when the barrage started.

Finally, when I thought it safe enough to crawl out, I mounted the rear of the tank and pounded on the closed hatch. The guard opened it, and I got in. One detail escapes me. I knew our crew members very well, and this particular incident is indelibly imprinted on my memory; yet I cannot remember who was on guard when I reached the tank that night. Later I dashed back to the barn and brought back my sleeping bag and whatever else I had left behind. Quite a few of the soldiers were still there; some had slept through the whole thing. I suppose their thinking was *Anything to get out of the cold!*

I sought the shelter of our tank on another occasion and once more had to settle for crawling under it. Again timing was important, and I could not get into the tank quickly enough to avoid enemy action. Our position was exposed, so we were easy targets for enemy air attacks. The German *Luftwaffe* bombed and strafed us constantly with their new jet planes, but the new planes were too fast for the pilots.[6] They could not adjust their aiming points to the increased speed, and their bombs fell a great distance beyond the intended targets. Their machine-gun fire also missed badly. I am glad they were inexperienced! Conventional, *i.e.* non-jet aircraft also bombed and strafed us many times while we were on that ridge, and the pilots in those planes had much more skill than the jet pilots. Fortunately we took only a spattering of their fire, no armor-piercing ammunition.

One day I had an errand that took me about a quarter-mile away from our tank. Moving around at all was very hazardous, so my assignment must have been important. Upon my return I passed a tank destroyer company that had just received a fire mission. I stopped to watch. There was a certain humor in the crew's actions. The tank destroyer company was made up of black soldiers exclusively. In 1945, the Armed Forces were not integrated, so black servicemen had their own units. After each salvo was fired, one of the soldiers would shout, "Mr. Hitler, count yo' chillun!"

Hanging around to watch was a big mistake. The firing naturally drew counter-fire, and suddenly I found myself in another artillery barrage. I was

[6] The pilots may not have had enough training in flying jets because airplane fuel, especially jet fuel, was very scarce in Germany, and using fuel for training may have seemed a luxury they could not afford.

not so lucky this time as I had been before. A mortar shell[7] exploded near me, and I received some shrapnel wounds in my back and right leg. Such wounds were sometimes called 'salt and pepper wounds' because the fragments were very small. I was not incapacitated, so I ran or crawled away as fast as I could. Soon there was pain, however, and I was alone in a kind of no-man's-land. I remembered what to do to alleviate pain from my first aid training. I went behind a small building and opened my first aid kit, got out the morphine ampule, and clumsily administered the drug to myself. I doubt I got more than about a fifth of it, but it eased my pain.

I managed to get to an aid station, but it was under fire, too. The medics removed most of the shrapnel.[8] It was cold in the aid station, and I had to take off most of my clothes. After receiving emergency care, I got dressed with the help of one of the medics. I was glad to be out of the way. There were wounded coming in, and they were much more in need of care than I. Those already given treatment were put into another room. No one was allowed to leave until nightfall, and the aid station was getting crowded. Under the cover of darkness, the wounded were evacuated and supplies brought in.

After about an hour of hanging around the aid station, I decided to make my way back to the tank. It seemed safer than where I was. The aid station personnel were too busy to notice if I were there or not. Eventually I made it to the tank and decided to stay there. My clothes were torn, and I was all bandaged up. But there was no more bleeding! The battalion aid station physician had given me a few pills to counteract pain, and I took one that evening. The wounds were superficial, and I wanted to stay with my crew. The alternative, riding an ambulance through artillery fire in the dark on icy roads, was not all that appealing either! In spite of my earlier experience in the barn, I decided to spend the night there. I had to lie on my stomach, but

---

After the War, I saw a great many new, unused jet fighter planes parked on airfields at Innsbruck and Munich.

[7] I was quite sure that it was a mortar shell because an artillery shell would have given several seconds' warning. As an artillery shell approaches, it makes a screaming sound. During that time, one can 'hit the dirt.' A mortar shell just goes *whoosh, bang!*

[8] I still had some shrapnel in my leg when I was discharged. Over the years pieces work their way to the surface, so I may or may not have any left in me now.

I was warm and cozy. I was excused from guard duty, and I slept through until morning. There was another big artillery barrage during the night, but I never heard a thing!

Our battalion was part of Combat Command B. There are three combat commands in an armored division, *viz.* Combat Command A, Combat Command B, and Combat Command R. Book tactics call for one of them to be held in reserve. At Hatten-Rittershoffen all three were committed to action. We had no reserve forces.

For the Americans, Hatten-Rittershoffen was a defensive battle. We were trying to prevent the Germans from breaking out onto the Alsatian plain and retaking Strasbourg. Because we were fighting defensively, our attacks were really counter-attacks, but, as in football, sometimes the best defense is a good offense. Such seemed to be the tactic employed by some of the Americans trapped in Hatten.

I did not know it at the time, but two of my friends from the Army Specialized Training Program were among them. Tom Bryant and Harvey Sabinson, both in the 94th Cavalry, were in Hatten throughout the battle. Harvey received a battlefield commission. After his platoon leader,[9] platoon sergeant, and squad leader were killed or wounded, Harvey took charge. I think that he was a corporal or private first class at the time. Our platoon never got into Hatten. Had I known my friends were there, I would have wanted to be in one of the tanks sent into Hatten to help the trapped troops. (Easy to say now, of course!) C Company's entry into Hatten along the railroad tracks was such a mission.

I became a corporal sometime in January. Details like promotions were ignored during the fighting, so I did not learn of my new rank until we were out of the Hatten-Rittershoffen area. I was promoted again shortly thereafter. Crews were being changed all of time because of casualties. I was a loader, gunner, and tank commander at one time or another. Lieut. Martin, our platoon leader, took over as A Company Commander, and Sergeant Frank Reissner took over the platoon. Frank accepted a battlefield commission, so he then had the rightful

---

[9] A lieutenant.

rank of a platoon leader. Because there were so many holes in the various crews, everyone was expected to do whatever needed doing. I must have impressed someone during the battle because I was offered a battlefield commission. I declined for several reasons, the main one being that junior officers had a high rate of mortality. I had seen Lieut. Tomey killed at Gertwiller, Lieut. Kirby severely wounded at Kapsweyer, and Lieut. Klinefelter's lead tank hit and badly burned.

We went with very little sleep, and the weather was terrible. Under such conditions, one would expect more illness than we experienced. The body must make some accommodation for unusual exposure.

There were exceptions, of course. Carl, our gunner, became ill after about six or seven days in Rittershoffen. His symptoms were those of a bad cold. I rounded up all the powdered lemon from K rations that I could find and made several steaming hot lemonades for him every day. Most of the fellows did not use their lemon powder anyway because they preferred coffee and chocolate. I heated the water on a portable Coleman-type single-burner stove. Taking care of Carl was difficult because we were so busy fighting the Germans. I took over as gunner for much of the time after Carl got sick. George Johnson acted as loader, and Carl sat in George's bow gunner's seat in an effort to keep warm. Carl was sent to a field hospital after we got out of Rittershoffen. There he learned he had pneumonia.[10]

We were under constant shelling and frequent air attacks. All of the 14th AD units as well as the 79th and 42nd Infantry Divisions suffered heavy casualties. Moreover, we were unable to dislodge the enemy from either Hatten or Rittershoffen.

Finally the order came from VI Corps to withdraw to previously prepared defensive positions. Withdrawal was scheduled for January 20-21, but there was an unexpected complication. The division engineers had laid mine fields

---

[10] Carl wrote to me in 1993; he hoped I could help him obtain financial assistance from the Veterans' Administration. He had recurring respiratory problems that he attributed to having pneumonia while in Service. He needed someone to vouch for his having been ill. I was glad to help and wrote to the VA -- but to no avail. Carl was denied his request.

behind the lines and had neglected to inform the withdrawing units of their exact locations. Several inches of fresh snow fell the night before the first units were to leave, so they could not see where the engineers had been. The commander in the lead vehicle chose a route that seemed impossible for tanks. He reasoned that the engineers would not bother to mine that area. He was right! None of our tanks hit a mine.

Our departure was inauspicious. The last tanks had guns pointed to the rear. We moved slowly and as quietly as we could.[11] All kinds of vehicles clogged the roads. A 155mm artillery piece skidded and blocked our way. The column was backed up for miles As if in a commuter gridlock at rush hour, we sat waiting in the tangle of tanks, Jeeps, and half-tracks. I remember thinking to myself, "What if the Germans attack now?"

But they didn't!

---

[11] There are as many versions of the withdrawal as men who were there. More than one soldier and crew claim to have been the last in town. Our platoon thought we were. Most likely we were not. I think that C or D Company of our battalion may have had that distinction.

I read about two infantrymen guarding a crossroads who were forgotten by their company. Their last encounter with the enemy turned out to be a cow slowly moving in the snowy night. They made it out of town and lived to write about their last night in Rittershoffen.

January 11 through January 20, 1945, must have been the most harrowing ten days of my life. Because I was living on the edge the whole time, my recollections are almost surreal. Yet some things stand out:

Pumping adrenaline during fire missions. The loader works harder than anyone else in the crew.

Frozen K rations.

A hot meal. The mess truck reached our ridge a few times. What brave cooks!

Infrequent but welcome chances to use a sleeping bag and get warm. Tank crews spent most nights huddled in their tanks, freezing in that coldest of winters. The infantrymen had to spend nights in foxholes.

Waiting, always waiting, for something to happen -- incoming artillery, enemy attack, whatever. The Germans used some paratroops as regular infantry in the battle. (This we learned when we captured a few of them.) Thus we had yet another worry: we could be attacked from the rear by paratroops dropped behind us.

Being caught in the open at night when the Germans launched flares. A flare lit up the sky as if it were day.

Wondering about our 'Christmas' family in Rittershoffen.

Not being able to wash my face, brush my teeth, shave, or put on clean clothes.

Almost constant shivering, either from cold or sheer terror.

Horrible artillery barrages. Sometimes the night was so bright from the combined shellings that roosters, mistaking the light for dawn, crowed all night.

Having to leave the protection of the tank for any reason.

Two-hour guard shifts in the middle of cold, starless nights. Imaginations ran wild as one could see the enemy in every shadow.

Concern for Carl. He had a fever. We split up his guard shifts.

Worrying about my family. I was unable to write home. We had mail once or twice during the ten days of the battle. I received a few letters from my parents. I hoped that they did not know or suspect just where I was or what was happening to me.

Praying, always praying

God, don't you hear me??

Evening, and morning, and at noon, will I pray and cry aloud.

... Psalm 54:17, KJV

Chapter X

Defense

After Hatten and Rittershoffen, the 14th Armored Division took up positions defending the Lower Vosges mountain passes and the city of Strasbourg. Everyone breathed a little more easily now that the battles were over, but another German offensive could still be launched. After a few life-and-death struggles, a soldier is always wary, always looking over his shoulder.

Our first stop was Hochfelden. We did not stay there long, for soon the division moved to occupy several small towns south of Hagenau, the next strong point the Germans were likely to attack. Hagenau is on the Moder River, a natural barrier to the German advance. The 14th was to cover any parts of the river shallow enough to ford, also any bridges in the sector. Our platoon was dispatched to a small town several miles south and west of Hagenau.

Before I did anything else, I went to a field hospital to be checked over. It was located about thirty miles back of the lines in a middle-sized French town. The hospital was in a warm and pleasant building that probably had been used for government offices. I got cleaned up and was examined. The battalion aid station medics had done a wonderful job. I rested for a few days, but then I went back to the 25th. I did not have that magic 'million dollar wound,' a not-too-serious injury that would send a soldier home.[1]

On January 25, we received orders to move in a northeasterly direction and seize Schweighausen, a town several miles west of Hagenau and on the river. We were also to cut the roads leading to the town. The Germans had accomplished what we had hoped to prevent. They crossed the Moder River, penetrated the 42nd 'Rainbow' Infantry Division's[2] defensive positions, and were threatening to surround the troops in Hagenau.

---

[1] A broken leg was typical of such a wound. The Army didn't have time to wait for the bone to set, so anyone with a broken leg was sent home. A broken arm was <u>not</u> a ticket home. The Army's logic escapes me.

[2]Douglas MacArthur's division in World War I.

Somehow, long since forgotten by me, our platoon got into Hagenau, and there we found ourselves in another mess. I had been helping out as crew member in several tanks. I did everything but drive. Most of the time I acted either as tank commander or gunner. The replacements we expected after the engagement at Hatten-Rittershoffen were slow in arriving. Frank Reissner, our new platoon leader, asked me to share his quarters for a few nights. I was without a permanent tank assignment at the time, so I stayed with him.

Frank and I slept in a room that had direct access to the outside. The door was about halfway down a dark passageway that ran perpendicular to the street. It was narrow because the house next door was very near. We closed the shutters and drapes. I went outside to see if any light showed through. None did, so we settled down for the evening. Occasionally an artillery round whistled into the town, but there was not the incessant pounding of an artillery barrage.

Frank set to work censoring mail, a new chore to him. All outgoing mail had to pass through a censor. Frank was an officer -- or soon would be -- so his lieutenant's bars qualified him to do the job. He had a razor blade and a pile of enlisted men's letters. I did not envy him.

I tried to read a little, but I soon felt tired decided to turn in. I checked with my old crew to see if they might need help on guard duty. They did, and I drew an early morning shift.

I went back to our room to tell Frank and then went out again to use the outhouse. At the end of the very dark passageway a group of Germans grabbed me. I was without my gun, and I thought to myself, "How foolish to move about unarmed!" In retrospect I realize I was lucky not to have had my weapon. If I had tried to resist or shoot it out with my captors, they would have killed me. The Germans were holding two GIs from the infantry also. The three of us were hustled across the river. Going across the bridge was scary. I was afraid that some American GIs would see us and start firing. Once across, we were told to jump into the back of a truck. We did not go very far before being taken into a house for questioning. We were asked exactly what one would expect. The interrogating officer spoke some English, and for the moment I pretended to know no German. We wanted to make his task as hard

as possible. He asked about our units, the strength of the American troops in that sector, and immediate battle plans. Much of that information was beyond our knowledge anyway, so it was easy for us to play dumb. Every soldier is instructed from the very beginning of his training to invoke the Geneva Convention in such a situation. According to the rules, a captive has to divulge only his name, rank, and serial number.

The interrogation did not last long because American artillery batteries began to shell the place. Again I was caught on the wrong side. Any artillery barrage is bad, but how much worse it is to cower and shiver with fright while being shelled by friendly fire! Eventually the barrage stopped, and the officer in charge decided to send us farther to the rear. As we were getting into the truck, the driver took off, and we all tumbled out and headed for cover. One of the fellows lagged behind and had an encounter with one of the guards. He managed to escape and joined us. We found our way back to the bridge without too much difficulty. Getting across was something else. We did not want to attract attention from either side We finally made it by crawling on our stomachs. I had been gone for several hours. Frank was asleep when I got back.

Technically, I had been captured. But I really think the German officer in charge wanted us to escape, either to have an excuse to shoot us or to get us out of the way. He had other things to think about without having to bother with Prisoners Of War.

An interesting sidelight: I never learned the last names of the other prisoners.

I arrived back in time to do my guard shift. I hadn't had any sleep, but I managed to stay awake anyway. In my frame of mind I almost hoped I would encounter some Germans. I wanted to frighten them as much as they had frightened me.

The next morning we had tales to swap. My experience was not even close to tops on the 'harrowing' scale. I think Eddie Berg's deserves the honor. Eddie was sleeping with some other tankers in a brick schoolhouse. His was the last in a row of sleeping bags, so his head was right in the corner of the room. Sometime during the night, he had to get up to go outside. When he returned,

he found the room in which he had been sleeping empty with a big, gaping hole in the corner where he had lain. His head would have been right where the artillery shell exploded, had he not gone out. The same artillery barrage hit a track on the Donges tank and put it out of commission. Our original crew had a penchant for losing tanks without having anyone injured.

Replacements arrived sometime in late February, but there were not enough of them to fill all the crew vacancies. They were young, just out of high school. Most of them were very naive. Don M~~~ was especially innocent and gullible. He informed us that he was grateful to be in the armored force because a tank is relatively safe. He said he had been told that nothing could knock out an American Sherman tank, that the best the Germans had would not be good enough to pierce its armor. We asked him who said that and quickly informed him that a German 88 could go through a Sherman tank like a knife through hot butter. To convince him further we showed him a few knocked-out tanks.

Even after that, Don did not take combat very seriously. He fell asleep standing up while on guard duty one night. He caught it from the next soldier scheduled to go on duty, who had slept about an hour into his shift. When he went to relieve Don, Don was still asleep. The next night the sergeant in charge handed Don a hand grenade and told him to hold on to it very tightly. Then the sergeant pulled the pin. A hand grenade will not explode until a release mechanism is activated -- which cannot happen as long as the mechanism is held in a clenched fist. The sergeant told Don that he would return to put the pin back when Don's shift was over. He didn't wait that long, of course, because if Don had relaxed his hand he would have dropped the grenade and killed himself and anyone else nearby. Don got the message!

There was another incident involving Don. It happened when our platoon was off the line for a few hours. We had been fed a hot meal and were about to take off. Don had to get from the mess truck back to the platoon, and he was late, as usual. An eight-inch howitzer battery was dug in nearby. Don saw a shortcut -- right in front of the big howitzers. Just then the battery had a firing mission. A firing mission is always carefully timed. Don ambled in front of the guns and held up his hand to signal that he wanted the fire held

until he was past. The air was blue with the expletives of the battery commander! Even then, Don did not move very fast. So far as I know, Don survived the War without mishap.

A lighter side to Don's early days with the 25th involved his singing. We asked him what songs were popular in the States when he left. We had not heard any new music for a long time. The first song Don sang for us was *Don't Fence Me In.* He was awful, and we never did learn what the music of the day was. Don was a good-natured kid, though. We all liked him and tried to keep him out of harm's way.

One cold night we were all bedded down in a barn. We were warm and snug. I did not want to get up for guard duty, but I had to. I groped for my boots, found them at the foot of my sleeping bag, got dressed, and then stumbled out toward our tank. The tanks in our platoon were drawn up in a line facing a clump of woods that was about a quarter-of-a-mile away. The forest provided natural concealment for German gun emplacements, so we were uneasy about our position, especially at night. As I left the barn and approached the line of tanks, I noted some activity. Several shapes (Ours or theirs? I did not know!) were moving about in front of the tanks and toward the woods. I walked quietly and soon noticed that the indistinct forms were our guards. There had been a snowfall the previous afternoon, and the snow between our line of tanks and the woods was clean and untouched. The guards were out in front of the tanks, scooping clean snow into their canteen cups.

There were three kinds of K rations, one for each meal of the day. Each had a different drink -- coffee for breakfast, lemonade for lunch, and hot chocolate for dinner. All of the drinks were made from powdered concentrate. The guards were using the nice clean snow and the lemonade powder to make lemon snow-cones. I reminded them that they could have been shot, either by someone on the new guard shift or by Germans in the woods. Having said that, I made a snow-cone, too.

One day Headquarters Company was issued a new weapon, a Sherman tank with a rocket-launcher[3] mounted on top of it. The launcher had eighty launching tubes arranged in four rows of twenty tubes each. I was picked to be commander of the new tank, an assignment I didn't relish. Somehow Frank got me out of it. How he managed I do not know, but he protected all of his platoon from being drafted into the new crew. We all wanted to stay away from the rocket-launcher tank because it would draw German artillery fire as soon as it fired any rockets. The Germans had a similar terror-inciting weapon; they called it the *Nebelwerfer.* We supposed our rocket-launcher also had a scare-tactic purpose, for both fired many rocket-propelled artillery rounds at once. The sound of all that artillery coming in at the same time was terrifying!

Our troop movements in February and March were dictated by the attempted thrusts of the Germans. We were on the defensive and reacted more than acted. Because we moved a lot, the supporting tactical air units became confused. Each of our tanks had an identification panel that was laid across its back deck The panels were bright pink and were supposed to be easy to spot from the air. A squadron of Lightnings, Lockheed P-38 fighter planes, strafed us one bright day when we had the identification panels in place. We fired back, and soon the planes left. They did no damage, and neither did we -- but the incident made us angry. We later learned that the pilots were all new and very young. They caught 'buck fever,' *i.e.* they shot too quickly in the excitement of the moment, but to us they seemed to have little excuse for shooting at friendly troops!

Sometime in March, we came into contact with the French troops in Alsace. They had been busy south of Strasbourg, in the Colmar Pocket. As the Germans pulled back, the whole of Alsace began to open up. One action I remember as particularly disturbing. The French tank commanders rode on the outside of their tanks and acted like movie cowboys. Their practices may have been flamboyant, but they were also dangerous. The French tanks and tank

---

[3] The Sherman tank was a versatile vehicle. Besides its intended purpose as a fighting machine, it was adaptable to many other tasks. A rotating drum with huge chains attached could clear mine fields without harm to its occupants. With a bulldozer blade mounted on the front, it could move all manner of debris out of the way.

destroyers were with us when we went into action someplace in northern Alsace. The French chose to fight in the open, disdaining the use of any natural cover. They lined up their vehicles on a ridge, exposed to the enemy, and they were picked off one by one. We hated to see that, but we were powerless to help. The Frenchmen were veteran troops and should have known better.

The French troops with whom we fought were supposed to be given a prominent role in the northern Alsace fighting. Gen. de Gaulle wanted to be assured that the French would be regarded as heroes in the defense of Strasbourg. We cared little about the politics: we just wanted to be away from the French troops. They were not with us long, and soon we were back to fighting with other American divisions.

Strange and interesting things happen when a war is fought in places occupied by civilians. I am not familiar with the breeding practices of the Alsatian farmers, but I think that spring is calving time for them. Right in the middle of the War, we witnessed a farmer assisting his cow in delivering her calf. I had grown up in the country but had never seen the birth of a farm animal. The farmer and his neighbors worked hard with the cow until finally a cute little calf was born. We all cheered. Somehow it seemed especially appropriate that amidst all the killing, a new life came into that village. I know it was only an animal, but it was all we had. I never encountered the birth of an infant during all the fighting, but life goes on, and there were babies born in Alsace in 1944 and 1945.

The second week of March we began what would become our last move through northeastern Alsace. One day when we were going over our old battlefields, we went about thirty miles without much resistance. On other days we had to fight for a town two or three times. But we were convinced that we would soon break out and get to the Rhine. We passed by Rittershoffen with its bitter memories and headed towards some small towns north of the Hatten-Rittershoffen area. We encountered stiff resistance around Altenstadt. The German artillery and *Nebelwerfer* pounded us. Frank Reissner, our new platoon leader, and Ed Kistner, his Jeep driver, were caught in the open while looking for new positions for our platoon. When the artillery barrage lifted, Ed

looked for Frank but could not find him. He had been wounded and evacuated by medics from the 36th Infantry Division. I felt bad about Frank. After sharing quarters with him, I felt I knew him as a friend. His injury left the platoon leader's spot open again. I inherited the position for the time being.

Shortly after being appointed acting platoon leader, I was assigned the point position for a move -- in a Jeep!! Jeeps had been used as point vehicles before, but they were usually from the Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon. I was especially wary of riding in a Jeep because of one particularly diabolical enemy tactic. Many Americans folded the windshields of their Jeeps down -- in the style of a 1920s roadster. When the Germans saw that, they strung piano wire across the road about as high as the neck of an average-sized rider or driver. If the Jeep were moving very fast, the piano wire would decapitate all the people in the front seat. To counter their tactic, all American Jeeps had a vertical bar welded to the front bumper. At the top of the bar was a hook that would prevent the wire from sliding over the top. The Germans then used the same wire as 'trip-wire,' that would set off explosives in the road. No wonder I did not want to ride in a Jeep with nothing in front of us!

My driver was Ed Kistner. He was very good and had experience driving under fire. He and I led the whole battalion as well as some infantrymen attached to the battalion. It was a sunny spring day. Had it not been for the War, we might have enjoyed the nice drive in the country. Everything went well for the first few miles. A large building that looked like a school appeared on our left; after the building there was a crossroads. Ed hurried through the intersection, and almost immediately an artillery shell landed a few yards from it. Ed and I abandoned the Jeep and virtually flew into the ditch. The Germans had the crossroads 'zeroed in,' and they had observers in the schoolhouse. They had plenty of time to adjust their artillery to hit exactly when and where they wished.

Now we were on one side of the crossroads, and the rest of the battalion was on the other. After a while I crept back to the Jeep and got on the radio. I spoke to the battalion commander, and he halted the column before it got to the dangerous spot in the road. Next we had to locate the German guns and return

some artillery fire in an effort to still them. We actually *wanted* the Germans to fire again so we could locate their guns. We had to tempt them. Ed and I in the Jeep were to be the bait. We turned around and headed for the intersection again. A few yards from the lethal zone, Ed gunned the engine, and we shot through -- as if running a gauntlet. We accomplished our purpose: the Germans fired and gave away their positions. Our artillery observers had come forward almost to the crossroads. Our own Assault Gun Platoon went into action and gave covering fire so the column could pass through. I do not know that we actually destroyed the German artillery batteries: I do know we silenced them.

About March 20, we found ourselves back in the familiar surroundings of Kapsweyer. The place was no more hospitable to us the second time there than it had been on the first. In preparation for our advance into the dragon's teeth and the Seigfried Line, our artillery units fired a huge barrage. The big guns from Corps Artillery were there, as well as our own 105mm and 155mm guns. The big ones were 8-inch howitzers and 240mm rifles. All that artillery drew counter-fire from the German batteries. The noise of the combined artillery fire, both outgoing and incoming, was deafening. The preparations for our next assault on the vaunted West Wall, *i.e.* the Seigfried Line, went on for several days. A troop of the 94th Cavalry was with us, but it was not Harvey's outfit. Their mission was to probe the German defenses and report their findings to our Command Post. Our own Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon was also busy snooping around the outskirts of the next town. The cavalry, along with a squad of engineers[4] from the 125th Engineer Battalion, crept up to the first row of dragon's teeth. The engineers blew up that first row. They determined that it would be too difficult to blow up all of the teeth, so some other method of getting into town had to be devised. They decided to build a treadway bridge across the tank traps and the dragon's teeth. They built the bridge while under constant enemy fire. All during the preparation time, our platoon was parked on the outskirts of Kapsweyer and facing

---

[4] John Copes was among them. For the incident of his watch, see Chapter VII, *Into Germany -- and Back,* footnote 9.

Steinfeld. We were firing almost constantly, and we were drawing counter-fire all the time.

Finally, on March 22, we made a direct assault on Hitler's West Wall. During one nighttime barrage, we took off down the road to Steinfeld and the Seigfried Line. I cannot imagine why we would want to leave at night, but we did. Armor is *never* supposed to move when it is dark. Kapsweyer and Steinfeld are separated by nothing but open fields. There was no natural cover, so we were completely exposed. The days were getting warm, and the spring thaw made the fields wet and soft. The column had to stay on the road.

About half-way to Steinfeld the whole landscape lit up. The Germans had fired flares that illuminated the fields on both sides of the road. In addition to the flares, enemy artillery shells were exploding all over. The fields and the road were bright as day. We were sitting ducks. We could do nothing but go on and hope for the best. The tanks were to cross the dragon's teeth on the recently-erected treadway bridge. Before we had cleared the dragon's teeth, we came to a stop at the outskirts of Steinfeld. A mortar shell hit one of the tank trailers.[5] The mortar shell did not detonate the ammunition in the trailer, but it did start a fire that could ignite the whole trailer. Al Crawford, the commander of the tank to which the trailer was attached, got out of the tank and proceeded to unhitch the burning trailer. I was outside of my tank, trying to find a way through the dragon's teeth. When I saw what was happening, I ran to help Al. By the time I reached him, he had already gotten the trailer hitch unhooked. He and I managed to move the burning trailer into a ditch.[6] About then the artillery fire increased, and I headed for cover. I hurried through the open cellar door of the nearest building. My action was foolhardy, but I was fortunate: there were no Germans in the cellar. I made the same impulsive move into the Kapsweyer pillbox in December; I was lucky then, too, for it was empty. This time I found American GIs.

---

[5] The AG had 105mm cannons, and the line company tanks had 76mm guns. Because of the frequent use of our tanks as artillery pieces, we needed more ammunition than the line company tanks, so some AG tanks towed ammunition trailers. The trailers made backing up difficult for the drivers, and the danger of their blowing up made the ammo trailers unpopular.

[6] Al received a citation for his quick response in this potentially dangerous situation.

Our mortar platoon had been firing mortar shells of smoke to hide our movements. They especially wanted to 'blind' the enemy troops in the nearest gun emplacements. Most of the houses at the edge of town were camouflaged pillboxes. They were innocent-looking farm buildings, but when artillery shells hit their sides, their tiles crumbled off and revealed six-foot-thick reinforced concrete walls. The windows came away and exposed gun ports arranged in tiers. The smoke mortar shells were concentrated on the streets that had 'houses' from which we had received fire. Confusion reigned. The mortar platoon people were pinned down by heavy artillery and mortar fire, and smoke from their own shells had drifted back onto them. The whole platoon -- with all of its gear, including mortar and ammunition -- crowded into the cellar. The men didn't notice where they were when the severe shelling started, so they were lost and afraid to venture from the relative safety of the cellar.

The enemy seemed to be all around us. I waited until there was a lull in the firing to tell the men that I had a pretty good idea of how to get back to our lines. I seem to have a natural 'feel' for topography, and I thought that I could grope my way. We took off single file. I felt sorry for the ammunition and mortar bearers, who had to carry heavy loads plus their own weapons, but the platoon leader did not want to leave anything behind. My first stop was a bad one: we were right in front of a house that turned out to be a camouflaged pillbox. I went back to the rear of the platoon to see that everyone was with us. After a lot of running through streets and alleys, I finally got the platoon to where it belonged. There they could set up their mortars and fire. I then had to find my own way back to my own platoon.

In another part of town, an A Company tank inadvertently fired toward a D Company platoon. There were a lot of mixed-up orders, and the scene was like the cartoon of an unorganized stampede with cattle running in all directions. Unfortunately, in all of the confusion Lieut. Klinefelter was seriously wounded, perhaps by friendly fire. It was either reported or rumored that one of Lieut. Martin's A Company tanks had made the goof. I sincerely hoped not. I liked Lieut. Martin, and I knew him to be a courageous and cautious soldier.

Our battalion fought its way through the few fortified German towns on the west side of the Rhine. The Germans began to surrender in numbers. Those who continued to fight retreated to other positions and eventually tried to get to the east side of the Rhine.

In our pursuit of the enemy, we found ourselves assigned to a mission with some Algerian troops. The Algerians wore colorful uniforms, and some rode horses. Most of them were very tall, and all of them were very black. It was rumored that at night they would crawl among the foxholes in or near 'no-man's land' and quietly reach in and feel the helmets. If a helmet were the wrong shape, its owner had his throat slit. Such stories may sound very interesting and dramatic, but there was a down-side to the Algerians' being with us. We could not stay in any town at night. The Algerian troops were hard to control, and they looted and raped with little regard for the Geneva Convention. Once, in the process of flushing out retreating Germans, I cautiously entered a house and found nobody there. Some of the Algerians followed me. There was a beautiful grand piano in one of the rooms, and I was tempted to play it. But I remembered the training lectures that warned of booby traps and stayed away. One of the Algerians, who had probably never heard a word about booby traps, moved toward the piano, and I dove for cover. Fortunately for him -- and me -- the piano was not wired to blow up.

After breaking through the Seigfried Line, our 25th Tank Battalion reverted to Combat Command R, the combat command usually kept in reserve. I thought it strange that we moved north to go into reserve because north seemed the direction of the most action. The Germans were frantically trying to cross the Rhine, so the front lines became ill-defined. German units were in chaos, but we were not able to take advantage of their vulnerability. Our battalion stopped in Pirmasens, where we cleaned vehicles, did the necessary repairs, wrote letters, and awaited orders.

Col. Watson, the battalion commander, was gone for a few days, and Major Howard Philips, the battalion executive officer, assumed temporary command. Two tanks from our platoon and two tanks from Company B were parked in the same courtyard. Maj. Philips did not like that and ordered us to move at least

two of them. Any concentration of tanks was a target for the enemy. The 'exec' was exactly right, and we all knew it. The tanks were duly moved, and Maj. Philips was happier for our effort.

The tanks had been parked together for the convenience of the crews. Fellows from several of them met nightly for poker and bridge games. The safety of everyone concerned should take precedence over the proximity of the game tables, but we were getting sloppy. Officers like Maj. Philips had to bring us into line. I played in some of the games, read a little, and wrote letters to all of my correspondents.

The Rhine crossing was to be the next big event, but not one of us knew when it would be. Even if I had known, I could not have written about it.

Thou hast been a shelter for me and a strong tower from the enemy.

... Psalm 61:3, KJV

Chapter XI

Götterdämmerung

Götterdämmerung means *twilight of the gods.* It is the title of the fourth and closing opera in the *Ring* cycle by Richard Wagner. The term has come to denote the collapse of any political or social system that deludes itself into self-aggrandizement. The leaders are usually self-proclaimed heroes or 'gods.' One of Adolph Hitler's favorite musical works was Wagner's *Ring.* He would attend the Bayreuth festival and identify his inner circle as a pantheon of deities.

After the Germans under Field Marshall von Rundstedt failed to break through to Antwerp in the Battle of the Bulge or to the Verdun-Paris plain in Operation *Nordwind,* the tide turned in favor of the Allies. It was obvious to everyone that in a matter of time Hitler's *Thousand Year Reich* would come to a premature end -- by about 990 years! The 'handwriting was already on the wall' after the successful landings on the beaches of Normandy in June, 1944. However, the Germans were stubborn, and much fighting still would be required before Hitler and his henchman would capitulate. It is harder to stop an altercation, be it a minor spat or a war, than it is to start one.

Gen. Eisenhower's strategic plan for ending the War was not good politically. He considered Berlin to be of little strategic value. The city had no working factories, its German government was falling apart, and it was far removed from the arenas of action. Accordingly, Eisenhower directed the American First and Ninth Armies in the north to proceed toward Berlin at a slow pace; he was always careful to keep his lines well-ordered and to avoid unnecessary exposure. To him, Berlin was not worth risking men and resources.

However, Eisenhower might have done well to consider the international political situation. The Russians were permitted to get to Berlin and Vienna before the Western Allies, and because they 'liberated' those cities, they laid claim to predominance in occupational matters. President Roosevelt and Prime Minister Churchill would have done well to intervene and counsel Eisenhower about the importance of taking Berlin and Vienna.

Because there was a possibility of the Nazis' holding out in an Alpine redoubt, the U.S. Third and Seventh Armies made a giant swing, first to the northeast and then to the south, as they swept through all of Bavaria into Austria and Czechoslovakia. Some German die-hards put up stiff resistance at strategic points. Among the hold-outs, the most fanatic were the SS troops. They fought as if they could still win the War. The battles for Nürnberg and the Danube cities of Ingolstadt and Regensburg were especially fierce, but Munich and Berchtesgaden offered only token resistance. Many of the German troops, especially the young people and old men, were only too ready and anxious to surrender.[1]

---

[1] Boys as young as nine and girls only seventeen or eighteen were all made to bear arms for Germany.

Fighting continued even after Hitler's suicide, but his death in the Berlin underground bunker put to rest the rumor of a Nazi last stand in the Bavarian Alps. Joseph Goebbels, Germany's minister of propaganda, also died of his own hand in the bunker, and Allied authorities soon rounded up the rest of Hitler's inner circle.

During the fighting, the Allies came upon many prison camps, all horrifying, and release and care of prisoners became the concern of front line troops. They found Holocaust camps and camps for political prisoners -- Dachau and Buchenwald among them -- and Prisoner Of War camps such as Moosburg. Because the 14th Armored Division played a very important role in the liberating of prisoners, it became known as the *Liberator Division.*

The account of the division's liberation of the Moosburg Camp as written in the 47th Tank Battalion history reads:

> On April 29, 1945, Combat Command A, 14th Armored Division was stopped at the Isar River preparing for the assault on the Moosburg Prison Camp. At 0600, a strange group strode into Command Headquarters to meet the commander, General C.H. Karlstad. It consisted of a German major representing the commander of the Moosburg Allied Prisoner Of War Camp, Colonel Paul Goode of the US Army, a group commander of the British Royal Air Force, the senior American and British officers imprisoned in the Moosburg Camp, and a Swiss Red Cross representative. The German major carried a written proposal from his commander for the creation of a neutral zone surrounding Moosburg and for all movement of Allied troops in the vicinity of Moosburg to be stopped while representatives of the Allied and German forces confer on disposition of the Allied Prisoners Of War. The German proposals were rejected, and the party was given until 0900 to return to Moosburg and submit an offer of unconditional surrender or receive an Allied attack at that time. The Germans chose to fight, and by 1030, German SS troops were lying dead in the fields and the streets of the town. The American medium tanks were roaring towards the camp. The tanks broke right through the double barbed wire enclosure. There was some resistance from the guard towers, but the tankers quickly neutralized the towers by blowing them away with cannon fire. The official estimate of the total number of Allied prisoners released was 110,000. There were Americans, British, Canadians, Norwegians, Brazilians, French, Poles, Dutch, Greeks, Rumanians, Bulgarians, Russians, Serbs, Italians, South Africans, New Zealanders, Australians -- men from every nation fighting the Nazis. Among the prisoners were twenty-seven Russian generals and sons of four American generals. There were war correspondents, radio commentators, and three Russian women doctors. Also among the prisoners were eight of the 47th's own, soldiers from the very unit that opened the gates. One tanker freed his own son. Around the city were thousands of slave laborers, both men and women.
>
> All combined to give the 14th the most incredible welcome it had ever received. Tanks were slowed to five miles per hour as they went through the camps -- the press of prisoners was so great. The prisoners cried and shouted and patted the tanks. "You damned bloody Yanks, I love you," shouted a tall rangy Australian, and then he

threw his arms around a Jeep driver. A weary bearded paratrooper climbed onto a tank and kissed the tank commander, tears streaming down his cheeks. There were many, many more scenes of extreme emotion.

The 47th Tank Battalion and the 68th Armored Infantry uncovered almost a score of arsenals in the town. There were machine guns, pistols, rifles, *Panzerfausts,* and ammunition.

That night many of the newly freed prisoners roamed the streets. They broke into liquor supplies in stores and bars and took food from restaurants and homes. They had Schnapps, Champagne, Cognac, wine, chickens, pigs, lambs, geese, hams, eggs -- whatever they could find. Ex-POWs and ex-slave laborers, ex-concentration camp inmates, soldiers and civilians, men and women, young and old, representatives from every nation in Europe, drunk or sober, crying or laughing -- they roamed the streets that night and reeled along the sidewalks -- singing, shouting, kissing, wearing tall silk hats gotten from who-knows-where, carrying stoves, chickens, geese, pictures, sabers, and even cross-bows. The German civilians hid behind shuttered windows.

The combat troops finally moved through the mad bacchanalia to cross the river. The care of the released prisoners was turned over to the rear echelon.

The liberation of a concentration camp was a grim chore. The 45th Infantry Division with supporting elements of the 14th Armored Division marched into Dachau, where they found the German machinery for Jewish genocide. The cremation ovens were still warm, the corpses of recently gassed Jews still in them. The Jews who were strong enough turned on their SS guards and killed them on the spot. The Americans found themselves having to stop the murder of the SS. Some of the SS troops donned prisoner clothes to avoid capture. What a poor ruse! They could hardly pass for prisoners, not when they were healthy and well fed! In the days following the liberation of the camp, some of the officials of the city of Dachau were made to assist in the burial of dead prisoners. They proclaimed innocence of any wrongdoing; they said they knew nothing of what went on in the camp.

Many well-known people were incarcerated in concentration camps. Elie Wiesel was interned in Buchenwald. He later became a writer and winner of the Nobel Peace Prize. The Dutch ten Boom sisters were imprisoned in Ravensbruck. Martin Niemoeller, a German pastor who protested the Nazi regime and was involved in a plot to kill Hitler, was sent to Sachsenhausen and later Dachau, where he was executed. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, a German theologian and pastor, was in the United States when war broke out and elected to return to Germany. He was held in Buchenwald and executed near the end of the War.

The United States Third and Seventh Armies continued their march south.

The War in Europe ended on May 8, 1945. The Allied Armies stopped fighting and took up occupation duty.

O thou enemy, destructions are come to a perpetual end.

... Psalm 91:6, KJV

Chapter XII

The Final Dash

Easter, 1945, fell on April 1, the day I crossed the Rhine River. It was also April Fool's Day, but hardly anyone noted that fact. We had more serious things to think about. For some days before we crossed the river we had little contact with the Germans. A few artillery rounds came in each day, and some nights 'Bed-Check Charlie,' the German pilot in the small reconnaissance plane, flew overhead, but most of the time we sensed no enemy activity. There were few poker and bridge games: most of the fellows read or simply engaged in quiet reflection. I thought of many things:

> *I wish that I could have gone to some Holy Week services. I haven't even seen a chaplain for weeks, and Easter is almost here. Would this be the last time that I would be away from home on this important day in the church year? Would the crossing be difficult? Our crews have some replacements. Would they hold up under fire? Why don't the Germans give up? Surely they know that they cannot win. If I get through this, will I have to go to the Pacific Theater? Letters from home are always cheerful. What do my parents know or suspect?*

Sometime in late March, it was rumored that some of us might be assigned to use a new amphibious tank recently brought into our area for the Rhine crossing. Other amphibious vehicles had met with mixed results in the landings in Normandy. The amphibious Jeep, known as a *seep,* seemed to work all right, but most tankers, myself included, were skeptical about driving anything bigger than a Jeep out into the water. In February, all of our platoon members managed to avoid assignment to the rocket-launcher tank, thanks to Lieut. Reissner, our platoon leader. Because he had been wounded, he was no longer on the scene, and we had no officer to speak for us. We squirmed a bit and hoped to avoid assignment to the amphibious tank.[1] As it turned out, no one from our platoon was drafted for amphibious duty.

---

[1] The duplex drive (DD) tank, an M4 tank with twin propellers, was used in the Rhine crossing by other units. An accordion-like canvas skirt that came up high enough to make visibility a problem could be inflated to give flotation to the whole Rube Goldberg devise. The 3rd Division used twenty-one DD tanks. Six did not make the crossing: one was destroyed by shellfire, one was stuck in mud, two had the canvas skirt come off before launching, and two sank. The 45th Division had fourteen DD tanks, all of which made successful crossings.

The Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon reconnoitered possible sites for crossing the Rhine. The Germans needed bridges to get as many men and as much equipment across the river as possible. The last bridge in our sector was at Germersheim. When the Germans had no more use for it, they destroyed it with pre-set charges of TNT. The Allied Forces crossed on a treadway bridge built by the Corps of Engineers. The engineers erected the bridge in the daytime while under fire from the enemy on the other shore. Tanks, tank destroyers, and infantry covered them. When we crossed and saw what they had done, we marveled at their bravery and skill. Installing the last part of the bridge near the German shore must have been especially harrowing.[2]

Our crossing was at Worms, a city rich in Reformation history. Sgt. Donges' tank crew was not complete, so I rode with him in my old loader spot. I preferred that to riding in a Jeep, the only alternative, because Jeep riders are very exposed. I had already had one unpleasant experience riding the point in a Jeep. We left the vicinity of Pirmasens sometime after midnight on April 1, and it was dawn by the time we moved down the river bank towards the bridge. Even though the enemy did not challenge our movement, I was uneasy about the crossing. The weight of a tank made the bridge sink a bit, and I felt as if we were riding in the trough of a wave. I was reminded of walking on 'rubber ice' in the spring when I was a boy, and I couldn't forget that I frequently broke through the ice -- especially if I stopped walking. I wondered if the treadway bridge would act like that rubber ice. If it did, the tank would break through the bridge and sink if it ever stopped. (Actually the tank would not have sunk had it stopped, but I'd have been hard to convince otherwise at the time.)

I hoped to see some places important in the Protestant Reformation,[3] but we moved through Worms and into the open countryside very quickly. I did notice that the town was severely damaged.

---

[2] It crossed my mind that I might have been one of them had my engineering studies in the Army Specialized Training Program been allowed to continue.

[3] Ruth and I visited Worms in 1980. The Reformation Memorial came through the War unscathed, even though every building around it was a mass of rubble.

We met no resistance the first day east of the Rhine. Our column of tanks and infantry went right through Darmstadt. At the edge of town we came across a monument honoring Baron Manfred von Richthofen, the World War I flying ace. von Richthofen became known as the 'Red Baron' for the color of his Fokker triplane. He is the same Red Baron as Snoopy's nemesis in Charles Schultz' comic strip *Peanuts.*[4]

The first night in Germany seemed strange. We occupied Gross Bieberau, a village east of Darmstadt and near the Main River. It was quite different from the Alsatian villages we had come to know and understand. There was no sign of the War. All of the buildings remained undamaged, and the town was neat and orderly. The Alsatian villages were farm communities, and all the houses had barns attached. Gross Bieberau houses were more modern and did not suggest a peasant population. White flags hung from all of the second-story windows. The flags gave us a false sense of security. I thought that most of the fighting was over and that the balance of our time in Europe would be easy. The next five weeks would show how wrong I was!

When night came, we were nervous, even with the apparent resignation of the townspeople, so we slept on or near our tanks instead of searching out billets in local homes. We wondered if die-hard German troops might emerge from the cellars. The night passed without incident, and our wonderful cooks had a hot breakfast ready for us the next morning.

We crossed the Main River at Wörth am Main (Worth on the Main River), near Aschaffenburg,[5] a well-known medieval city. We camped near the river the day before we crossed. Someone threw a grenade into the water (I'm not sure why!) and stunned a lot of fish. They rose to the surface, where we could easily pick them up. We had fresh fish for dinner. The Germans on the other bank also caught fish near their bank. We were wary of the enemy (as were they of us), so we grabbed our fish and quickly scrambled for cover. Eventually each

---

[4] Seattle's Public Broadcasting System featured the Baron in a program on flying during World War I.

[5] Ruth and I visited Aschaffenburg in 1985 and were privileged to see a famous painting by Matthäus Grünewald in the Stiftkirche. The painting is kept behind locked lead doors. The sexton opened them for us.

side recognized the other's intent, and no one fired a shot. The Germans and we had made a sort of 'grenade fishing' truce!

More uneventful days followed. We crossed the Main again at Gemünden, where we saw the first of many Displaced Persons we would see throughout our push east. DPs were always very courteous: they gave us the right-of-way as we approached and cheered as we went by. All of the towns flew white flags from their city halls. North central Germany is very pretty, and the weather was pleasant. We were getting complacent and naively assumed that we were no longer in any danger.

Sometime in early April, a group of Germans who had been hiding along the Autobahn ambushed one of the our artillery batteries. The main body of our column had already passed. Artillerymen are seldom called upon to fight as infantry so many of them did not even know where their rifles were -- though each of them had been issued one. These artillerymen acting as infantry acquitted themselves surprisingly well. They drove off the Germans without suffering any casualties themselves. The incident served as a reminder that the War was still going on.

One of the tanks in our column met an unusual fate. We were moving slowly along a narrow road that had a small stream running parallel to it. None of the tanks had room to maneuver, so all were vulnerable to attack. Suddenly the soft shoulder gave way, and the tank in front of mine slowly slid into the stream. It came to rest on its side in about four feet of water. All the members of the crew got out safely --

But half of the road bed in front of us was gone, and there was no room to go around the big hole. Just then a boy informed us that he had seen German SS troop activity in the nearby forest. Another tank commander and I scanned the woods with field glasses but could see nothing. Each of the tanks behind the hole was a sitting duck, and a concealed 88 could easily have picked off any one of them. Several tankers ran back down the column to look for a way out of the mess we were in. They found a way around the hole, but it went very close to the woods in suspect. Each tank gunner turned his tank turret around so he could cover other tanks. After about an hour of jockeying, we got back onto the main road. A reconnaissance squad went to see if there were any

Germans in the woods, and it did, indeed, find SS troops hiding there. They were flushed out and taken prisoner by a unit following us. The wet crew from the tank that went into the river rejoined us later that day. They had retrieved most of their belongings from the tank, and a Service Company unit even managed to get the tank out of the water several days later.

From Worms we moved in a general northeasterly direction. We went through Bamberg and took Lichtenfels on April 12. Lichtenfels was as far north as our battalion went. Coburg is located about twenty kilometers north of Lichtenfels and Bayreuth a little farther east. All these towns are part of the history and cultural heritage of the German people. Except for Coburg, which I knew from Reformation studies and history classes,[6] I knew nothing of any of these places.

There was a great deal of confusion among both the German and Allied Forces. The Germans frequently 'fell over each other' in trying to get out of our way. Similarly, we were chasing the fleeing Germans as fast as possible, and sometimes we ran over each other. In one village I saw two tanks, one German and one American, at the same intersection. Each had been hidden from the other by the house on the corner. Apparently each tank proceeded into the intersection and was surprised by the presence of the other. The gunner from each tank fired his big gun almost simultaneously. The result was strange. Both tanks were abandoned and out of action. The American tank was not damaged, but its crew members were all gone. The barrel of the rifle on the German tank was split open. A part of the barrel was stripped back like a peeled banana. We could only guess what had happened. The American's cannon shell may have caught the edge of the opening on the German cannon and stripped a side of the barrel back, or the German gun barrel may have been clogged with debris and blown itself apart. We never knew for sure. The incident was just one of the oddities of tank warfare.

At Haag, a town south of Bayreuth, our Service Company had to act as infantry. The company had pulled off the Autobahn and set up a bivouac position in late

---

[6] The Coburg Castle was Martin Luther's place of refuge during the Diet of Augsburg. Queen Victoria's consort was Albert of Saxe-Coburg.

In 1985, Ruth and I stayed in a pension in Bamberg and visited the Coburg castle one afternoon. We also toured saw the Wagner Museum in Bayreuth. We wanted to see the Wagner opera house, known as the *Festspielhaus,* but we could not get tickets.

afternoon. The men were going about their ordinary chores when two boys approached a corporal and told him that a large number of German soldiers was in the nearby woods. Captain Arnold H. Green, the company commander, believing that his company might be the victims of a trick, was super-cautious. He assembled a force of twenty-five men and followed the boys into the woods. After a short walk, they broke into a clearing and came upon a German supply depot. They captured 433 German soldiers and ten women -- without firing a shot. Some of the men picked up German Luger pistols as souvenirs.

After several skirmishes around Bayreuth, we headed southwest toward Nürnberg on the Autobahn. The city was famous for the Nazi Party rallies held in the huge stadium. Some units of our battalion were scheduled to join the 45th Infantry Division in Nürnberg to participate in a victory parade. In the midst of preparations, word came down from Division Headquarters that we were to move again. We bypassed the city on the east and saw nothing of historic significance.

The planners of the victory parade assumed that taking the city would be easy, but it turned out to be very difficult. Nor was our way simple. Our immediate objective was the Danube River. We hoped to find some bridges intact so that getting past it would not be so difficult as crossing the Rhine had been.

Before considering the next action, please note the backdrop and the cast of characters, *i.e.* the makeup of the tank crews in our Assault Gun Platoon, in the dramatic sketch. As mentioned before, Lieut. Reissner, the platoon leader, was wounded near Wissembourg on March 19, his wound sufficiently serious to disqualify him from returning to his platoon. A battlefield commission was then offered to several fellows, including me. No one accepted the commission, so we were without an officer platoon leader temporarily. Sometime after the Rhine crossing, one Lieutenant H---- was assigned to us. The new platoon leader wanted to ride in a tank, so I relinquished my position to him. Sgt. Donges had a tank with an empty spot, so I rode with him or in a Jeep. Eddie Berg, the driver in our original crew, was the driver in Sergeant Jim Anderson's tank. Technically speaking, Jim should not have been in a tank because his Military Occupation Specialty number identified him as an artillery mechanic. But he wanted to ride in a tank instead of a Jeep for awhile, and because he was

an able leader, no one objected. In other words, I should have been in a tank with our original crew, and Jim should have been riding in a Jeep.

We were going straight south on the main north-south Autobahn. German ME 109 planes bombed and strafed us, but we suffered no casualties. We ran into trouble about twenty kilometers south of Nürnberg. A C Company tank led the column; it was followed by the Assault Gun Platoon. When the point tank reached a road junction near Gogglesbuch, it was knocked out by a well-hidden German 88. The next tank was the one for which I was nominally the commander, but Lieut. H---- was in charge. The Germans let that tank through. The tank commanded by Jim Anderson with Eddie Berg as driver followed and was hit by the same anti-tank gun. The 88 armor-piercing shell entered the left side of the tank just above the track. It went right under Eddie's seat. He lost both of his legs.[7] The shell went across the tank and exploded in front of Gilbert Chapman, the assistant driver/bow gunner. The exploding shell killed Gil. The tank began to burn, and the other three crew members were severely burned. When we saw what was happening, several of us ran towards the burning tank. While trying to help, we were under constant machine-gun fire because the tank and the area around it were still under siege. I got part way into the tank and helped to get the gunner out. Jim Anderson managed to crawl out by himself. Ed Kistner, a Jeep driver, pulled the loader out. I was most concerned about Eddie Berg because he was from our original crew. The medics arrived shortly and wrenched Eddie loose. With their litter-bearing Jeeps they were able to evacuate all the wounded at one time.

When Carl Phillips, our gunner, came back from the hospital after his illness,[8] he saw the results of the action and thought his entire old tank crew had been killed. If Carl had been with us and we had all been together, things might have worked out that way. Carl's illness and the subsequent crew juggling spared some of us our lives but lead to awful consequences for others. That

---

[7] Eddy died in the veterans' hospital in St. Cloud, Minnesota. Had I known in time, I would have visited him. I only learned of his being in central Minnesota after he died.

[8] See Chapter IX, *Hatten-Rittershoffen,* page 91.

was the action for which Ed Kistner and I were recommended for Silver Star citations.

A tank under the command of Sgt. Winslow was supposed to go through '88 junction,' a place highly infested by Germans. Dick Keskey, a friend of mine, was the driver of the Winslow tank. Dick told me years later that Sgt. Winslow refused to take his tank through the junction after he realized that the Germans could pick it off. He was reprimanded for his refusal.

A tank destroyer was brought up to fire on the German gun. The tank destroyer was knocked out immediately, and the crew was fired upon by artillery as they jumped to safety. The enemy gun had to be located and taken out if we were to proceed. A captain, the commander of B Company, and his driver went forward on foot in an effort to spot the gun. They were soon pinned down by machine-gun fire. The captain was killed by a sniper, and his driver narrowly escaped. Before the captain died, he stopped Sergeant Dean Rumburg,[9] a liaison between the battalion and the line companies, to tell him of the gun position.

After the medics had evacuated all of the wounded from the knocked-out tanks, I tried to get back to the head of the column -- or what was left of it. Unfortunately, I was on the wrong side of '88 junction.' There were several of us stragglers, and each of us took off on his own. I thought I could make it back after dark, but I never got to try. The Germans kept the junction under machine-gun and artillery fire, so I had to make my way to the Battalion Command Post, which was several miles back. There was some traffic going that way, and I caught a ride. When I arrived, there was another battle going on!

A German counter-attack was in progress near Allersberg. Our tanks and infantry had a good position overlooking the approaches to the town. We were on a ridge, the highest point of land in the area. When I arrived in the town of Altenfelden, I went to the Battalion Command Post, where I was told to get up

---

[9] In the summer of 1949 or 1950, I read that Dean Rumburg died in an automobile accident that happened between Spokane and Pullman, Washington. Dean was returning to school at the end of summer. He played football at Washington State University, so the account of the accident was on the sports page.

to the ridge because more crewmen were needed there. As I approached the line of tanks, I saw a corporal jump up onto Col. Watson's tank and begin to fire the 50-caliber anti-aircraft machine gun. He had to shoot: the Germans were coming right at us. They made no effort to take cover, and they maintained a nearly straight line. Finally, they broke and ran -- but not before suffering many casualties. There was speculation that they may have been drugged.

I sensed that the counter-attack was not over. The tanks from Gogglesbuch were summoned to Altenfelden. The anti-tank gun must have been knocked out, for all the tanks made it past '88 junction.'

Occasionally someone has to leave the relative safety of a tank and make a reconnaissance on foot because the crew cannot see very well from inside a tank. This was one of those times. We had to know what was over a ridge, especially in the area immediately in front of our line of tanks. The ridge fell away steeply, so we could see nothing beyond our enclosed positions. Usually the tank commander does the reconnoitering.

One of the tanks on the ridge was under the command of Lieut. H----. I tried to get his attention by banging on the side of his tank. I did not want to get up onto the back deck for fear of exposing myself to sniper and machine-gun fire. After getting no response, I had to go up and open the tank commander's hatch. Lieut. H---- was terribly frightened and did not want to move. I used stronger language than was prudent, and he called my conduct insubordination and threatened court martial. He saw to it that I lost my rank temporarily, but a colonel spoke up for me. He had seen and heard enough of the incident to witness in my behalf. But the fight was not over.

A few days later, the colonel asked to see me. I thought that I was in big trouble. I knew Lieut. H---- felt that he had every right to charge me. I had been angry, exposed to enemy fire, and impatient with him. The colonel did little more than advise me to be a more careful in my speech. I was restored in rank, and no more was said of the incident.

Lieut. H---- was the first officer whom I ever met, or even heard of, to whom an unusual rule applied. In the Army of that day, an officer was advanced in pay after a certain length of time -- even if he were not advanced to a higher

grade -- as a reward for his putting in time. It was said that Lieut. H---- was a second lieutenant getting a first lieutenant's pay. The lieutenant was, in fact, at a terrible disadvantage. He was a replacement only recently arrived in Europe. With little or no battle experience, he was supposed to lead seasoned troops -- not a good position to be in!

After the incident at Altenfelden, Lieut. H---- was not very popular and did little to endear himself to anyone. He was arrogant and something of a braggart. One evening not long after my run-in with him, some of us started a poker game. I needed some cash to get into the game, so I offered a dress sword I had taken off a captured German officer for sale.[10] The lieutenant offered to buy it. He said he wanted to be able to tell his children and grandchildren about the time he relieved a German colonel of his dress sword. There was no way that I was going to let him have my sword! I sold it to someone else for less than he offered, and I made the deal in his presence.

There were Germans in the forest to our left, so there was a real possibility that they could get around our flank and reach our supply depot near Nürnberg. Once again our Service Company was pressed into service as auto and tank mechanics became infantrymen. They did the job: they routed the Germans in the woods.

Eventually the combined firepower of all of our tanks, all our mortar platoon, and all of one division's artillery batteries forced the Germans to retreat. How tragic that the Germans held out when they obviously could do little more than harass us, all the time killing people on both sides!

After the events at Gogglesbuch and Allersberg, we continued down the Autobahn toward the Danube River. Sometimes we moved too fast to tend to personal care. One morning, after sleeping in the tank, I had the 4:00-6:00 A.M. guard shift. Rather than go back to bed at 6:00 A.M., I decided to clean up. We were parked next to a stream. I shaved and bathed with icy water, but I felt better. A cold-water shave is hard on the skin.

Later that day we arrived in a town with a school. We took over the bright and airy dormitories. We were becoming careless. We supposed that the Germans

---

[10] Dumb move! The sword would be a great War souvenir now.

would offer little or no resistance, and we expected the War to be over sooner than it was. That night we had to leave the best quarters we had had in a long time because of a heavy enemy artillery barrage. So much for thinking the War was finished! We still had a ways to go.

Several days later we arrived at Ingolstadt on the Danube. Our sector of the city had suffered some damage, but it wasn't bad. Another GI and I went poking around in some apartment buildings located in what appeared to be a middle class neighborhood. There we learned how German city folk lived. We walked through the unlocked doors of an apartment that was nicely furnished. It gave evidence of recent use. We noticed that there was no portrait of Hitler on the wall. At the time, many German homes displayed Hitler's picture, just as many American homes displayed Roosevelt's. We wondered if perhaps the tenants had discarded the usual Hitler picture when it became apparent that the War was ending and American troops would soon arrive.

Special Services arranged a treat for us on our only night in Ingolstadt. We got to go to the movies. The film starred Elizabeth Taylor in *National Velvet,* the film that launched her career. I thought that it was a great movie.[11]

We crossed the Danube, neither beautiful nor blue at Ingolstadt, and proceeded in a southerly direction. Some of our division went southeast, and some went southwest. Our division was officially part of the Third Army at the time. (All the while we were in Germany we were on the left of Gen. Patch's Seventh Army or on the right of Gen. Patton's Third Army. We never knew which Army we were in. Certainly, the 'big brass' knew, but we didn't -- nor did we care!)

We had one crew member that was extremely paranoid. I cannot recall his name or when he was assigned to my tank, but I do remember what he looked like. He was among the replacements assigned to us after the Gogglesbuch and Allersberg actions. Somewhere south of Ingolstadt, we came upon a train on a railroad siding. My paranoid tanker jumped out of the tank and positioned himself with the 50-caliber machine gun mounted on the

---

[11] I saw only two movies during the War, so I guess I would think any movie was pretty good. Movies were more common after the War.

turret. He started to shoot at the train. He intended to spray the train from one end to the other. I had to restrain him. I am almost certain that the train, a civilian train posing no threat, was empty, so he did no harm. After I stopped him, I had the driver proceed to the tracks so I could get out and poke around a bit. I found no sign of life. I was probably in more danger from our tanker with 'buck fever' than I was from the enemy!

Our way south was hurried and haphazard. At least so it seemed to me. Many times we were out of visual or radio contact with other parts of our platoon. Once we came to a river we thought to be the Isar,[12] with a bridge that looked to be undamaged. I was suspicious, so I left my tank to examine it. Just then several bearded and disheveled men came out of the woods to our left. They frightened me, and I immediately ordered them to put up their hands. I spoke in both English and German. They smiled broadly but paid no attention to anything I said.

I tried to make my wishes known in halting French. That didn't work either. Then one of them showed me a German Luger and even offered it to me. I was getting less suspicious now, for they seemed to be surrendering or even offering friendship. One of our crew suggested we give them pencil and paper, whereupon one of the bearded men eagerly drew a sketchy picture of a prison camp with guard towers and fences. He also wrote something. I recognized the lettering as being Greek. We then communicated in sign language and penciled pictures. One of the our guys admired the Luger. The Greek smiled and with signs offered to get another if we wanted it. He went off in the direction from which he had come, and a little while later we heard one shot. He soon returned with another Luger. I shudder to think how he got it. By that time we realized that our visitors were Greek prisoners recently escaped from a German prison camp. We knew that they must be hungry. The only food we had were D rations, which are very high-calorie chocolate bars. The Greeks ate them ravenously. We tried to warn them to take it easy because after a long time on limited food, they very likely would become ill from the rich bars. And

---

[12] The Isar runs through Munich.

they got sick! Fortunately we had re-established radio contact with the troops in the rear and were able to send for an escort to take the Greeks to them.

When we crossed the Isar River, we were assigned to support the 45th Division on our right. That division was in the Seventh Army, but I think we were still officially in the Third. Sometime during our march south we had recrossed the Isar and now approached Munich from the northwest.

It fell to elements of the 45th Division and its supporting troops to liberate the concentration camp at Dachau. No one knew anything about Dachau, so the horror of the camp was a shock to everyone. The details of my first personal encounter with the Nazi 'final solution' are sketchy and mixed-up at best. I find myself remembering impressions rather than being able to reconstruct any 'story line' of incidents.

A lot of infantrymen on foot were positioned ahead of our tanks at the Dachau entrance. Our tank was second in line after them. Many infantrymen from the 45th, who had been riding on tanks, dismounted and burst through the gate. At first there was a great deal of shouting and confusion, but we soon knew our tanks would not be needed for firepower. There would be no resistance. We were up in our tanks, not on the ground, so we did not become involved in the direct taking of SS troops or in the treatment of the prisoners. We were like spectators -- but none of us was prepared for what he saw.

Such scenes have been well presented in cinema and on television. Aside from the real footage that is frequently shown in documentary films, at least two movies give some idea of a concentration camp's terror. They are *Escape from Sobibor* and *Schindler's List.*

Anything you may have seen in such films -- be assured -- IS ALL TRUE! The behavior of the town's citizens was especially contemptible, and we were dumbfounded by it. They all pleaded ignorance of the goings-on inside the camp. The mayor and other local dignitaries were forced to go through the camp. A later incident, one that I did <u>not</u> witness, involved the removal of

bodies from the camp and carrying them in rude coffins to a suitable burial place.[13]

We left Dachau shortly after arrival. We were called back to our battalion and were no longer attached to the 45th Division.

Had we never been part of the 45th Division, we still would have been exposed to concentration camps. The 14th Armored liberated several satellite camps of Dachau and the huge Prisoner Of War camp at Moosburg. Because of our involvement in liberating efforts, the 14th Armored came to be known as the *Liberator Division.* Its news periodical still carries the name *Liberator.* Its official flag hangs among the flags of all U.S. Army units involved in the liberation of death camps in the foyer of the Holocaust Museum in Washington, D.C.

Hospital concentration camps[14] were located at Ecksburg and Ampfing near Töging, the town that our battalion occupied after the end of the War. When the fighting stopped, men from a company of the 84th Medical Battalion were sent to take over the two German hospitals. In them they found 300 former Dachau inmates, physically starved and mentally tortured. The company account read:

> Conditions were indescribably bad. Sanitation did not exist. There were no medical supplies and little food. Conditions were no better than those at the main Dachau camp. A few nuns from a neighboring convent were doing whatever they could to alleviate the terrible conditions. In about a week (American) medics had the place clean and in good order. For many of the patients, help had come too late.

The Military Police brought a male patient to C Company of the same battalion and told the medics to do whatever they could to keep him alive. He was a German officer suffering from a massive overdose of sleeping pills. The medics pulled him through, and when he finally regained consciousness, it was learned that he was the assistant commandant of Dachau. His suicide attempt didn't work. We heard no more about him but presume that he was tried in War Crimes Court.

---

[13] A famous picture in a May, 1945, issue of *Life* magazine shows the parade of well-dressed Dachau citizens carrying the open coffins. Each coffin is borne by four townspeople.

[14] A seeming contradiction in terms because prisoners were thought to get no care.

After we were detached from the 45th Division and returned to our battalion, we went back to 'business as usual,' still always ready to engage the enemy. The Germans offered just enough resistance to keep us alert!

One miserable overcast rainy day, we were attacked by an American P-47 Thunderbolt fighter plane with German markings. It was flying low and seemed to be losing altitude. Everyone fired at it with something, be it rifle, pistol, or machine gun but when it hit the ground, we did not know if we had shot it down or if it just ran out of fuel. It came down without lowering the landing gear but was still intact except for a bent propeller and damaged undercarriage. Our tank crew was first to the downed plane. The pilot was dead. He was wearing a strange combination of clothes: nothing matched, and his attire was not a uniform. He had no identification, not even dog tags. Some American air bases in the north had been captured by the Germans a few weeks earlier, and very likely the plane came from one of those bases. We reported the incident to a higher echelon of command, but we never heard anything more of either the plane or its pilot.

Rumors concerning the cessation of hostilities began to circulate in early May. Nonetheless, we remained in combat readiness, albeit somewhat sloppily. At last we got word that the War was over. Officially it ended on May 8, 1945. For one or two days after that we acted as if the War were still on. We were not sure that the enemy knew the War was over, and we did not want to be caught unprepared by some overzealous or unaware Germans.

Finally we were able to relax and proceed to our occupation assignment.

After offering prayers of thanks and breathing sighs of relief, we speculated about the future. Who would go home first? Would any of us have to serve in the Pacific?

Answers to these and many other questions would come soon enough. For the time being each of us lived in a state of euphoria, for each had his private thoughts about what he had done and what he had left to do.

He maketh wars to cease unto the end of the earth.

... Psalm 46:9, KJV

Chapter XIII

Occupation Duty

Töging and Fürstenfeldbruck

After the War ended, American troops became an Army of Occupation with few exceptions. Soldiers who had been in Europe a very short time were sent to the Pacific Theater, and soldiers who had been in Europe a very long time were sent home. All German cities and most German villages were occupied by American forces.

My first occupational duty was in the town of Töging, a pleasant Bavarian village about forty miles east of Munich. Headquarters Company of the 25th Tank Battalion was the main unit in the town, although some troops from A Company were stationed there as well. The town was untouched by the War because it was of no strategic significance, *i.e.* it had no factories, rail yards, or munitions depots. Töging was divided into three distinct districts. The main section of town included the business district and the churches and schools. The lower part of town at the bottom of a steep hill directly off the main street was mostly residential. Located just north of the main part of town was a group of small houses that were dwellings of a special kind.

The main part of town had two churches, Catholic and Lutheran. The Catholic church had an onion dome, and the Lutheran church a spire -- the usual pattern of church architecture in Bavaria and Austria.

When we arrived, many of the business places were open. Among them were a grocery store, a barber shop, and a shoe repair. The shoe repair deserves especial mention because many American officers had boots made to order by the cobbler. We had only our combat boots, and everyone wanted something a little nicer. The boots that the Töging cobbler made were good-looking and comfortable. I am sure he charged nothing but was usually given something. Items most in demand by the German people were sugar, coffee, and cigarettes. I do not recall seeing any enlisted men having boots made. I had a pair of plain

brown dress oxfords that my parents sent me while I was still in the States. I had carried them in my duffel bag all through Europe.

A small tributary to the Inn River ran through the lower town. We took our tank there to wash it, much as one would take his car to a car wash. A Displaced Persons camp lay adjacent to our tank-washing spot. Displaced Persons were people who had escaped or had been released from concentration camps and people who had to flee from their homes because of the War. The United States Army was trying to help them, but organizing such a massive effort is complex and slow. We soldiers tried to help them by bringing them whatever we could, but individual efforts were not enough. The plight of DPs in central Europe in the summer of 1945 was sad and even desperate. The Marshall Plan eventually corrected much of the hardship, but it was not implemented until the middle of 1947.

The third part of the town was a group of small cottages close to our quarters. We thought they were residences for townspeople until we learned that they had been built to house young women of good Aryan stock who were then mated with Aryan men, usually servicemen, in a selective genetic way. The village was one of Hitler's baby farms. Hitler frequently spoke of the Germans as the master race, and his selective breeding program was established to enhance the purity of Aryan stock. At War's end the women stayed in the houses because they did not know where else to go. Most GIs viewed the whole setup with revulsion.

We lived in Töging's main school, probably a gymnasium. (The word *Gymnasium* in the German educational system is a high school for students aspiring to enter a university, not a place for holding athletic events.) Our quarters were comfortable, but the sleeping arrangements were not very good. We slept directly on plywood, for the beds were without springs and mattresses. Admittedly, plywood was better than the ground or the floor of a tank, but we had hoped for something better. During the fighting we frequently slept on soft beds in homes, and now that the War was over we had to sleep on hard surfaces. 'Hardly seemed right!

Special Services supplied us with things like sporting equipment and books. We had only one radio for several rooms. I decided to remedy the situation by running wires from the radio to satellite speakers. I found wires and speakers somewhere in the building. I did the first speaker easily and was working on the next connection with both the radio and second satellite speaker turned on. Working on a radio plugged into the wall outlet was a big mistake! I got zapped. I forgot that Europe uses a 220-volt power system. I was not hurt, but I did no more 'hot' wiring after that!

Much of the school equipment was still in the building, including a piano in the main hall. There were several people in our unit who could play. Their music was a real morale boost! We knew no popular songs, but the radio helped us learn them. Armed Forces Radio had good programs, and the piano players would listen and pick up the tunes of the day. We had been out of touch for a long time, but it didn't take long for us to catch up with the rest of the world.

The town had some well-kept tennis courts on which Dick Keskey and I played almost daily. Special Services issued us the equipment we needed. I wanted to play baseball, but there was no Special Services organization for baseball in early May. Leagues were formed later, however, and I did get to play some. By autumn the Occupation Army had 'settled in,' and football was well organized.[1]

There was a stable with riding horses near our quarters. T.D. White,[2] the former first sergeant in our company, had been in the cavalry since the 1930s, before the cavalry was mechanized. Because he was familiar with horses, he became the self-appointed riding academy head. I had never ridden much, but I caught on quickly and had a great deal of fun riding through the nearby forests. I never rode alone because I was still uneasy around horses, even though these were quite docile. The fellows with whom I rode were probably

---

[1] I hoped that George Johnson enjoyed using the football that he got out of the tank in Gertwiller. He risked his very life for it!

[2] T.D. had no Christian name, only initials.

no more experienced than I. The road to the open country and woods where we liked to ride took us through the village north of town. Many of the women living in the enclave described above would come to their front gates, smile, and wave. They didn't seem to be particularly provocative -- just friendly.

Obtaining booze was a matter of concern to enlisted men. The officers had a monthly ration of spirits, but enlisted men had only a monthly ration of beer -- no hard liquor. The most available spirits were Hennesey brandy[3] and Calvados. Calvados is an apple brandy that packs a wallop. One day Cpl.[4] White, our erstwhile stable-master and horse authority, drank too much Calvados and tried to saddle a particularly stubborn horse. After much struggling, he got the saddle part-way on, tried to mount the animal, slid off, and held onto the horse's tail. The horse broke out of the stable and took off down the street with T.D. hanging on for dear life. Unfortunately nobody had a camera handy.

The Army instituted a non-fraternization policy as soon as we entered Germany. It mattered little from the time we came into the country until the end of hostilities on May 8: we had neither the opportunity nor the desire to fraternize with the locals during the fighting. However, after the War was over, there was a natural tendency to socialize with the people. The Army's fraternization ban was very strict. We were not to associate with the Germans at all. Penalty for violation of the ban was a $64.00 fine and possible court martial, though I never heard of any soldier who was fined -- much less court martialed. The ban, very difficult to enforce, was eventually dropped -- but for now it was still in effect!

The Army was quite concerned about morale. A sightseeing trip to Innsbruck, Austria, was arranged not long after our arrival in Töging. About fifteen of us

---

[3] One star, two star, or three star -- the more stars, the better the brandy!

[4] T.D. White, originally from the back hills of Kentucky, joined the Army during the Thirties. All but illiterate, he could write just well enough to file daily reports. With diligence he rose to the rank of first sergeant in the Regular Army. When the War made it imperative that any officer, commissioned or non-commissioned, be able to read and write, T.D. was made a private. According to the rules, he could have asked for a transfer, but he chose to stay with his unit -- and rose to the rank of corporal.

went. We traveled by truck -- not the most comfortable way to go, but Tauck tour[5] buses were scarce in 1945. The trip was pleasant. We stopped several times along the way.

The first stop was by a small collection of beautiful half-timbered chalet-like houses. I engaged a middle-aged man in small talk, thus risking the penalties of the fraternization ban. His was the first protestation of innocence I heard. He insisted that he had never agreed with the Nazis, that his neighbor might even have been a party member, but he certainly was not! The man asked me a strange question: he wanted to know why the American Army had not kept right on marching east when the War ended. He said that we would have to fight the Russians someday, and if we did it immediately, we could use the remnant of the German Army. Besides, we already had a large force on the European continent.

Another stop was at a rest area, hardly more than a wide spot in the road. There I saw the first of many mountain shrines, a figure of Mary in a small chapel-like construction mounted on a post. The little chapel was about the size of a large birdhouse. I saw many more shrines along mountain paths and roads during the occupation and again years later on trips to Switzerland, Germany, and Austria. Near the end of the day we dropped out of the mountains into the valley of the Inn River. There was an airfield on the valley floor, where many jet fighters were parked on the airstrip. We were told that the airplanes had been there for a long time -- just parked because the Germans had no jet fuel. (Thank goodness!)

We had sleeping bags and slept in a school. After a supper of rations that we brought with us, we settled in for the night. We passed the time with poker games and bull sessions.

The next morning we were in Innsbruck, a beautiful city in an Alpine setting. Innsbruck suffered very little bombing damage, so we felt like pre-War tourists.

---

[5] Tauck Tours is a first-class tour company. In October, 1991, Ruth and I took a Tauck tour through New England, New Brunswick, and Quebec.

I took off with two other fellows. The first street that we came to was Innsbruck's famous Maria Theresienstrasse. There we saw the classic 'postcard' view of the city with the Alps in the background. We visited the *Hofkirche,* the imperial church, built as a mausoleum for Emperor Maximilian but used as the burial place for many other Austrian monarchs as well. Next we saw the famous Golden Roof in a small baroque square. None of us knew very much about Innsbruck, either its history or its geography. We just happened to stumble onto places that are famous. The city had trolley service, so getting around was easy.

After lunch several of us walked to the cog railway. The trains had inclined seats to allow passengers to remain upright during the steep ascent. We rode the railway about half-way up the mountain, then caught a cable car that took us up to a very nice lodge and restaurant. There was also a ski hut where we paid no rent for use of skis, poles, and boots because we were wearing American uniforms. The fellow running the ski hut was most accommodating. Very likely he was an ex-German soldier and just a little frightened. Several lifts were running, and we had a great afternoon of skiing. Unfortunately, in all our playing around, we missed the last cable car going down the mountain and had to walk to the cog railway, take it to the city, and then find our way to our sleeping quarters. We didn't get back until early evening. It was almost dark.

After the Innsbruck trip everyone felt less hesitant about going to new places. There was little we <u>had</u> to do. The officers led us through the motions of military life -- drill, calisthenics, etc. -- but without much enthusiasm. It was easy to get a Jeep, so I used one to visit friends in neighboring towns and did some general looking around at the countryside.

The nearest town to the west was Muhldorf on the Inn River. It was larger than Töging and had some industry. There was a waterfalls in the river and a power plant nearby, where an American aluminum company owned a branch factory. According to the local point of view, the plant was never bombed because the Air Force had been instructed to spare the plant in order to protect American investment.

Other units of the 14th Armored Division were stationed at Neuötting and Altötting, two nearby towns. I visited both of them several times, mostly out of curiosity.

Of all the towns close to Töging, Burghausen was the most fascinating. The town is located on the Salzach River, which forms part of the boundary between Germany and Austria. Burghausen is perched on a narrow ridge about one-kilometer-long. It is famous as the site of one of the oldest and largest feudal castles in Germany. Harvey Sabinson was stationed in Burghausen, and I went to see him at my first opportunity. Harvey's quarters were in the castle. He was the most junior of all the officers in his unit, so his accommodations were the least desirable. He even slept on the floor. One would think that he could have found a bed somewhere in the largest castle in Germany. Harvey showed me around the castle, which was very interesting, but I found the town itself even more engaging. The lower section, situated on the river, had a very beautiful town square as its center. Many of the buildings were covered with colorful murals. The Catholic church was topped with the largest onion dome I had ever seen. In the lower town we saw an American Jeep with two sergeants and two local girls heading for a bridge over the river -- the most open and flagrant violation of the fraternization ban one could imagine!

On another occasion Harvey and I drove down to Wasserburg, a nice Bavarian town southwest of our general locale. First we went out into a nearby woods to do a little target practice with a .45-caliber pistol I was carrying. The noise probably scared the local populace.

Some Wasserberg girls were entertaining several big American soldiers in a social hall. The fraternization ban was still in effect and presumably a real threat. Still the GIs acted unaware of its restrictions. Even Harvey, an officer who should have turned them into the Military Police, failed to scare them. Harvey and I did not like the situation, so we left in a hurry.

In the first weeks after the end of the War, the men in the Occupation Army were nervous about the German people and the possibility of scorched earth

incidences.[6] We were especially concerned some die-hard Nazis might blow up a small power plant in our area. Two other soldiers and I were sent to look it over and guard it for a few days. We traveled light. The three of us went in one Jeep; we took only sleeping bags, food for a few days,[7] and some personal effects. The plant was steam-powered. It was in perfect condition but not being used at all. On the first afternoon at the site, I walked to a village about a half-mile away. I was the only American around, so I thought it highly unlikely that I would be caught fraternizing. It was a hot day, so I went to the only tavern in town to get a beer. The beer was a little watery, but it tasted good. Some older men were playing cards. I asked one old fellow if he played sixty-six.[8] He did, indeed! We played a few games, but I don't remember who won. I returned to the town several times, played some more cards, and drank some more beer. Eventually we three GIs went back to our unit. The power plant never seemed to be in any danger.

We had a lot of free time, so I visited many local places. On one of the outings, several of my friends and I went to Munich. I had passed through the outskirts of the city during the last days of the War but certainly did no sightseeing. We had no guide book, and we had no idea of what to look for. The first thing we stumbled onto was a museum on an island in the Isar River. The museum is not the city's main museum; it is devoted only to science and technology. Among the other things we saw were some airplanes parked at the main Munich airport. One airplane had a propeller at both its front and its rear. None of us had ever seen anything like it before. We called it a *pusher-puller airplane.* Many years later, I read about that very plane in a magazine devoted to World War II military aircraft.

---

[6] The term *scorched earth* refers to the practice of destroying one's own facilities in order to prevent the opposition from getting or using them. The expression *burning your bridges behind you* comes from the same source.

[7] I thought I would never again have to eat field rations!

[8] Sixty-six is a game derived from pinochle, which became popular in German communities. Most couples have a favorite two-handed game, and my parents especially enjoyed sixty-six. I learned it from watching them play. I was only guessing that the tavern habitués would know the game.

I made another trip to Munich about the same time for a reason other than sight-seeing. One morning several us were called in to Company Headquarters. One of the fellows thought we were to be reprimanded. Instead we were told to go to Munich in dress uniform for a medals presentation ceremony. There was to be lots of brass and a real 'spit and polish' parade on the Munich parade grounds. We got into dress uniforms quickly and reported to the truck that was to take us. The ceremony was scheduled for the afternoon. The driver dropped us at a building near the parade grounds, where we ate lunch. From there we went directly to the grounds. The ceremony was in conjunction with a review for Gen. Patton and other brass. The awards part of the program came early, so we did not have to stand at attention very long. There were to be many recipients of decorations, so the day promised to be endless.

But everything moved along very well. Only the citations for the highest decorations were read. Gen. Patton pinned some of the medals himself. I happened to be in the row he came down, so he pinned a Silver Star on me. He said nothing, but his aide congratulated everyone singly.

So I saw the great man up close again.[9]

Very soon after the end of the War, probably in the middle of May, 1945, I was sent to be interviewed by a selection board for admission to Officer Candidate School. I had already turned down a battlefield commission, so it should have seemed unlikely to the board that I would want to go to OCS. The War in the Pacific was not over, and the possibility of being sent there was not very appealing.

The interviews were held in a building on the Starnberger See [Starnberg Lake], a resort not far from Munich. There could be only one interview at a time, so those of us waiting in line got to enjoy the surroundings. Some of us took rowboats out onto the lake and did whatever else we could do to pass the time. I was accepted into OCS, but I chose not to go for reasons I have already mentioned. I knew before I went that I would turn down an appointment should I get one, but I liked the excitement of challenge. Besides, a day at

---

[9] I had seen Gen. Patton in Reidheim when he insisted that we remove sand bags from the sides of our tanks. See Chapter VI, *Baptism of Fire*, page 61.

Starnberger See was good incentive for going to the interview. The OCS was in very nice surroundings in Fontainbleau, near Paris.[10]

The Army announced the point system sometime in early summer. Each soldier was assigned points according to his length of service, his service medals, and his citations. One point was awarded for each month of service in the United States, two points for each month of overseas service, five points for each campaign medal or citation, etc. The required number of points for discharge when the system was first announced was very high. Men with very few points were sent to the Pacific Theater. Those in the middle stayed in Europe on occupation duty. I was in the middle category and considered myself lucky. I could not go home, but I would not be sent to fight the Japanese either. It turned out that the really fortunate men were the ones who were sent home for furloughs before being sent to the Pacific Theater and just happened to be in the United States on August 14, 1945, when the War ended. None of them was sent on, and they received early discharges.

When the point system went into effect, men were reassigned to different units. Membership in a unit was determined by points, not by military skills. Before I was sent home, I was assigned to two independent[11] tank battalions and a corps artillery battalion.

Before the breakup of the battalion, we made several moves as a unit. The first was to a village near Fürstenfeldbruck. We were housed in a castle, but it wasn't very romantic. The place had never been much and was run down. In another day it may have been owned by someone of lesser nobility. It had an inner court where the battalion parked some of its smaller vehicles. The second floor had a balcony around the entire court, and our rooms were off the balcony -- like a motel.

---

[10] Fontainbleau is the site of a famous palace, which is said to be more beautiful and interesting than the palace at Versailles. Ruth and I visited Versailles in May, 1995, but did not get to Fontainbleau.

[11] Not belonging to a specific armored division, such as the 25th.

Sometime on the way to Fürstenfeldbruck, our tank column went through the Munich town square with its famous *Glockenspiel* clock tower. We passed many other tourist sights in Munich, but most of us did not realize their significance.

About that time we picked up some new fellows. They had been in the village for a time, and we sort of inherited them. One fellow, a guy named Frank, stands out in my mind. He was good at dodging work. He had been overseas quite awhile but had managed to avoid front-line duty. His time in Europe was much like that of Eddie Slovik,[12] but he escaped Slovik's fate. The story he told was that he had to stay in the Army because he had a murder rap waiting for him when he got out. Frank said that he had been in a fight over a woman with a man in an alley of a southern town and stabbed him. He also said that he had two wives, one in the States and one in the village. He was the company barber. Barbers are known to talk a lot, so we all wondered how much of his banter was just that -- talk! Then he was caught stealing and cheating at poker. After that we kept our distance. Frank seemed like a nice guy on the outside. Someone said of him, "He'd give you the shirt off his back -- and steal it back that night." I had been in the Army long enough to avoid characters like him.

The combat veterans of the 25th who were still in the battalion had a special bond, almost like family. Frank's boasting of avoiding combat did not go over the way he thought it would, and he soon learned to shut up or risk more than just a bloody nose.

One day I decided to treat myself to something new to me, a shave by a barber. I certainly did not want to go to Frank, so I went into the village. The town had only one barber, a quiet fellow about forty years old. I was alone. The shop was empty when I entered, so I was taken immediately. I had no time to think about what I was doing. After I sat down I realized that the barber might well have been a German soldier, perhaps even a member of the SS. We talked a bit,

---

[12] Eddie Slovik was the only American soldier to be executed for desertion since the Civil War. He was executed in January, 1945, in the Vosges mountain town of St. Marie aux Mines. His story is told in *The Execution of Private Slovik,* a book by William Bradford Huie. Martin Sheen starred in a movie made from the book.

but I learned little about him. When he took the razor to my neck, I wondered if I should jump up and get out of there. He might have been a fanatic. Putting a razor to a GI's jugular vein would be very easy. I did not leave, and I got my shave. It cost about fifteen cents. One day I met the barber in the street. We exchanged pleasantries, and he asked me to come back for a haircut and shave on the house. I never went back. Maybe I should have. He didn't have much business.

We did not stay in Fürstenfeldbruck very long. The whole unit was ordered to move down into the Alps. We didn't know just where we were headed, but we prepared to go at a moment's notice.

Chapter XIV

Occupation Duty

Bad Reichenhall

The battalion -- with all of its tanks, half-tracks, etc. -- was ordered to move. For me the transfer would be my last involving equipment. All later changes would affect only people, their orders governed by their points towards discharge.

My remaining time in Europe was spent in the Bavarian Alps. I could not have asked for better assignments. The scenery was beautiful, and the weather was great. There were so many things to do -- especially for a Midwesterner like me! My occupation duties were light, and I had a lot of free time. I frequently refer to my months in Bavaria as my 'salad days.'

Our convoy left Fürstenfeldbruck early one beautiful summer day. We traveled the famous Autobahn most of the way towards our destination. The trip was an all-day trek, so each member of our tank crew took a turn at driving. The other four riders were strangers to me, but we got along fine. I was a little apprehensive when I had to drive because my experience navigating a tank was pretty much limited to guiding one around a parking lot in the States. An M-4 tank has a conventional multi-speed[1] transmission. Steering is done with two brake levers called *radials.* Pulling on one of the radials applies a brake to its track. The braking action turns the tank in the direction of the pulled radial, much the way dragging one's foot turns a sled.

With that bit of background you can well understand my misadventure while driving. At first everything went just fine. I did not make a jerky start, and I did not grind the gears. I cruised along in the top gear at about twenty-five miles an hour. Then the column of vehicles came to a blown-out bridge over a gully with steep sides. Rather than look for a detour, our convoy leader elected to go down one bank and come back up the other. All the vehicles ahead of our tank managed to execute that maneuver easily, so I didn't

[1] Five forward and two reverse speeds.

anticipate any trouble. As soon as I started down the slope, however, I realized that I was going much too fast. I had to shift into a lower gear. I managed to get into third gear, but third gear was not low enough. We were still going too fast, and I could not shift any lower. I tried to double-clutch and shift down, but I simply could not. There was nothing left to do but to apply brakes. That meant pulling on both radials at once -- HARD! I stood up, wrapped both arms around the radials, and pulled as best I could. We slowed down just enough to avoid complete disaster at the bottom of the ravine. By grinding away in first gear I managed to make the climb up the other side -- all of it without any of the other guys in the tank ever knowing anything was wrong. They just thought I went down the hill a little fast. I came to have a much greater appreciation for tank drivers!

When we had gone about a third of the way, we could see the Alps in the distance. On one of the snapshots taken that afternoon, I look as if I were leaning against a mountain. Unfortunately the picture is lost, its place in the family album only an empty space.

Individual vehicles had no maps, so our crew could not identify terrain features. Near the end of the trip we passed Chiemsee, a large German lake made famous by Mad King Ludwig of Bavaria. Ludwig built a palace on Herreninsel, an island near the lake's south shore. The palace, which he named *Herrenchiemsee,* was meant to be a replica of the palace at Versailles. None of us knew anything of the history of the place: we didn't even know the name of the lake!

Shortly after passing Chiemsee, we left the Autobahn and headed south into the mountains. I think there were more blown bridges and our move into the Alps was a detour. The road was narrow and winding. I was no longer driving, so I just sat on the turret and enjoyed the scenery. We passed Thumsee, another lovely mountain lake.[2]

In early evening we reached Bad Reichenhall, a delightful Alpine town near the Austrian border. There we took over German Army barracks at the edge of

[2] I just had to return to that lovely setting! I managed to get back to it several days later. My cut-off fatigue pants served as swimming trunks, and I used a log mountain lodge on the shore to change clothes.

town. The first night each of us found a cot, cleaned up, and went to bed. The next day we were assigned quarters. We were now in the 191st Tank Battalion, still an armored outfit, under the command of Colonel Wellborn Dolvin.[3] I was a sergeant and had easy duty. The 191st had some new Pershing tanks, which mounted 90mm guns. We wanted to see the cannons fired, so out of mere curiosity I took a group of men to a clearing. We fired a few rounds of live ammunition, but none of us wanted to ride a tank into battle again -- ever!

The 191st was a veteran outfit with more combat time than the 25th. The men had fought in Italy, France, and Germany. The battalion had a fascinating character, a small Polish man, who enjoyed the battalion commander's special favor. He existed by his wits as he knocked about Europe throughout the entire War. I never heard him called anything but Jan. He may have been a prisoner of the Germans at one time. At least he said he was, but we never knew when Jan was telling the truth. Somewhere in France or Germany he attached himself to the 191st. Col. Dolvin was a romantic sort. He may have considered Jan a latter-day cavalry scout -- like the heroes frequently depicted in western movies about the Civil War or fights with the Indians. Jan knew just enough English words to communicate. His clothing was nondescript: his only recognizable clothes were his pants and a field jacket, both of which were US Army issue.

Members of the battalion frequently told of Jan's exploits, for he acted as the eyes and ears of the outfit. He worked closely with the Intelligence and Reconnaissance Platoon, but he could move about more freely in enemy territory than Americans. On one occasion he failed to return from a scouting mission. Col. Dolvin committed the entire battalion to rescuing Jan. From a purely tactical point of view, the action was ridiculous. Fortunately there were no casualties. Had there been any and had the object of the mission been learned by his superiors, the Colonel would have been in deep trouble!

Jan was a womanizer: he seemed to have a woman friend in every town. He scrounged coffee, tea, and sugar in small amounts from the kitchen and

---

[3] In November, 1995, Ruth and I attended an Elderhostel at Paris Landing State Park, Tennessee. One of the topics, *World War II,* was taught by Dr. Malcom Muir, a distant relative of the naturalist John Muir. Dr. Muir quoted Col. Dolvin in one of his lectures. I told the group that I had known Col. Dolvin and admired him very much.

collected whatever cigarettes he could to help him impress his lady friends. He had no visible source of income. Perhaps Col. Dolvin paid him out of his own pocket for the many times Jan helped the battalion.

There remained a small contingent of Germans in Bad Reichenhal when we arrived. The major in charge of the German troops had a handsome German shepherd dog. Corporal John Curran had been Jeep driver for Col. Watson, battalion commander of the 25th. Because of his job, John got to meet people and go places that the rest of us enlisted men did not. He was similarly privileged in his new battalion. He met the officer with the dog, appropriated the dog, and assured the German that he would take good care of him. The major gave John instructions on how to handle the dog, what to feed him, etc. John must have been very good with animals because the dog obeyed him immediately and never caused any problems. I personally was always afraid of the animal: the reputation of the breed alone would have prevented my taking charge of him. The dog became the battalion mascot.

Lieut. Martin had become company commander of A Company during the fighting. His point count put him into the 191st Battalion, and he and I were assigned to the same company. I was glad to see him again. We understood each other, and I liked him a lot. As noted earlier, Lieut. Martin was *gung ho* in battle, and he was no less so in occupational duty. One of the first things he did in his new job was to organize a long hike, which turned out to be more like a climb. Bad Reichenhall is in the Alps, and Lieut. Martin's 'hike' went right up one of the mountains. There was a lot of complaining, of course, but when his men got to the top, one and all were glad to have come. Standing on a mountain top is an exhilarating experience, but for 'flatlanders' -- which is what most of us were -- it was especially grand!

I loved the mountains! One especially adventuresome thing I did very early in my Bad Reichenhall stay was to ride the cable car up to the Predigstuhle [Bishop's Chair]. The lower terminal of the cable car was at the edge of town. When I arrived at the base of the mountain, I asked the cable car operator if there had ever been an accident. I expected him to say *No.* Instead he said the last incident had been in 'whatever year.' He was probably just teasing, but we

approached the venture a little more soberly, and one of the fellows would not get into the car at all.

The ride to the top was a real thrill. On the way up I saw a chamois. My dad always polished his car with a chamois skin, so I just assumed chamois skin came from a Coast-to-Coast hardware store. The view from the Predigstuhle is fantastic.[4] I could look straight down the back of the mountain and see the glistening Thumsee.

I frequently went to the Red Cross club when I had free time. (I wonder how many Red Cross club coffees and doughnuts I consumed.[5]) The club was in a building that had been a culture center, so it housed both an art museum and a concert hall. It was located at one end of a beautiful and well-maintained city park. At the other end of the park was a band shell. On weekends the city orchestra gave concerts. Very few of the local citizenry but many American soldiers attended them. I went frequently. Hearing a concert was a nice way to spend a Sunday afternoon. After the fraternization ban was lifted, the local people came more often. On one especially nice summer afternoon, I was at the Red Cross club while waiting for the concert to begin. A young and comely German girl walked across the park and sat down on a bench near the band shell. Several of the GIs, myself included, admired her from a distance and speculated on chances of getting acquainted and taking her to the concert. I decided to approach her -- but got no farther than a few feet into the park when a first lieutenant came by. They went off together -- and not to the concert! The brass had a big advantage socially.

Bad Reichenhall bore few marks of the War. It had nothing of strategic importance, so Allied bombers passed it by. The downtown area was clean and pretty, and many of the businesses were open. The camera shop was very popular because it carried German film and camera equipment. Our own Post

---

[4] The cable car and the views at the Predigstuhle are much like the ones at Copper Mountain in Banff.

[5] When I go to a doughnut shop such as Winchell's with grandchildren, I sometimes order a plain cake doughnut like the Red Cross ones for 'old time's sake.'

Exchange did not yet have much film. Like most of the local business people, the storekeeper accepted cigarettes, sugar, or coffee in exchange for his goods.

I went to Salzburg the first chance I had. I knew nothing about the city, but I learned a lot quickly. For one thing, Mozart was born there -- but I did not visit his birthplace because it and other tourist attractions had not reopened since the War's end. In August I attended several concerts in the first post-War Salzburg Music Festival. I was unaware that I was attending a world-famous event -- like seeing the Olympic Games or the World Series. I kept two of the programs, which may be seen Appendix F. On August 20, the program in the Felsenreitschule included three Mozart pieces and one by Haydn. The next night, the concert in the Festspielhaus featured the music of Beethoven and Mozart. I recognized the Festspielhaus immediately when I saw the movie version of *The Sound of Music.* The talent show in one of the last scenes was filmed there.

I also attended a United Service Organization presentation in the Mozarteum, another of the Music Festival halls. The USO troupe consisted of only a few people, but they were talented and versatile. A male soloist sang *You'll Never Walk Alone* from *Carousel,* and I was enthralled! The musical opened on Broadway in 1945, so we were hearing songs from a really <u>new</u> show!

I especially liked the Mirabell Gardens in Salzburg. The Mozarteum and a very fine baroque church are situated adjacent to the gardens. At one time the city was ruled by the Bishop of Salzburg. His role was both religious and political. Legend says that one of the bishops was a huge man. Because of his size, he had to be carried about on a chaise borne by four servants. He conducted mass from a semi-prone position. Although the edifice in the Mirabell Gardens is not a cathedral, it was still one of the bishop's favorite churches. He had an art glass window installed in the ceiling above the chancel, so he could look at it while lying down.

I attended another USO show in Traunstein, a town about twenty miles from Bad Reichenhall. The headliners were Jack Benny (comedian and emcee), Larry Adler (harmonica virtuoso), and Martha Tilton (female vocalist). I managed to get a Jeep to transport three of us to the show. The performers were very fine,

but maybe any live presentation would have seemed good to an audience of entertainment-starved soldiers.[6]

Salzburg is famous for another summer festival, the annual presentation of *Jederman,* a play by the Austrian poet and playwright Hugo von Hofmannsthal.[7] I didn't get to see an actual performance, but I did happen onto the square at the right time to watch a rehearsal.

Eventually I learned something of local geography. One Saturday, Gordon Elrod, Dave Hardin, and I drove a Jeep to Berchtesgaden, the town closest to Hitler's mountain retreat. Gordon and Dave were from Indiana and Texas respectively, so none of us had experience in mountain driving. We drove very slowly and carefully. The road to the Berghof, Hitler's home, had a 15% grade, and part of it was one-way. Military Police at the base of the hill cautioned us before we began our climb. The Berghof itself was badly damaged, but the balcony overlooking the Alps looked safe enough for us to walk on. We had our pictures taken there as each of us assumed a German *'Sieg Heil'* pose. Our picture is still in a Kratzke family album. We wanted to go up to the Eagle's Nest, a tea garden on Mount Kehlstein, but the elevator was closed.

(When the elevator first resumed operation, only staff grade officers were allowed to use it until a group of dignitaries, including Gen. Eisenhower, wanted to ride in it. When the General saw the discriminatory sign, he took it down, and afterwards anyone could go up to the Eagle's Nest on the elevator.[8])

From the Berghof we went out to Königssee [King's Lake], the Alpine lake twelve miles south of town. We took the excursion boat out to St. Bartholoma

---

[6] In 1980, I attended another show in Traunstein. It was certainly different from the first one. Ruth and I were on a tour that included the Oberammergau Passion Play. Because Oberammergau and Traunstein are not far from each other, we stayed in Traunstein the night before the play. (The date just happened to be August 14, Ruth's birthday.) That evening we attended a beer fest in a huge tent. Everyone was in a happy mood at first. There were a *Lederhosen*-clad oompah band, bar maids serving good local beer in pint steins, and all the other trappings that make the German *Fasching* and *Oktoberfest* such entertaining festivals. Then, a little later, the crowd began to sway in rhythm. The movement became mesmerizing until we sensed a strong suggestion of nationalism that was supposed to have died with the end of the War. We found the scene both eerie and scary.

[7] von Hofmannsthal is probably better known for his stories *Ariadne auf Naxos* and *Der Rosenkavalier*, both of which were made into operas by Richard Strauss.

[8] I did not visit the Eagle's Nest until 1989.

Church, the subject of many paintings.[9] The boats, which are still in operation today, are very quiet because they are electrically run.

Rumors about the possible ending of the War in the Pacific began to circulate in early August. News of dropping the atomic bomb, the new super-weapon, onto Hiroshima and Nagasaki was greeted with enthusiasm. We assumed that the bombings would end the War and that none of us would have to fight in the Pacific. Hostilities actually ended on V-J Day, August 14, 1945, and the War in the Pacific ended officially on September 2.

I played some baseball that summer. The games were not very well organized, and our equipment was minimal. We had fun, but I still missed participating in the regular sporting activities I enjoyed before the War.

Sometime in the autumn, I learned via the grapevine that there was a Missouri Synod Lutheran chaplain stationed at Nürnberg. I contacted him and asked if he would come to Bad Reichenhall and hold a communion service for me and anyone else I could round up. I had not been to communion since I left the United States, so I was especially pleased when he agreed to come. I found only one other Lutheran GI who wanted to join me. The chaplain held a short service for just the two of us in the Lutheran church across the street from the Red Cross club. I am not certain as to the chaplain's identity, but I think he was The Rev. Carl Eggers,[10] our pastor at Christ the King from 1958 until 1964.

In early autumn, the girls of the Red Cross organized a party. There was no excuse or special occasion, but a party seemed like a good idea. The fraternization ban had been eased, so some of the fellows invited local girls. It was a Bring-Your-Own-Bottle party, so there was a scramble to find liquor sources. Most of the guys who came brought Hennessy brandy. Some fellow in my barracks, whose name I have forgotten, asked me if I would share the cost of a bottle of whatever he could find. I said I would, even though I knew very little about spirits. Somewhere he managed to buy a liter of Cointreau. It

---

[9] One such painting is in the permanent collection of the Frye Art Museum in Seattle.

[10] Pastor Eggers served as one of the Protestant chaplains to the German prisoners at the War Crimes Trials in Nürnberg. The Bellevue newspaper had a feature story on Pastor Eggers when he was at Christ the King.

didn't cost much, and we would not have to go to the party empty-handed. We didn't know that Cointreau is an orange liqueur, sweet and thick. It is a very good, actually quite expensive, but hardly a party drink. Each of us drank only a little of it, but in time we used up the bottle's contents -- most of it as a treat to other guys.

Liquor was difficult to come by and much in demand. Even after the War, only officers were allowed regular rations of good spirits. Enlisted men got beer. Someone learned of a good source of fine whiskey and brandy in Bolzano, Italy. Bolzano is located on the Austrian-Italian border not far from Brenner Pass, close enough to make a trip there feasible. We found a GI volunteer to drive a truck to Bolzano and bring back a whole load of booze. We gave him enough money and barter material -- mostly cigarettes -- to deal with whoever had the hooch. He took off, as thirsty enlisted men awaited his return in great anticipation. But he didn't return when expected. After waiting for what seemed a long time, we sent out a search party, including an MP, to Bolzano to find out what happened. We were worried that our booze buyer may have been hi-jacked. But he did not meet such a fate. Instead he had sold the truck, kept the money and barter materials, and settled down with a Bolzano family who took him in. The search party retrieved the truck and most of the money, bought the liquor, and brought the errant messenger back under arrest. The whole operation was only marginally legal in the first place, so there was a lot of eye-winking as the guy got off with a demotion and pledge to compensate all money spent.

Some of the fellows had liquor sent them by friends or relatives -- more difficult than it sounds! In an effort to prevent smuggling, the Army Post Office in New York examined all outgoing packages. The Army suspected that some soldiers would be involved in black market booze, and smuggling through the mails would be one way of obtaining goods for sale. The incidents that I knew about had nothing to do with smuggling for profit. The individuals involved just wanted to get some whiskey for themselves.

Dave Hardin received a package from his sister. It contained a well-padded[11] quart fruit jar full of cherries. The jar had a home-made label that identified

the contents, the date of canning, and the person who did the canning. Dave did not care for the juice in the which the cherries were preserved, so he poured it out. Upon sampling the cherries, he immediately recognized a non-cherry taste. His sister had replaced the cherry juice with Bourbon, and it had gotten past the Army inspectors in New York. Dave was annoyed that his sister had not alerted him to expect some very good cherries.

Another one of the fellows got a loaf of bread that had been cut in two and hollowed out, much like dugout canoe. The sender placed a bottle of whiskey into the hollowed out-bread, but when his package arrived, the bottle was gone. All the GI got was a stale loaf of bread with the inside portion missing.

There were many methods for getting things past the New York inspectors, and a few succeeded. I did not have any trouble, but then I never tried to have anyone send me goods of a questionable nature.

By the end of summer, our relations with the German people had become more open, and we no longer had to view each other with suspicion. There had been a lot of looting -- outright stealing, in fact -- after the War ended. *To the victor belong the spoils* was the motto of many GIs. I had no feelings of guilt when taking a pistol or even something personal like a camera or a watch from a German whom I had captured during the fighting, but I could not just take things from civilians. Sometime during the hostilities I picked up a German camera. I was unaware of its value until a camera buff told me that it was among the first single-lens reflex cameras in the world. Fool that I was, I sold it to a camera store manager in downtown Bad Reichenhall to raise money for a trip to Paris and London.

Lifting the fraternization ban prompted another phenomenon common to armies of occupation, *viz.* soldiers' socializing with the local girls. Many barracks beds were empty every night. The girls were rewarded for their tawdry accommodation with things difficult to get in a defeated country -- silk stockings, cigarettes, coffee, and sugar among them. Mostly I witnessed what went on around me with detachment, but one case struck me as particularly coarse and insensitive. One of the GIs took up semi-permanent residence with

---

[11] There was no styrofoam in 1945; something called excelsior was used as packing material.

a girl -- in her parents' house. I found that hard to fathom. I wondered to myself, "Was the family so desperate as to sell a daughter? What kind of parents would do that?!"

Passes were issued on a rotation system. One's position on the pass list may have been determined by length of service, time since the last pass, or alphabetically -- who knows? Whatever the system, my name was someplace in the middle of the first list. It rose to the top much sooner than I expected because many GIs preferred staying with their *Fräuleins* to accepting a pass. Whenever a GI turned down a pass, his name was dropped to the bottom of the list and everyone else's name was moved up. My name appeared at the top quickly, and I was even given a longer pass than I expected. I chose to go to Paris and London.

When I returned, I was no longer assigned to the 191st Tank Battalion and my stay in Bad Reichenhall was over. The several months there had been very interesting.

The mountains shall bring peace to the people.

... Psalm 71:3, KJV

Chapter XV

A Tale of Two Cities (and a Few More)

Sometime in mid-October, I was issued a pass to go to Paris and London. I went with Dan Delacourt, whom I did not know very well. We were in the same unit because of the points system. Dan turned out to be a nice guy and a good traveling companion.

Dan and I arrived in Munich towards evening and stayed overnight in sleeping quarters in the railroad station maintained by the Army for soldiers passing through. The train we took the next morning was slow, and our coach was old and poorly heated. We carried sleeping bags, which we used to keep warm even in the daytime. The train stopped in Augsburg for about an hour. I got off and walked around the area near the station; there the ever-present Red Cross girls were dispensing doughnuts and coffee.

A scene on the loading platform caught my attention. There were several young German men in Army uniform. They were all incapacitated in some way. One of them had only one leg and was quite awkward on his crutches. Another had a dangling empty sleeve. Very likely they had just been released from some hospital or rehabilitation center and had not yet been home -- or they would not have been in uniform. The German people ignored them or ridiculed them to the point of being cruel. I cannot imagine what their motives could have been. Perhaps the civilians were angry at the soldiers for having lost the War. Finally another American and I helped the fellow on crutches get onto his train. The people on the platform turned their backs and disappeared.

At some stop in France, I sold a carton of Raleigh cigarettes to a man at the station. I wanted some more French money for our stay in Paris. Raleighs were the least popular cigarettes among American soldiers. The Frenchman either did not know or did not care. He may have sold them for quite a bit more than he paid me. There was always a thriving black market in sugar, coffee, and American cigarettes.

We arrived in Paris at Gare du Nord [North Railroad Station] the next day. We inquired about housing at an American Red Cross desk in the station. The lady at the desk directed us to the Red Cross club in the city. The club was in a large building complex used to house soldiers on furlough. We took the Metro [subway] without any difficulty. Americans in uniform rode the Metro free of charge. The main Red Cross building was full, so we stayed in a little pension[1] across the street. We were lucky because the accommodations in the main building were like a 'Y.' Our room was elegant by comparison, and it offered much more privacy. It had its own bath including a bidet, something new to both Dan and me. We ate most of our meals in the main building. Whenever we were away from our quarters at meal time, we ate off the street. We tried not to eat street fare because the French had little food to spare. The restaurants offered only a meager menu.

We hit many of the popular tourist sights of Paris. High points of our visit included the Eiffel Tower,[2] the Madeleine (a church that looks like a Greek temple), the Pantheon, the Arch of Triumph and Champs-Elysées, the Paris Opera, the Louvre, the Sacré-Coeur Basilica, the Notre Dame Cathedral, and the Montmartre section of the city. The places that impressed me the most were the Louvre and Notre Dame Cathedral.

The Louvre was awesome. I had never visited a world-famous museum before. Many of the art works were hidden during the War and were still in storage, but the 'biggies' were on display -- *Mona Lisa, Winged Victory of Samothrace,* and *Venus de Milo* among them.[3] W*inged Victory,* also known as *Nike,* stands in a spectacular setting on a stair landing near one of the Louvre entrances.[4] It is a huge piece of statuary not easily moved, so it probably was not put away during the War.

Notre Dame de Paris Cathedral is famous for many reasons. It is not the oldest of the French Gothic cathedrals, nor does it have the greatest art glass. Neither

---

[1] A small hotel, usually without a lobby and sometimes without an elevator.

[2] A tower as one of the high points -- no pun intended!

[3] Pictures of the latter two, which I took in 1978, now grace our laundry room.

[4] I remembered it well. When I visited the Louvre in 1978, I knew just where to find it.

is it the largest. Those distinctions belong to other famous French churches, *e.g.,* Chartres, Rheims, Rouen, Amiens, etc.[5] But Notre Dame is Notre Dame, and it is and always will be regarded as the epitome of French Gothic architecture.

At the time I thought of Notre Dame as a Catholic university in South Bend, Indiana, or the setting for *The Hunchback of Notre Dame,* Victor Hugo's wonderful tale of Quasimodo, the deformed dwarf who lived in one of the cathedral's towers.[6] During my high school and college days, Notre Dame was a football team Protestants loved to hate.

Our guide at the cathedral spoke English. I suppose English-speaking persons were chosen to take people through because most of the tourists were American soldiers. I had been in many old churches during the War. Every village had two, one Catholic and the other Lutheran. Even the grandest of them did not prepare me for Notre Dame. It was unlike anything that I had ever seen. The guide did a good job of showing us around. To me the huge rose window was the cathedral's most impressive feature. It was removed and hidden during the War, but, fortunately for us, it had been reinstalled by the time we visited Paris. We were disappointed that we could not go up into either of the towers.

The Notre Dame guide told an interesting story -- perhaps apocryphal, perhaps true. He said that the church had an interesting custom. When a cardinal died, his red hat was suspended from the cathedral ceiling by a string. When the string decayed or broke and the hat fell, the soul of the deceased cardinal left purgatory. When Cardinal Richelieu, an unpopular French cardinal during the reign of Louis XIII, died, his hat was suspended by a wire.

We wanted to go to the top of the Eiffel Tower. The tower had been closed during the War and was just being reopened. The elevator had not yet been put back into service, but we were allowed to climb the steps to the first level.

---

[5] In our travels we have had the good fortune to visit many of the famous French church sites. Among them are Notre Dame de Paris, the Sacre Coeur in Paris, city cathedrals in Laon, Strasbourg, Rheims, Rouen, Beauvais, Amiens, Chartres, Bayeux, and St. Michel.

[6] I read *Hunchback* when I was in high school. There have been four movies made of the classic. I saw the one featuring Charles Laughton in the title role when I was in college.

We ate at the restaurant there. The food wasn't great, but the view was spectacular.[7]

It was expected of every visiting GI that he see one of the two famous Parisian shows, the *Folies Bergere* or the *Casino de Paris*. We did not get to either one. Many of the GIs staying at the Red Cross club spoke of their visits to these burlesque shows and said they were very good.[8]

After about a week in Paris, we caught a train for the coast. The English Channel can be very stormy during the autumn and winter months. It was now early November, and the weather was terrible. Because of the foul weather we had to wait several days before boarding a ferry. The Red Cross and the American Army Special Services maintained a hotel for detained travelers in the small town of Etretat. With the crashing of the surf, we could hear the detonation of mines being washed ashore. The explosions were especially disturbing to those of us who had been in combat. Many of the soldiers reacted by bounding out of bed and throwing themselves flat on the floor.

After a few days, we caught a railroad ferry bound for Portsmouth. The weather was still bad when we left, and the trip was rough. The ferry was much like our Puget Sound ferries except that instead of transporting cars, the ferry carried trains. The ends were closed while at sea. I always believed that an ocean-going vessel was safe because of its several compartments: if one compartment took on water, the other compartments would keep it afloat. When I saw that our rail ferry had only one big open compartment, my faith was a little shaken. But our ferry made it to the English Coast without incident.

Upon landing, we took a train to London, where we stayed at the Red Cross club in Grosvenor Square, right across the street from the United States embassy. Gen. Eisenhower's headquarters were in Grosvenor Square before the invasion, and many members of his staff lived in the same building that now housed the Red Cross club. The desk clerk was a beautiful English-speaking

---

[7] In general, restaurant food at the time was not very imaginative. In our more recent trips abroad, Ruth and I have never had a bad meal in France.

[8] The *Folies Bergere* now plays in Las Vegas.

girl. I wanted to ask her for a date immediately, just like every other GI who registered at that desk, but a big sign on the wall behind the check-in counter strongly advising against asking Red Cross girls to go out dissuaded me. I know for a fact that there were violations of the rule, but I went along with it.

By the time we were assigned our quarters, it was early evening and already too late to go anywhere. So I went down to the public rooms, where an extremely interesting ping pong match was in progress. A Red Cross lady was playing a soldier. She was ambidextrous, so she could toss her paddle from one hand to the other and hit the ball equally well with either. She won.

I met a Scotsman in the lobby and tried to engage him in conversation. He was willing to talk, but his Scottish burr was so thick I could hardly understand him. He was from some important regiment, and his uniform was very colorful. I also met a staff sergeant in a line company of the American 1st Infantry Division, the 'Big Red One.'[9] The unusual thing about him was that he landed in North Africa in 1942 and was in every battle that his division fought -- and he never suffered so much as an abrasion!

After breakfast at the Red Cross club, we set out to see London. We could ride the underground, called the 'tube,' and surface buses for a very little fare. On the first day we visited Westminster Abbey and the Houses of Parliament, which we found impressive. I was not quite so awed by the brighter, more inviting Westminster Abbey as I was by Notre Dame. English Gothic and French Gothic are different architectural styles, but I really did not have a preference. I saw little bomb damage in public buildings, and Big Ben was working just fine.

That night we went to a dance for servicemen. I learned the hokey pokey,[10] and the English girls wanted to do that dance all night.

Early during our stay in London we ate wherever we slept. Then one day an Englishman told us of a small restaurant that served steaks and fresh vegetables. We tried it, liked it, and went back several times. The steaks,

---

[9] The division's shoulder patch had a big red 1 on it.

[10] June Johnson, our friend from England, remembers the hokey pokey.

rumored to be horse meat, were a little tough, but we ate them anyway. The fresh tomatoes could not be faked.

We did not see so many of the tourist attractions as we might have seen. Parts of London were still nothing but rubble. Dan and I spent a lot of time loafing and going to movies. English theaters allowed smoking, so we always tried to sit low to avoid the pall of smoke. The movie that I liked the most was *One Hundred Men and a Girl;* it starred Deanna Durbin.

Dan and I wanted to go to Scotland. I had been told at my company headquarters that travel arrangements for trips into Scotland or Ireland had to be made in London. We were not successful in getting pass extensions to go to Scotland. Perhaps there was a quota system that depended on how many American soldiers the hostelries and eateries could accommodate. At any rate we could not go.

As a second choice, we elected to go to Ireland. In order to get a pass extension to travel to Ireland, the applicant had to convince the issuing officer that he had a relative or friend that he wanted to visit. Dan's last name was Delacourt and *Delacourt* sounded Irish enough for him to get the extension -- but *Kratzke?!* I talked my way past the officer in charge of pass extensions and traveled as Dan's companion. I didn't even try to pose as an Irishman!

We went by rail to Holyhead, Wales, and there caught a ferry for Dublin. I was standing at a bar on the ferry when the ship lurched violently to one side and then righted itself as fast as it had reeled over. The bar drinks slid down to the end of the bar, and all of us standing there grabbed whatever came flying by. Many of the passengers ran up to the deck to find out what was going on. The captain was averting mines. One of the crewmen fired his rifle from the stern and managed to detonate one of them. The ferry ride turned out to be more exciting and dangerous than we had bargained for!

It was late at night when we finally docked in Dublin. We were directed to a house not far from the center of town. Four of us shared a cab, and soon we arrived at our lodging. It was what would now be called a *bed and breakfast.* The house was very nice and must have been the home of a wealthy professional person. Six of us shared a large upstairs bedroom. It might have

been a sitting room in another day, for it had a fireplace. Although it was near midnight when we arrived, we were told that the cook would prepare a meal of steak, eggs, potatoes, and fresh tomatoes if we wanted it. We opted for a sandwich and went to bed. Our breakfast the next morning was the huge meal that we had been offered the night before.

In a complete contrast to London, Dublin was untouched by the War and bustled with activity. The restaurants had ample fresh meat and produce. We stayed inside Dublin for our sightseeing because there seemed to be no convenient way to visit the surrounding countryside. Two of the well-known tourist attractions in Dublin are the *Book of Kells* at Trinity college and Dublin Castle. We missed both of them, more out of ignorance than for lack of time or inconvenience of location.

The people of Dublin were extremely friendly. A serviceman in an American uniform was admitted to just about anything the city had to offer for very little cost. By contrast, English servicemen dared not wear their uniforms at all because the Irish considered the presence of one English soldier on Irish soil tantamount to a British armed invasion -- and the soldier could be shot.

One rainy afternoon we went to see *Marco Polo*, a film starring Gary Cooper, but the other days we spent walking about the city, taking in whatever sights there might be. I was appalled by some of the street scenes. The Irish are very emotional, so street demonstrations were common. Panhandlers were everywhere. Seeing a mother nursing her infant and begging at the same time came as a rude awakening for this sheltered Midwestern country boy.

In Ireland, custom officials searched travelers both entering and leaving the country, so Dan and I had to pass through customs twice. The officials were especially strict with people going out of Ireland. Every English person was thoroughly searched. The wall behind the service counter had a shelf full of whiskey and other spirits confiscated from English citizens. An American in uniform was not even questioned: we could have taken anything we wanted out of the country. An Englishman, perhaps a soldier in civilian clothes, approached Dan and asked him to carry a bottle of Irish whiskey onto the ferry and then return it when we were at sea. Dan declined.

Once back in London we went back to the Red Cross club and prepared to return to France. Again we were delayed a few days by the bad weather in the English Channel. We had no convenient way to notify our outfit of our situation, so we just waited until the weather cleared and then boarded the ferry. On one of the decks I saw an interesting poker game played by only two players. They were playing five-card stud, which usually requires at least four or five players to be a good game. The two soldiers were playing with nothing but £ (one pound) notes.[11] The game was very fast. When we reached the harbor in France, they were about even.

We had a few more days in Paris before we had to return to Germany. I had been gone more than a month on a two-week pass.

[11] A £ was worth about $4.00 in 1945, which is about $30.00 in 1997.

Chapter XVI

Winter in the Bavarian Alps

At the end of my 'grand tour' of Paris, London, and Dublin, I had to come back to reality. I had a wonderful trip! I returned in late November, but I cannot recall where I spent Thanksgiving. (Foreign countries do not observe the holiday.)

When we arrived in Munich, Dan and I had trouble finding our respective units. In the month that we were gone, each of us had been transferred, not to the same unit. Because of my discharge points, I was transferred to the 774th Tank Battalion stationed in a small town south of Munich. I don't remember where Dan went.

I knew only one person in my new unit, Ray 'Shorty' Fisher. He had been a driver for one of the tanks in the Assault Gun Platoon.

Time passed slowly because everyone was awaiting discharge. We had no specific duties, so we read a lot and played poker and blackjack. The weather was cold and rainy, so we didn't do much sightseeing.

I had been in the 774th only a few weeks when I was transferred to the XX Corps Artillery, which was stationed in Berchtesgaden. I had visited Berchtesgaden during my Bad Reichenhall stay, so I was familiar with the pretty town and its surroundings. I was pleased to be going there.

Because unit assignment was made according to number of points and not according to Military Occupation Specialty number, the usual functions of a unit were seldom carried out. There were very few artillerymen in the XX Corps Artillery, and those few were there by accident, not by design. To keep troop morale as high as possible and to preserve some semblance of order, each unit had to find something for each person to do. At first I ran the Post Exchange, a servicemen's store that sold cigarettes, candy, etc. The PX was located in a small storefront across the street from one of the Catholic churches in downtown Berchtesgaden. My duties were simple. The systems for keeping books and inventory accounting had been set up by someone else, so I just had to see that the store was run honestly. I was required to make a regular report

to the Special Services group that ran all the PXs in the area. Several girls from the Women's Army Corps worked for me. They waited on customers, stocked shelves, etc. They, too, were just biding time, awaiting shipment home.

The PX job didn't last long. The mail clerk was transferred, so I applied for and was given his job. I had to make a daily trip to Salzburg with the outgoing mail and pick up the incoming mail. Except when I had to drive in bad weather, my job was very nice. I was not assigned any particular vehicle, so every day I went to the motor pool and picked up whatever was available. More often than not I got a Jeep, but occasionally I was given a command car, a somewhat larger vehicle. Sometimes I carried passengers -- people who had made prior arrangements to catch rides -- like organized hitchhiking.

One day I was to take a civilian couple from the Post Hotel in Berchtesgaden to their hotel in Salzburg. They were a dual vaudeville team working the United Service Organization circuit. They needed quite a bit of luggage for their props and such. I happened to have an open command car that day, and the weather was cold and clear. The couple did not mind at all: they were bundled up and stayed warm.

There were two routes to Salzburg. One was faster but less interesting. It involved going down a steep hill, which could be treacherous if there were ice on the roads. The other was safer and more scenic but took longer. The day I carried the show business passengers I gave them the scenic tour. They were enthralled by the beauty of the countryside.

My daily trips to Salzburg were interesting and fun. I always dropped the outgoing mail at the Army Post Office on the way into town. Then I would go to the Red Cross canteen on the Mozartplatz, one of the main squares of the city, for coffee and doughnuts. I learned much about the city by watching and listening. Just being in Salzburg was a pleasure.

Some WACs stationed in Berchtesgaden started a little library on the second floor of a downtown building. First they got permission to use the space; then they scrounged around and found some semi-attractive furniture to make it into a comfortable reading room. They added some English language books and American periodicals for the servicemen. With a ping pong table in an

adjacent room, the library became an enlisted man's social club. I spent many evenings there.

The music and drama scene in Salzburg provided another opportunity for entertainment and socializing. I attended several concerts that winter. General Mark Clark was at one of them. He had a box in the center of the balcony, and the orchestra sounded the appropriate *Ruffles and Flourishes* to usher him to his seat. The musicians were all Austrian or German, so very likely they did not understand the significance of the piece they were playing.

Whenever I wanted transportation for myself, I tried to get a closed vehicle. Jeeps were always open, but some of the command cars had canvas side curtains to make them a little warmer. I had a Jeep the night I went to the concert that Gen. Clark attended. It was a cold night, and I had a date. I told the girl to dress warmly, but she did not understand just how cold an open Jeep could be! Apparently I did not make much of an impression on her, for even though the concert was good, she never went out with me again. She probably found some GI with a closed car.

Some of the troops stationed in Berchtesgaden lived in the Berchtesgadner Hof, a posh hotel taken over by the Army.[1] The back of the hotel faced the Alps, so the rooms on that side and the dining patio commanded a beautiful view of Mount Watzmann, the highest mountain in that region of the Bavarian Alps. I stayed at the Hof for only a short time because I was among those who had to leave to make room for some visiting dignitaries from the Nürnberg War Crimes Trials during their Christmas recess. Justice Robert Jackson, who headed the tribunal that conducted the trials, was an American Supreme Court judge, and when his entire contingent chose to spend the holidays in Berchtesgaden, he used his clout to have them registered at the Berchesgadner Hof, the best hotel in town.

My next room was in a dormitory made into a barrack. It was on the XX Corps Artillery Headquarters grounds. The headquarters office, mail room, mess hall and motor pool were all convenient. My roommate was Eugene O'Grady. Gene had a *Fraülein* in town, so I had a private room most of the time. Gene

[1] The Berchtesgadener Hof is still a Rest and Recreation center for American troops stationed in Germany.

slept in our room, his official quarters, only when there was something important like inspection the next morning.

One day I was approached by Horst and Wolfgang, boys about thirteen or fourteen years old, who asked if their mother could wash my clothes. They also offered to work for me for very little compensation. I accepted on both counts. Their mother did my laundry very nicely, and the boys ran errands and polished my boots. But I could never get them to arrange my things in the manner specified by the United States Army. According to US regulations, boots are lined up under one's bed with the toes out. In the German Army, a soldier's boots are placed under his bed with the heels out -- and these boys still followed the German dictate. I always managed to correct their mistakes before inspection.

A lot of fellows had German girl friends, so Gene's sleeping in town was not unusual. The Army should have done something to discourage the practice, but who would blow the whistle when many officers were doing the same thing? One day a full colonel ordered an enlisted man to deliver a load of firewood to a certain civilian. The enlisted man was suspicious, so he checked out the house. A pretty girl answered his knock, and he heard the colonel's voice coming from another room. The enlisted man spoke loudly enough for the colonel to recognize his voice. The enlisted man left, and the colonel never said another word to him about the incident.

Once the motor pool people came to lunch in the mess hall and announced excitedly that they had a big armor-plated Mercedes that once belonged to Hermann Goering[2] parked in the compound. Everyone gathered around the car, and one of the motor pool sergeants offered to drive people around the parking lot. I rode in the Mercedes a few minutes. I had seen pictures of Hitler's automobile, and his and Goering's cars looked very much alike.

Another automobile that found its way into our motor pool was a German Horch.[3] The car was an oddity to us Americans because it used charcoal for

---

[2] Hermann Goering was head of the *Luftwaffe.*

[3] Later the name was changed to Audi. Both Horch and Audi are derived from the verb to hear -- *hören* in German and *audire* in Latin.

fuel. A contraption that looked like a water heater was mounted vertically on the left side of the rear bumper. German fuel went for airplanes, tanks, and other front line vehicles, so some clever engineers improvised and built the charcoal burner for use in civilian automobiles. The burner probably ruined the engine.

A maker of custom skis had a shop in the center of town. I wanted to have some skis made to order, but when I found that the job would take several weeks and I wanted to ski as soon as possible, I had to find another way to get equipment. I frequently went to the Schiffmeister, the hotel on the north shore of the Königssee where soldiers could stay free of charge. The rooms, furnished in 'resort rustic' with a down comforter on every bed, were very nice, and I always managed to get a room with a view of the lake. The hotel ran a ski hut, where American soldiers paid no rent for use of skis, poles -- whatever. Thus I spent a lot of time on the slopes with good -- though not my own -- skis.

The only lift was a rope tow, but we thought it was great. A major from the German ski troops gave me some pointers, as did Horst and Wolfgang. Both boys were good skiers; very likely they started skiing as soon as they could walk. My ski experience at Königssee got me started on Alpine skiing. I caught the 'bug' and would ski for most of the rest of my life.

I became more homesick as Christmas approached. I had friends, of course, but no one with whom I could share my beliefs and holiday traditions. I had been going to the *Evangelische Kirche* [Lutheran church[regularly, so, of course, I went there on Christmas Eve. Much to my surprise, a WAC choir in the balcony sang several times during the service. I did not know about the choir. The women had not let the word out -- nor had they made any effort to recruit men. The service was beautiful. It snowed that night, and Berchtesgaden was at its prettiest. The town looked like a travel brochure picture of Christmas in Tyrol.[4]

The girls that ran the Red Cross club put on a New Year's Eve party in a hall near the Schiffmeister Hotel. Besides the dance floor there was a second room

---

[4] Thirty five years later, I took Ruth to that church. I described many details of the building to her, and when we went in, I was pleased to find that my memory was accurate. The two of us attended a service in the church in 1989; it was still unchanged.

for serving refreshments. The girls put up decorations and managed to find party foods such as beer and soft drinks for the occasion. There was a nominal admission to cover the girls' out-of-pocket expenses. Strictly speaking, liquor was not allowed, but many service people came with a bottle of booze anyway.

The party was fun until a fight broke out. I saw the whole thing but stayed out of the way. A Navy yeoman with the Justice Jackson War Crimes Tribunal from Nürnberg with too many drinks under his belt became belligerent. (Germany was Army country, so many soldiers viewed Navy personnel with a jaundiced eye anyway.) The yeoman pushed his luck when he began to insult the Army. A big burly first sergeant asked (told) him to 'knock it off.' The sailor started swinging with a broken beer mug. The sergeant took the mug away from the sailor and hit him with it. The sailor got a nasty cut on the head. Several of us took him to the hotel, but he was hard to keep down. A medic finally gave him a shot of something and carried him off to the dispensary in town, where he got stitched up. He appeared at dinner in the Schiffmeister on New Year's Day with a bandaged head. The first sergeant was in the dining room, and I expected more fireworks. Instead the sailor approached the sergeant's table -- all smiles -- and asked if he could join the sergeant's party for dinner. They acted like old friends, and I doubt anything more ever came of the incident.

During the same New Year's Day dinner, we were treated to an impromptu ice skating show. The windows of the hotel dining room looked out on the shore of Königssee. The lake was frozen, and someone had groomed the ice in front of the hotel so it could be used for serious figure skating. We considered the young lady performing for us to be very good. Whether she was or not makes no difference. All of the diners thought she was great.

I settled into a routine after the holidays. I went to Salzburg every day to pick up and deliver mail for my unit. I attended concerts in Salzburg whenever I could, and I went to Königssee to ski as often as possible. I, like everyone else, was biding my time and awaiting the announcement that soldiers in the point spread including my number would be the next to go back to the States.

My day came in February. I liked Bavaria, but it couldn't compare with the little prairie town in Minnesota that was my home.

Chapter XVII

HOME

The first step in my journey home took me to the collection depot in Rosenheim, a town between Salzburg and Munich. There each of us was assigned to a camp on the French coast. The coastal camps were named for cigarettes brands -- Lucky Strike, Chesterfield, etc. I was sent to Camp Phillip Morris near LeHavre, a depot for soldiers being sent to New York. Veterans bound for Boston or various southern ports in the United States were taken to other camps. The troops exuded a cheerful air of expectancy, although a few GIs were not happy to be going home. Some were leaving girl friends or wives behind. (The wives would be sent to the United States at some later date.) Others were leaving lucrative black market businesses. Camp Phillip Morris was dreary and its grounds muddy, but no one seemed to notice. Wooden sidewalks connected all the important buildings, so we didn't have to slosh around in the muck. I was assigned to a tent with some very nice fellows. We hoped to be shipped out together, but we weren't.

On a gloomy day in February, I left Camp Philip Morris and went to LeHavre, where, after the usual Army delay, I boarded the *USS George Washington,* a converted luxury liner much like the *Santa Rosa* that took me overseas in the first place. Prior to boarding ship, we had to exchange all of our foreign currency for American money. We could convert funds only in an amount equal to the sum of all our pay while in Europe plus ten percent. Some fellows had much too much money from their black market dealings or large gambling winnings. Several GIs approached me and asked if I would exchange some of their money for them. I had enough of my own to use up all of my allowance, but even if I had not, I would not have done as they asked. Not only was such an exchange illegal: it was also asking for trouble with the military authorities. I thought it strange that we were limited on money exchange but could take home all the merchandise and souvenirs we wanted. I had a German pistol, a camera, a Swiss watch, and a leather telephone case.[1] Had those items been

[1] I acquired the German pistol in a trade, the camera from the camera shop in Bad Reichenhall, the Swiss watch also in a trade, and the leather case from a German Signal Corps

given their proper value and added to my exchange allowance, I would have been way over my limit.

It takes a long time to load a troopship, so we could not leave immediately. My quarters were crowded and modest, but I was so happy to be going home that I did not mind at all. The *GW* was a bigger and nicer ship than the *Santa Rosa,* and the food tasted good. Perhaps everything seemed better because I was going west instead of east.

On the first day out of LeHavre our ship stopped unexpectedly. We were in the middle of the English Channel in calm seas, so there seemed to be no reason to delay our getting under way. After what seemed a long time just sitting motionless, a harbor tender pulled alongside, and some very official-looking Frenchmen came aboard. We had a stowaway on our ship. He was found and taken aboard the tender, which headed back to shore. We passengers never learned who the stowaway was. Was he a smuggler, a European trying to reach America, an American without a passport? The possibilities were endless!

Shipboard activities became routine and boring. We were fed three meals a day, each served in several shifts. Movies were shown in some of the larger rooms, and there was a lot of reading and gambling. We had one lifeboat drill.

I witnessed one exciting incident. A crap game was being played on a blanket in a secluded passageway. Some GI had organized the game, and because he owned the blanket and the dice, he made the rules and ran the game. He called himself the 'house.' The rules were the usual for craps -- with one exception. Anytime craps (1, 2, or 12) was rolled, the house picked up the shooter's bet. Those who had 'faded' the shooter would ordinarily have won that money, but instead they got to take back only what they had bet -- the loser's money going to the 'house.' Some gambler entered the game without knowing the rules. He 'faded' the shooter for some part of the shooter's bet, and when the shooter rolled craps, he thought that he had won. The 'house' picked up the money the newcomer thought was his. He was furious and had to be restrained. Even after the rules were explained he continued to berate the 'house' and all of the

---

officer. I gave the watch to my father and the pistol to my son Peter. I kept the camera for myself, and my children used the leather case to contain a puzzle of the United States.

other players. He got his money back in a dark passageway that night. The 'house' got roughed up a bit but chose not to resist. He learned never again to run a game without everyone's knowing the house rules.

The voyage from New York to Marseilles took two weeks, but the return trip required only one. The *USS George Washington* was considered a fast liner. Viewing the Statue of Liberty was quite a thrill. It seemed like a long time since I had seen her on the way out of New York Harbor. Upon landing we were taken immediately to Camp Kilmer, New Jersey, where I boarded a troop train going to Camp McCoy, near Sparta, Wisconsin.

The train arrived about 2:00 A.M. Incoming troops were delivered to barracks and told to meet in the mess hall. There each of us was informed he could have any meal he wanted -- or he could have something light and collect a special meal the next day. The cooks had been instructed to prepare food for arriving troops at any time of the day or night. Everyone elected to have something like a coffee and doughnuts and go to bed. The next day at noon I had a steak dinner with apple pie and ice cream for dessert.

The Army discharge procedure did not take very long. Most of the paperwork had been done in advance. If a soldier wanted medical or dental care, he was allowed to choose between getting it immediately at Camp McCoy or waiting and having it done as a civilian. No one in my group stayed for any medical or dental work. I needed some tooth repair but chose to have it done later. I wanted to get home too much to wait around.

I called home as soon as I found a phone. I thought that my call would be a big surprise to my parents, but they had known that I was in the United States from the moment I landed. The Army sent a telegram to the next of kin of every returning veteran. Mother and Dad even knew when to expect me to arrive in Villard.

On the day that I was scheduled to leave, a major came into my barracks and asked for me. I could not imagine what the trouble might be. I was anxious to get going and worried that I might be detained. The major was pleasant and invited me to go with him. We got into his staff car and were taken across the post. There we went into a building where a captain was waiting for us.

The captain told me that I had not received my Purple Heart and Bronze Star medals. The action at Gertwiller did not go unnoticed after all! The presentation was brief but impressive. The major then had his driver take us back to my barracks, where I stuffed the medals into my duffel bag and hurried back to the major's car. The major took me to the train just in time for departure: I was headed for St. Paul only minutes after I arrived at the station!

There was a festive air aboard that train. About half of the passengers were discharged servicemen. They were boisterous in celebrating their new civilian status. A major addressed a GI as *Sergeant* and was quickly told that *Mister* was the correct title. They put their arms around each other and shouted their delight. Liquor was not in evidence, so the party remained only noisy, never out-of-hand. Some of the veterans got off along the way, so the car grew quieter as we approached St. Paul.

In St. Paul I had to wait until late afternoon for the 'Soo' line local to take me to Glenwood. I ate in the St. Paul depot, boarded my train, and settled back for the three-hour trip. I leaned out the half-open door between cars as we approached the station in Glenwood, and I remember catching my first glimpse of my parents and my brother Paul. (Bob, my other brother, was in the Army, stationed at Fort Belvoir, Virginia.) It was cold on the station platform, but the four of us stood and talked anyway, our reunion happy and tearful at the same time. The ten-mile ride to Villard was pleasant. When we got home my mother set out all sorts of food. I really was not hungry, but I ate anyway. Mother and Paul went to bed late that night, and my father and I stayed up to talk of many things until early the next morning.

My return caused little excitement in Villard. Many veterans had already come home, so one more vet was hardly newsworthy. The local weekly newspaper carried a small notice but nothing more. I hardly expected a parade down Main Street!

Many consumer goods were still hard to come by in early 1945. I could wear some of my pre-War civilian clothes, but most of those things did not fit very well. (I had lost nearly forty pounds!) I needed (or wanted) some new white shirts, but I could not find any in Villard. I managed to replenish some items in my wardrobe in nearby Alexandria and Glenwood. I bought my first post-War

suit, a brown pin-stripe model, in Minneapolis. One might think that after all those years wearing khaki, I would hardly pick a brown suit. Indeed it was my last choice, but it was the only one I could find. Months later I purchased a second suit, a blue one.

The return to civilian life affected every veteran differently. Some ex-GIs had a difficult time adjusting. Many were so nervous that any loud noise spooked them: they would fall to the ground at the noise of an automobile's backfiring, a sound not at all like the shot of a rifle or explosion of an artillery shell. Some ex-servicemen wore clothes as far removed in color and style from service uniforms as they could find. One fellow I knew bought several of the most gaudy, hand-painted silk neckties one could imagine! I was less flamboyant, and my adjustment was really very easy.

I wanted to go back to school as soon as possible. I went to Minneapolis to check out the University of Minnesota class schedule for spring quarter. My GI Bill of Rights[2] entitlement took away much of the economic burden of my returning to the classroom. It authorized me to attend the school of my choice for as long as I was in service plus one year -- up to a maximum of four years. I resolved to use as much of my educational privilege as possible.

---

[2] The GI Bill of Rights is the popular name for the 1944 Servicemen's Readjustment Act, which provided United States veterans of World War II with special assistance. The act supported the economy against a postwar slump, raised the national educational level, and made housing available. Sponsored by President Roosevelt and supported by veterans' groups, the act had several major provisions:

1. A veteran was entitled to as much as four years of education and/or vocational training with tuition up to $500.00 per year, charges for books and fees, and living allowances of $50.00 per month for a single veteran and $75.00 for a man with dependents, all at government expense.
2. A veteran was entitled to as many as fifty-two weeks of unemployment insurance at $20.00 per week. Taking advantage of this stipulation was called *Membership in the 52-20 Club.*
3. A veteran was entitled to buy a home, farm, or business with a loan guaranteed by the Veterans' Administration.

Amendments in 1945 raised tuition payments above $500.00, living allowances to $65.00 and $90.00 for single and married men respectively, and home-loan guarantees from $2,000.00 to $4,000.00.

Though the GI Bill contributed to the building boom in the suburbs after World War II, its major impact was on education. Educators were unprepared for the flood tide of more than 2.5 million veterans who became students in 1946 and 1947. Villages of prefabricated houses and trailers became as common as dormitories on college campuses everywhere.

I stayed with my Aunt Emma and Uncle Gust, my Minneapolis relatives, for a few days while checking things out at the U of M. I found that the third quarter was not a good time to get back into the academic scene because too many courses were taught in sequence beginning with fall quarter. I chose to start classes during the summer, at which time I would go through the red tape necessary to get back into school and to begin receiving my veteran's benefits. I also arranged for room and board in a fraternity house. After taking care of those details, I went to St. Louis to visit relatives and friends.

Back in Villard, I found time heavy on my hands. I needed little time to 'unwind.' I wanted to get moving again. There were few jobs awaiting returning veterans in a small town. Even if I could have found employment nearby, I had no car for the commute.

My father let me use the family automobile for several all-day excursions. The springtime weather was nice and the outings pleasant, but they did not use up much time.

I occupied myself for awhile by doing some work on the church and the parsonage. The parsonage was in need of paint, so I painted it. I also helped the trustees with routine maintenance of the church. I worked for Art Fischer occasionally on a day-to-day basis. I had worked for him before the War, so I knew what he wanted. Art was in heavy construction and moving: he moved such things as buildings, huge boilers, etc. I sometimes worked a shift at the switchboard in the telephone office. The telephone company in Villard was owned and operated by a man and his son and daughter-in-law. The switchboard had to be tended twenty-four hours a day, so they appreciated having someone who could take over occasionally. I learned a lot doing odd jobs while waiting to go back to school.

In June it was time for me to go to Minneapolis for the University of Minnesota summer session. Mother and Dad took me down to the city. I think they used my move as an excuse to take a short trip. Travel during the War had been restricted by gas rationing, so an outing was a special treat.

Now I was back in school. I went home on weekends, and I joined Villard's baseball team. Rural leagues played their games on Sunday afternoons. I didn't

always have a way of getting back to Minneapolis after the games, so Dad frequently took me to Sauk Center, where I caught a Greyhound bus.

One weekend my parents picked me up in Minneapolis so that I could go to Judy Heyne's wedding with them. The Heynes lived in neighboring Detroit Lakes when I was a kid, but Pastor Heyne had since taken a call to Waconia. The wedding was to be there. I recall that I found it strange that 'little' Judy Heyne was getting married. Her older brother Bob, who was my age, and I had been good friends all through grade school. I came to realize suddenly that life went on while I was away and that the Judy Heynes of the world grew up during that time and were now getting married.

Tom Olson was the only one of my old friends who returned to Minneapolis. Tom's roommate, Merle Gorder, was a Navy fighter pilot with weekend reserve duty. Battle Lake, his home town, was in central Minnesota, and he would frequently fly over his parents' home while on 'weekend warrior' duty. I doubt the Navy would have approved his flying upstate to 'buzz' his family and friends!

That summer the congregation in Villard arranged a celebration honoring Dad's twenty-fifth anniversary of ordination into the ministry. There was an afternoon service in the church and afterwards other activities in the town hall. Some of the Waconia and Minneapolis relatives came. The congregation's gift to my father was a sum of money to be put towards a new car. The family automobile made it through the War. It had to: no new cars were built during those years. Dad ordered a new DeSoto.[3] The dealer placed the order and told Dad the car might not be delivered fully equipped.[4] When his first post-War DeSotos were delivered, the local dealer sold all of them to customers willing to pay extra 'under the table' money. There was nothing that Dad could do but take back his down payment and go to another dealer. He then purchased a nice new Chevrolet.

Several incidents during my adjustment to civilian life reminded me that there had been a war. The civilian population on the home front was used to

---

[3] DeSoto was a Chrysler product. It is no longer manufactured

[4] For example, some cars were delivered with wooden bumpers -- with a promise that the regular metal bumpers would be installed by the dealer as soon as they were available.

restrictions -- and also certain abuses. There were many who cheated on the system, and there had been a thriving black market in scarce commodities. As a veteran, I was a 'babe in the woods' and did not always understand what was going on. I should have known, I suppose, because I had seen it all in post-War Europe. I just thought that sort of thing would not happen in the United States. How naive!

While at the University of Minnesota I often hitchhiked to my destination. On one occasion in the summer of 1946, I was picked up by a fellow who was very talkative. He said that he got along just fine during the War. He had no trouble getting tires and gasoline on the black market. He boasted of his ability to get by when everyone else was having difficulty. Near the end of my ride I casually remarked that I had served in the Armored Forces and on several occasions we could have used some of his gasoline. He was very quiet after that.

In September I moved out of the fraternity house into a rooming house near campus. Phil Johnson, a good friend and high school classmate of my brother Bob, was my roommate. Our room was typical of accommodations around any urban campus, but its rent seemed high. During the War, the government had imposed controls on rents in an effort to hold down inflation. The control was still in effect in 1946, so it was easy for us to determine what our rent should have been. Phil and I checked with the Office of Price Administration and found that our landlord was, indeed, charging more than the ceiling. We informed him, and he professed ignorance of the law. He said that he had just purchased the house and that the previous owner had not informed him of the rules. Legally we could have claimed treble damages, *i.e.* we could have asked for three times the amount he overcharged. Instead we just asked that he adjust our rent and apply the overpaid amounts to our next month's rent. He agreed, of course, and we enjoyed the rest of our stay in his house.

Almost all of the people with whom I had contact during my first regular quarter back on campus were very nice. Sometimes I wore a veteran's pin, affectionately dubbed a *Ruptured Duck,* in my coat lapel, but I really didn't need it. Somehow people could always spot a veteran, even without a label!

Baseball had always been my favorite sport. The 1946 World Series pitted the Boston Red Sox against the St. Louis Cardinals. I was a Cards fan, and I listened to as much of the Series as I could. I may even have cut a class or two to hear the games. The Cards won the series with a dramatic and famous play. Enos 'Country' Slaughter scored from first on a long single. Johnny Pesky, the Sox shortstop, was the relay man on the throw in from the outfield, and he paused just long enough for Slaughter to score. I remember the drama Phil and I sensed as we sat with our ears glued to my little radio.

Not all faculty members were prepared to teach the veteran student. My German instructor was really a high school teacher who was hired by the University during the faculty shortage, and she treated us as if we were high school kids. Some of the veterans objected strenuously, and she soon changed her methods.

I still did not know what field I wanted to enter. I considered architecture because it combined the artistic with the mathematical. I felt one's major should be job-oriented rather than purely academic, that medicine and engineering were preferable to history, English, physics, or chemistry. I had to learn that a student could major in any one of these subjects and still find employment, that he did not have to be a minister, a lawyer, a dentist, or a businessman to support himself. I stumbled around trying to find my calling until a few years later, when at Oregon State, Professor James Brady and Professor Richard Dempster inspired me to study physics and mathematics.

Late in my first quarter back on campus I met Ruth Pauline Volkert at a Gamma Delta[5] function. There was little chemical reaction between us in our first encounter, but during winter quarter I took her out for the first time -- and not long after that we became engaged.

We were married on April 4, 1948.

---

[5] Gamma Delta was an organization for Lutheran students on campus. It was sponsored by the Lutheran Church Missouri Synod.

Sing unto the Lord with thanksgiving;
sing praise upon the harp unto our God.

... Psalm 147:7, KJV

Chapter XVIII

A Soldier's Return

For many years I gave little thought to my Army career. Few people asked about it, and I never spoke of it voluntarily. I directed my attention toward my family, my church, and my profession. In the back of my mind, however, I nurtured the idea that one day I would return to Europe and visit some of the places that were important in my service experience. Eventually, that dream became a reality several times over.

I first returned to Europe at Christmastime, 1978, when Ruth and I went on a Reformation tour. Many of the sites relating to Martin Luther are in east Germany, which was Communist in 1978. We spent a day in Paris before flying to West Berlin. The Paris that I remembered as a soldier in 1945 had changed, but the familiar landmarks were the same. My earlier experience must have made a great impression on me because so much of what I had seen came back to me.

Nothing on the German part of the tour seemed familiar. I had never been in any of the places we visited. Only the evidence of destruction and rebuilding in West Berlin gave me a vague sense of having been there before. Communist East Germany was not nearly so well restored, and much of the remaining rubble was a grim reminder of my earlier trip to the continent.

I sensed the War again at the concentration camp at Buchenwald. I had not actually been there, but I had taken my tank into several other prison camps. The sign *Arbeit macht frei* [Work makes one free.] over the gate struck a familiar chord, for that sign is over the gate of every German prison camp.

I remembered it well from Dachau. The thought did not make much sense to me at the time -- nor did it seem any more reasonable to me in 1978. *Work makes one free* in a prison camp involves a contradiction of terms. Only after reading more about the Holocaust did I come to understand the terrible irony of the expression.

* * *

In 1980, Ruth and I went on a tour that included the Oberammergau Passion Play. Other stops along the way included Traunstein, Berchtesgaden, Salzburg, and Worms -- all places where I had fought as a soldier or had visited as part of the Occupation Army. Berchtesgaden interested me the most because I lived there for several months. While there Ruth and I left the organized tour for a few hours and took off on our own. The first familiar place we came upon was the Berchtesgadner Hof, the best hotel in town. We walked around in the public rooms and the patio in the back of the hotel. Nothing had changed, and the magnificent view of Mount Watzman remained as lovely as I remembered. Because of our limited time, we had to hurry along: I wanted to visit the church I used to attend. Before we went in I described the interior to Ruth. I even remembered how the chancel had been decorated for the 1945 Christmas Eve service.

We stayed overnight in Traunstein, where I once attended a United Service Organization show in 1945. Nothing about the town was familiar to me on my second visit. Ruth had had a shoulder operation before we left Seattle, and because she had to do daily physical therapy, we were always up before the rest of our fellow travelers. While she was doing her exercises, I took a walk in a city park near our hotel. At that quiet early hour I was quite alone when I came to the memorial to the townspeople who fought and died in two world wars. I reflected on many things in the serene beauty of the park. The people there grieved for their lost loved ones just as much as their counterparts in America. I felt a flood of emotion as I left for breakfast, where inevitably we'd hear the schedule of the day's activities.

In the cathedral in Salzburg we heard the beautiful strains of a Schubert mass being performed for the Feast of Assumption. Most of the other places in Salzburg the tour group visited seemed familiar, and I enjoyed seeing them again. One spot I did not remember was the gazebo in which Lisle and Rolf danced in *The Sound of Music.* It is not located by the main house -- as one might expect -- but across the lake from it. From Salzburg we went to Innsbruck, the landmarks of which I remembered well.

The Passion Play at Oberammergau, the purpose of the tour, overshadowed my memories of War. It was a truly wonderful happening, both as a dramatic presentation and as a religious experience.

We toured more of Bavaria after the play. We watched the *Glockenspiel* in the Rathaus [city hall] tower in Munich. At eleven o'clock every morning, figures in the chiming clock come to life as two tiers of dancing and jousting mechanical figures perform their hourly match. I recognized the square that I had ridden through in a tank, but the *Glockenspiel* was not in operation then.[1]

Just a few kilometers northwest of Munich is Dachau, part our tour's itinerary. I wondered how I would feel if I went there again, but I was determined not to avoid the encounter and stayed with the group. Most of the camp had been dismantled, so all that was seen on the near-empty grounds was a visitor center with exhibits, and some interesting outdoor sculpture. The memorial is a beautifully-executed work. It does not minimize the horror of the camp; rather it presents the story in a tasteful and informative way.

In an effort to recall my exact feelings on that April day in 1945, I left Ruth to be by myself for a time. My mind conjured up a jumble of images, none of which was very coherent. I remembered a lot of shouting and crying and screaming. There were gunshots as prisoners tried to kill their guards, and Americans from the 45th Infantry Division had to maintain order under extremely difficult conditions. One's first impulse under such horrible circumstances is to help the victims, but there were too many of them to administer aid one-on-one. The Medical Corps and the Military Police had to be called upon to help. As soon as it was apparent that tank firepower would not be needed, our unit was sent back to our battalion. There I learned that some members of the battalion had been involved in the actual liberating of the prisoners.

After a little time by myself, I rejoined Ruth in the main museum, where enlarged photographs proved more electrifying than any mental images I may

---

[1] In 1945, a GI donated paint to have the figures refurbished. In return for his favor, he got to ride one of the life-size wooden horses in the jousting tournament. Thus the GI became a knight (!) for a day.

have experienced while walking alone around the camp. (When Ruth and I were in Israel with a group of students from the Lutheran Bible Institute of Seattle in 1987, I was asked to speak a few words at one of the Holocaust memorial sites. In my talk I said that we have been endowed with the great gift of selective memory and that life would be intolerable were we unable to forgive and put some things far back into the recesses of our memory banks.)

Worms, the next city on our itinerary, had special meaning for me, for I crossed the Rhine in a tank there on Easter Sunday, April 1, 1945. After the War, the town was completely restored, so in 1980, I got to see the Reformation sites that I missed in 1945.

* * *

Many observations marked the anniversaries of the most important events of World War II -- the bombing of Pearl Harbor, D-Day, VE-Day, and VJ-Day among them. Two such commemorations that concerned me were the fortieth and fiftieth anniversary observances of the Battle of Hatten-Rittershoffen. Ruth and I attended both.

The *Liberator,* the 14th Armored Division Association's periodical, ran announcements of many such occasions months in advance, and a division veteran, who owned a travel agency, arranged special tours. Ruth and I decided to go to the fortieth anniversary in 1985, but we wanted to travel independently in order to see more of Europe than just a little corner of Alsace. We flew from Seattle to Copenhagen and then on to Düsseldorf, Germany, where we rented an Opel. We drove first to Cologne to visit its famous cathedral and then went on to Bonn, the capitol of the West German Republic at the time. Ruth recognized the city as the place of Beethoven's birth, and I indulged her with a visit to that landmark of culture. From Bonn to Stolberg, where we stayed at the charming and comfortable Altes Brauhaus Burgkeller, a sixteenth century brewery converted into an inn. The meals there were excellent. Ruth ordered steak tartar, raw ground beef with raw egg and capers. I had something less exotic.

The next day we toured Aachen, ancient seat of the Holy Roman Empire. We went to mass in Charlemagne's chapel, around which the Aachen cathedral was

built. Charlemagne was crowned the first Holy Roman emperor on Christmas Day in 800, so the chapel may be the oldest building in which we have ever set foot. The Allies captured Aachen, the first German city to be taken, in October, 1944.

Because 1985 marked the fortieth anniversary of several important battles, we met many other American veterans and their parties, especially near the German-Belgian border. The Battle of the Bulge ended in late 1944, but its fortieth anniversary observations were delayed until spring of 1985 to avoid the bad weather of winter.[2] The battle at Hatten-Rittershoffen, part of the succeeding Operation *Nordwind,* was fought in January, 1945. Its fortieth anniversary observation was deferred until May of 1985.

Ruth and I both read *A Time for Trumpets,* a book about the Battle of the Bulge by Charles MacDonald. MacDonald was not only a good historian: he had actually taken part in the battle. Places we visited mentioned in his book include Bastogne, Malmedy, Wiltz, Clervaux, and Ettlebruck. Our innkeeper in Wiltz was a World War II history buff. He was a just a boy in 1944, but he recalled a meeting of Generals Eisenhower, Bradley, and Patton in the building next to the inn. He lent us a German 'coffee-table' book about the Ardennes Offensive[3] written from the German point of view.

In Clervaux we met a veterans' tour led by MacDonald himself. We spoke to him and later joined his group for lunch. Ruth flattered MacDonald by telling him that Fred Friedel, her military history teacher at Bellevue Community College, admired his work and that his book *Company Commander* had been required reading for the course. MacDonald acknowledged that Ruth had a good teacher who knew whereof he spoke. He then wrote a short note to Friedel, which Ruth hand delivered. Later in that eventful day Ruth rode down the hill between the War museum and the restaurant in a Jeep driven by some ex-GIs in MacDonald's group. We were never told where they found the Jeep.

We visited the American Army cemetery just outside the city of Luxembourg, where Gen. Patton is buried. The staff there was most courteous and helpful.

---

[2] Winter in the Ardennes was terrible in 1944 and no better in 1984.

[3] The German name for the Battle of the Bulge.

We also stopped at a less well-known German cemetery nearby. The crosses marking the graves of the German soldiers are gray and coarsely hewn -- in sharp contrast to the graceful white crosses in the American cemetery. I wondered what the contrast meant in regard to the two cultures.

We spent the night, our last in Luxembourg, at the Bamberg, an old inn on the Moselle River.

The next day we went to the German military cemetery at Bitburg. We had trouble finding it because none of the town's citizenry would admit to knowing where it was. When President Ronald Reagan visited there in 1974, he roused cries of protest from his critics because along side the graves of regular German soldiers were the graves of the hated German Stormtroopers, the dreaded SS. Even in 1974, it seemed strange for an American president to show them honor.

From Bitburg we drove to Cochem on the Moselle River. We stopped at Burg Eltz, an ancient castle that looks as if it could have been the setting for the story of Rapunzel. It even had a high bay window from which she could have let down her hair.

We stayed along the Rhine that night and arrived at the German-French border late the next morning. Gasoline was cheaper in Germany than in France, so we stopped to fill the tank. A vender was selling fruit at the station, and we bought some to eat in the car. How strange it all seemed! The last time I crossed the frontier at that place I was engaged in fierce fighting. Now I was munching on an apple and some grapes while going through a routine check at a customs gate.

Kapsweyer and Steinfeld, towns important in my division's assault on the German Siegfried Line, are near the border. Very little seemed familiar to me as we drove through them. Our tank crew slept in the last house in town in 1944, but I could not find it. We asked a local woman some questions, but she acted as if she were unaware of her village's significance in the War -- or she just chose not to remember and thus not have to communicate with us.

We had lunch in a beautiful restaurant in Wissembourg, the courtyard of which I recognized from 1944. Next we visited the Maginot Line. When I was

there in 1944, I was naively unaware of being right in the middle of the famous French fortifications.

After a brief stop at a town that I remembered for its having electricity, we arrived at Niederbronn and checked into the Grand Hotel, a luxury hostelry and casino. The hotel served as headquarters for the tour group. Ted Perkins, the group's leader, was most congenial and allowed us to join in all the planned activities. The town mayor held a reception for us that evening. I was the only member from the 25th Tank Battalion so was given a little extra applause.

The next day Ted invited us to join the group for a tour of Verdun, the scene of many German-French conflicts through the centuries and famous as the site of a great battle during World War I. Verdun turned out to be one of the most sobering and chilling places we have visited.

Sunday, June 16, we arose early because it was Fathers' Day, and I had several cards to open. After breakfast in our room we went to mass at the church across the street from the hotel. During the service I heard our bus engine warming up, so we left immediately to get aboard. My first impressions of Hatten and Rittershoffen were much the same as those of Kapsweyer and Steinfeld. Most of the War-torn towns in Europe have been rebuilt, so there is little to remind the returning soldier of the havoc and destruction he remembers.

The bus driver dropped us off near the monument between Hatten and Rittershoffen. There the American veterans from the American 42nd and 79th Infantry Divisions assembled with the German 21st *Panzer,* 25th *Panzer* Grenadier, and 7th Parachute Divisions. The United States Army European Honor Guard added a marshal air; it had participated in all high-level functions observed by the Army in Europe, the Normandy ceremony attended by President Reagan among them. The French provided a color guard and band, and French dignitaries, including a representative of the French Ministry of Defense, were very much in evidence. A representative from every American division placed a wreath at the monument. The Germans and French also placed wreaths. Following the unveiling of the monument, the veterans and their wives marched into Hatten, where more ceremonies followed. Local dignitaries spoke, and Americans responded. I was one of the American

veterans given a moment at the podium. General Arnold Burmeister, German commander at the battle, was the featured speaker of the day. He was eloquent.

The proceedings became more informal after that. The assembly broke into little groups, and soldiers and civilians from both sides exchanged stories. At noon the host towns provided *Kugelhopf,* an Alsatian specialty, and wine at a lawn party. We were served by pretty girls in native dress. A sumptuous banquet followed the lawn party, and after the meal the townsfolk presented memorial gifts to all the American veterans. The people waved and threw kisses as our bus slowly and carefully made its way through the crowd.

The next day we followed Ted Perkins and his tour group into Rittershoffen. We left them about mid-morning to try and find the family with whom I spent Christmas Eve, 1944. With a bit of sleuthing, we did indeed locate them. Their name is Holzmann. The story of my reunion with the Holtzmanns was printed in the *Liberator*. (See Appendix E for the complete text.)

We bade farewell to the Holtzmanns in late morning and had lunch in Betschdorf. The restaurant was small, so we were able to engage a couple at the next table in conversation. We asked them if they had attended the ceremonies in Hatten and Rittershoffen over the weekend. They allowed that they were from Germany and were not interested in any such observation. We quickly changed the subject! We asked about the local pottery, for we had seen several advertisement for *Poteries* and wanted to buy some of their wares. Our neighboring diners told us that the really good Alsatian pottery was available in Soufflenheim and took us there to shop. We found the Soufflenheim pottery more refined and more artistically decorated than that of Betschdorf. We bought Kugelhopf forms in three sizes.

Our first stop in France was Rheims, site of Gen. Eisenhower's headquarters. I was interested in the city for military reasons; yet we made no effort to find any of the places associated with the War. Instead we visited the famous Rheims cathedral. The damages it suffered during the War had been repaired. In fact, it was so fully restored that it is again numbered among the great cathedrals of France.

The next day, our morning patisserie stop, a ritual, was in Beauvais. When the French Gothic cathedrals were being built, neighboring sees or bishoprics competed with one another to claim all manner of superlatives. The bishop of Beauvais wanted to have the highest choir ceiling of any cathedral in the world. He and his flock had it for a short time, but it collapsed. So much for mortal arrogance and pride! The rebuilt church is outstanding nonetheless!

Later in the day we went to Rouen,[4] another city with a great cathedral. Claude Monet used the Rouen cathedral as the subject in a series of paintings portraying the front of the church at different times of the day. We bought a poster (not a print) of Monet's *Rouen Cathedral at Dawn* and eventually sent it to our six-year-old grandson Thal because he read a book about Monet.

We used Bayeux as our headquarters while we were in Normandy. We stayed in a small downtown pension the first night and a modern hotel the second. The Bayeux cathedral museum houses the famous Bayeux tapestry, an embroidered panel depicting the Battle of Hastings in 1066. When American troops arrived in Bayeux, they found the tapestry displayed around the nave of the church. It has since been hermetically sealed and placed in the museum.

The D-Day museum in Bayeux has the usual collection of soldiers' gear, battlefield relics, etc. A small book, *Das Evangelium nach Mark* [The Gospel According to St. Mark] was among the personal effects of a fallen German soldier. My service devotional books had been a prayer book and New Testament. How ironic that we should have to fight one another!

We saw the German bunkers and gun emplacements[5] on the heights above the Normandy beaches. We walked around in shell craters left by the pre-landing naval bombardment and saw the barbed wire at Point du Hoc. To take the ground above Omaha Beach, the US Rangers had to scale the cliffs at the Point and breach the wire.[6] Appropriate to the rules and results of war, there is an American veterans' cemetery at Normandy.

---

[4] Jeanne d'Arc was burned at the stake in Rouen.

[5] Tom and Jan Dalby told of a strange experience they had while visiting the heights above the beaches. They were in one of the German bunkers overlooking the English Channel when they heard voices coming from below -- talking German. The people speaking German were tourists, but Tom said he and Jan had an eerie feeling.

We toured Mont St. Michel off the Brittany coast and returned to Bayeux for the night. The next day we drove back to Obernai in Alsace and checked in at the Gouverneur Hotel. It had a cobblestone courtyard, and the second-floor rooms opened onto a balcony that went around the entire courtyard. I met a veteran of the Battle of the Bulge who had fought on the German side. He was a Pole and had been a forced conscript. He seemed to think that the failure of the Germans was due entirely to a shortage of gasoline for their armored vehicles. It makes no difference now, and I told him so. He agreed, and we had a nice talk.

Obernai is a beautiful city. The Allies destroyed the church steeple and the city hall clock tower in 1944. Both have been rebuilt to restore the city's old world charm and feel.

We retraced the path my platoon followed forty years before. I found all of the important places in Gertwiller immediately, for little had changed. The tavern in which I sought refuge was closed, but the building was still there. The garden wall that I vaulted to get away from the hail of bullets in the street still defined a local burgher's courtyard. The only way to gain access to the courtyard, then or now, is through the owner's house or over the wall. I used the latter in 1944, but in 1985 I chose to skip the whole thing. The scene of the attack on the tanks in Lieut. Tomey's platoon has become a peaceful stretch of road, and the forest in which the German 88 was hidden is gone.

I took a few pictures, and we headed back to our hotel in Obernai. *Spargel,* or white asparagus, was in season in the Rhine country when we were there. The German and Alsatian people consider it a delicacy, and we enjoyed it on several occasions, one of them being the dinner at in inn in Obernai. The next day, after a tour of Strasbourg, we moved on into Germany.

I wanted to visit the places where I had been stationed as part of the Army of Occupation after the War. Töging, first on my list, is east of Munich, so we spent our first night in Germany in a little inn in Ascheim, a Munich suburb.

---

[6] June Johnson grew up on the Isle of Wight, which is located off the south coast of England. During the War, townspeople were required to house government officials stationed on the island. Rangers were trained on the cliffs on the south side of the island. When the invasion began, the person assigned to June's parents' home came home early and appeared very pale. Very simply he said *It has begun!* -- meaning, of course, the invasion of the continent.

Each room was named for a city; ours happened to be the 'Paris' room. Töging had changed but not a lot. The building I lived in was converted from a school to a hospital. The large athletic field behind the school was gone, and a developer had built some houses in its place. The village that we called *Hitler's Baby Farm* became a tidy suburb of well-kept houses and gardens. The Catholic church was new. I did not remember that the old church had been damaged.

From Töging we drove the few kilometers to Burghausen, the town where Harvey was assigned for occupation duty. When Harvey lived there, he and I could go into only part of the ancient fortress, but Ruth and I were able to tour the entire castle and grounds.

We drove on to Erlangen, where we stayed the night. The next day we were in Bamberg, where our battalion fought, but nothing there looked familiar. We drove on to Coburg, then to Bayreuth, and finally to Aschaffenburg.

The trip made lasting impressions on both Ruth and me, but we were ready and relieved to be going home. Ruth felt she knew me better for having seen the backdrop to a very important part of my life. Perhaps we even gained better understanding of each other.

* * *

In 1989, Tom and Jan Dalby and Ruth and I visited parts of Germany, Austria, Hungary, and Holland together. Some of the places in Austria and Germany were a 'return' for me, for I had lived in them after the War.

We flew to Amsterdam and then to Vienna, where we did all the usual tourist things associated with the city. Sunday morning we attended mass in the Hofburg Chapel where the Vienna Choir Boys sing every Sunday. Near the end of the mass we left and hurried to the Spanish Riding School for a performance of the Lippizaner horses. After touring Eastern Austria and Hungary, we circled back to Salzburg and that part of the Tyrol in which I spent what I called my 'salad days' in the Occupation Army. Our hotel was in Anif, where the opening scene of *The Sound of Music* was photographed. The Mirabel Gardens in Salzburg impressed me favorably in 1945, and I have watched the

movie *Hopscotch*[7] several times because the story is set there. The gardens were as lovely as I remembered them. I looked for the restaurant that had been a Red Cross Club, where I always stopped for coffee and doughnuts. I could not find it.

The electric boats that took us out to St. Bartholoma on the Königsee are the same ones I rode in 1945, and the boatman gave the same echo demonstration as he gave then. The lake's environs. however, were much changed. In 1989, there were many home developments and concessions, and the north shore of Königsee had been made into a national park.

On Sunday, Ruth and I drove to Berchtesgaden to worship in the church I attended as a serviceman. We became involved in a traffic jam, so we parked the car to see what was happening. A Roman Catholic 'first communion' celebration was about to begin, and the procession into the *Stiftkirche* took the form of a parade. The presentation was impressive and cheerful, but we had to leave in order to get to the Lutheran church on time for service. The Lutheran order was formal, stiff, and sober by comparison, and the pastor was the only person to speak to us afterwards. Perhaps the Protestants felt uneasy about being a minority in a predominantly Catholic country. Whatever the reason, the Lutherans seemed to live up to their 'frozen chosen' sobriquet. We returned to the Catholic church and stayed long enough to witness the priest's blessing on several of his little lambs.

Following the two church services, Ruth and I went to a downtown restaurant, where our waitress informed us that elevator to the Eagle's Nest, Hitler's tea house atop Mount Kehlstein, was already in operation -- much earlier than scheduled in the guide books. We hurried back to Anif to pick up the Dalbys, so they could share in this wonderful bonus experience.

We returned to the United States by way of Amsterdam, where we spent a few days unrelated to my War experience.

* * *

---

[7] Starring Walter Matthau and Glenda Jackson.

Ruth and I made yet one more nostalgia trip in 1995, the year that marked the fiftieth anniversary of the Battle of Hatten-Rittershoffen. We thought the observation might be anti-climactic after the fine fortieth anniversary observance in 1985, but we chose to go anyway.

We spent some time in Spain, then flew from Madrid to Paris, where we rented a car and drove to Hagenau in Alsace. Our motel sponsored several 14th Armored Division parties. Mme. Lisa Pommois, the woman to be credited with much of the success of the 1985 event, stopped by and joined us for dinner.

The ceremonies in 1995 were similar to those of 1985, but they lasted longer and involved more people. A Roman Catholic service was held in Hatten, a Lutheran service in Rittershoffen. The latter, which we attended, was conducted in French, German, and English. The organist and choir director was Berthe Holtzmann's daughter-in-law. Several of the Holtzmann clan looked for us, but they did not find us because we wore no identifying nametags. Later, when we stopped at the Holtzmann house, we found the entire clan ready and waiting for our arrival! The dinner reflected the best of French cuisine. The Holtzmanns invited us to return the next day.

The observation included a very moving dedication of a memorial to the eighty civilians from Hatten and Rittershoffen who were killed in the battle. The towns are small, so every victim was surely known by everyone who survived.

Most of the Holtzmann family attended the noontime dinner at Berthe's house the next day. The meal was wonderful again, and everyone was animated. We communicated in German, English, and sign language. Otto's wife took us on a town tour in the afternoon. Many displays in the museum had to do with the War. The children in the public school made a series of murals depicting Rittershoffen's history; several of the scenes emphasized the battle.

Late in the afternoon, Ruth and I went west into the area in which I fought in the Battle of the Lower Vosges. The country is mountainous and covered by dense forests. I gained new understanding of just how difficult the work of Task Force Hudelson must have been!

We wanted to visit the railroad car in which the 1917 Armistice was signed, but the car, also the site of Hitler's gloating acceptance of France's surrender in 1940, was moved to Compiègne and later blown up when Hitler thought it might be used for Germany's surrender after World War II. The building on the site of the 1917 Armistice signing now contains a replica of the original car.

We returned to Madrid, where we saw Picasso's *Guernica* in the Queen Sofia Arts Center. The painting is Picasso's reaction to the bombing of Guernica, which Generalissimo Francisco Franco allowed as target practice for the German *Luftwaffe* during the Spanish Civil War. The painting, one of Picasso's best-known works, depicts grotesque figures in the throes of agony.

Our last War-related stop was near the El Escorial, the royal pantheon containing the tombs of Spanish monarchs. Only a few kilometers away, marked by a huge cross on a mountain, is The Valley of the Fallen, burial place for 43,000 soldiers from both sides in the Spanish Civil War, with its basilica hewn into a mountain of granite.

* * *

In the years between 1977 and 1996, I made five trips to Europe that would qualify as *a soldier's return.* Ruth accompanied me on all of them. I sincerely believe that reliving some of my wartime experience and occupation duty gave me a better comprehension and a deeper appreciation of the magnitude of World War II and the sacrifices made by so many people, both military and civilian. Ruth and I surely came to a new level of wonder at the price paid for the liberty we so often take for granted.

Dr. Malcolm Muir closed his last lecture at the Elderhostel in Tennessee by acknowledging the veterans of World War II for their contribution towards that liberty, for, as he said, "Two of the most evil powers history has ever known were Nazi Germany and Imperial Japan. Had they been successful in their war effort, the world would have been plunged into darkness for two hundred years." My feelings after resurrecting my experience as a solider, a bearer of arms for the cause of my country in World War II, are best

expressed in three words I saw scrawled in chalk on a wall in the midst of a pile of rubble in Augsburg. Not too surprisingly, they are the same words spoken to me by a German *Panzer* officer as he and I shook hands at the Rittershoffen monument in 1985. May they remain the hope of every new generation!

Kein Krieg Mehr!

NO MORE WAR!

For a summary of the trip
taken in commemoration
of the sixtieth anniversary
of the Battle of Hatten-Rittershoffen in 2005,
see Section VI (Volume VI) of the family history,
pages 1424 and following.
Photographs may be found in the Picture Pages.

Amen and Amen.

... Psalm 89:52, KJV

Appendices

Appendix A

ARMY IDENTIFICATION, MEANINGS, AND ACRONYMS

The identification of units, functions, etc. may seem problematic. Therefore, my children, you are advised to refer to this section for an explanation of acronyms, abbreviations, etc.

Tank and Infantry Companies are identified by Company letter and Battalion number. Thus A-25 means Company A, 25th Tank Battalion; B-62 means Company B, 62nd Combat Infantry Battalion; HQ-25 means HeadQuarters Company, 25th Tank Battalion; Ser-25 means Service Company, 25th Tank Battalion.

Artillery Batteries are identified in the same way. A-500 means Battery A, 500th Armored Artillery Battalion. Similarly for Armored Cavalry troops, A-94 means Troop A, 94th Armored Cavalry Battalion.

Companies, Batteries, and Troops are equivalent units.

AD stands for *Armored Division.*

AIB stands for *Armored Infantry Battalion.*

AG stands for *Assault Gun.* The Assault Gun Platoon was in the headquarters company of a tank battalion. It consisted of five tanks mounted with 105mm howitzers instead of the usual 76mm rifles that a line company tanks carried. The howitzers were multi-purpose weapons, used as artillery or as direct fire weapons.

AGCT stands for *Army General Classification Test.*

ASTP stands for *Army Specialized Training Program.* Soldiers in ASTP went to college or university.

AWOL stands for *Absent Without Leave.*

Bivouac means field exercise.

The term *brass* as used in the Army has two meanings. It may refer to officers, for their insignia, or it may refer to a shell casing, that part of an artillery shell that contains the gun-powder.

CCA, CCB, and CCR indicate Combat Command A, Combat Command B, and Combat Command Reserve, respectively. A combat command is approximately the same as a brigade in the old Army.

CP stands for *Command Post,* the field headquarters of a company commander or a battalion commander.

ETO stands for *European Theater of Operations.*

GI stands for *Government Issue.* It also refers to any soldier, infantryman, tanker, artilleryman, etc.

HE stands for *High Explosive.*

HQ stands for *Headquarters.*

I and R stand for *Intelligence and Reconnaissance* and are usually used as designation for a platoon. For example, headquarters company of every tank battalion has an I and R platoon.

KP stands for *Kitchen Police, i.e.* washing dishes, scrubbing floors, serving meals, etc.

The *Liberator* is the newsletter of the 14th Armored Division.

MOS number means Military Occupational Specialty number.

MP stands for *Military Police.*

NATO stands for *North Atlantic Treaty Organization.*

NROTC stands for *Naval Reserve Officers Training Corps.*

OAM stands for *Oklahoma A&M* (Agricultural and Mechanical).

OCS stands for *Officer Candidate School.* The program was ninety days long, and second lieutenants that came out of OCS were called 'ninety day wonders.'

OSU stands for *Ohio State University* during my Service days. Later the letters could also stand for Oregon State University.

POE stands for *Port Of Embarkation.*

POW stands for *Prisoner Of War.*

PX is the Post Exchange, the army store. It could be anything from a local GI hangout selling toiletries, ice cream, candy bars, pop, and beer to a full department store.

R and R stands for *Rest and Recreation.*

VA stands for *Veterans' Administration.*

VD stands for *Venereal Disease.*

USO stands for *United Service Organization.*

WAC stands for *Women's Army Corps.*

Appendix B

14TH ARMORED DIVISION, THE LIBERATOR DIVISION

The 14th Armored Division was activated on November 15, 1942, with Headquarters at Camp Chaffee, Arkansas. Elements of the division were called upon to save lives and property in May of 1943 during a terrible flood along the Arkansas River.

After participating in the 1943-1944 Tennessee maneuvers, the division had one change of station -- to Camp Campbell, Kentucky -- before embarking for the European Theater in October of 1944.

On October 29, 1944, the 14th became the first division to disembark at the Port of Marseilles, and two weeks later elements of the division were maintaining defensive positions along the French-Italian frontier. After assembling in the vicinity of Rambervillers, on November 21, the division launched an attack through the Vosges Mountains to eliminate and trap German forces in this region. By December 4, the 14th had fought its way to the Alsatian Plain and had captured Gertwiller, Benfield, and Barr, breaking the backbone of the German defenses. After four days of hard fighting, the men of the division crossed the Lauter River, entered Germany on December 16, and battered their way into the outer defenses of the Siegfried Line.

The 14th was given a brief rest but on Christmas Day was sent to defend a long sector of the front running south from Bitche to Neunhofen, as elements from the Seventh Army were sent north to help meet the German counterattack in the Bulge. On New Year's Day, 1945, the Germans launched an attack down the Saar Valley through Bitche, and the 14th Division lines were badly bent by the force of the enemy attack but held to stop the enemy drive.

After the failure of the Bitche attack, the Germans attempted to break through to Strasbourg at Hatten and Rittershoffen, and the 14th was once again called upon to halt the enemy in a series of bitter actions which took place starting January 12. Fighting against positions in the old Maginot Line, across icy plains, and through the rubble of destroyed cities, the 14th slugged it out with three German divisions for ten days in what became known as *one of the greatest defensive battles of World War II.*

On January 20, the enemy forces began withdrawing, and the division was given a rest and assigned to defensive positions during February and early March. On March 15, the division was back on the attack and drove across the Moder River, cracked the Siegfried Line, and captured Germersheim on the Rhine River. The Rhine was crossed at Worms on Easter Sunday, April 1. At Hammerburg, the division freed four thousand Allied Prisoners Of War before turning southeast to cross the Main River at Lichtenfels in order to cut the Nürnberg-Bayreuth Autobahn.

The 14th continued to drive into southern Germany, crossed the Danube at Ingolstadt, liberated the Moosburg Prison Camp where 110,000 Allied prisoners from all nations were interned, and crossed the Isar River.

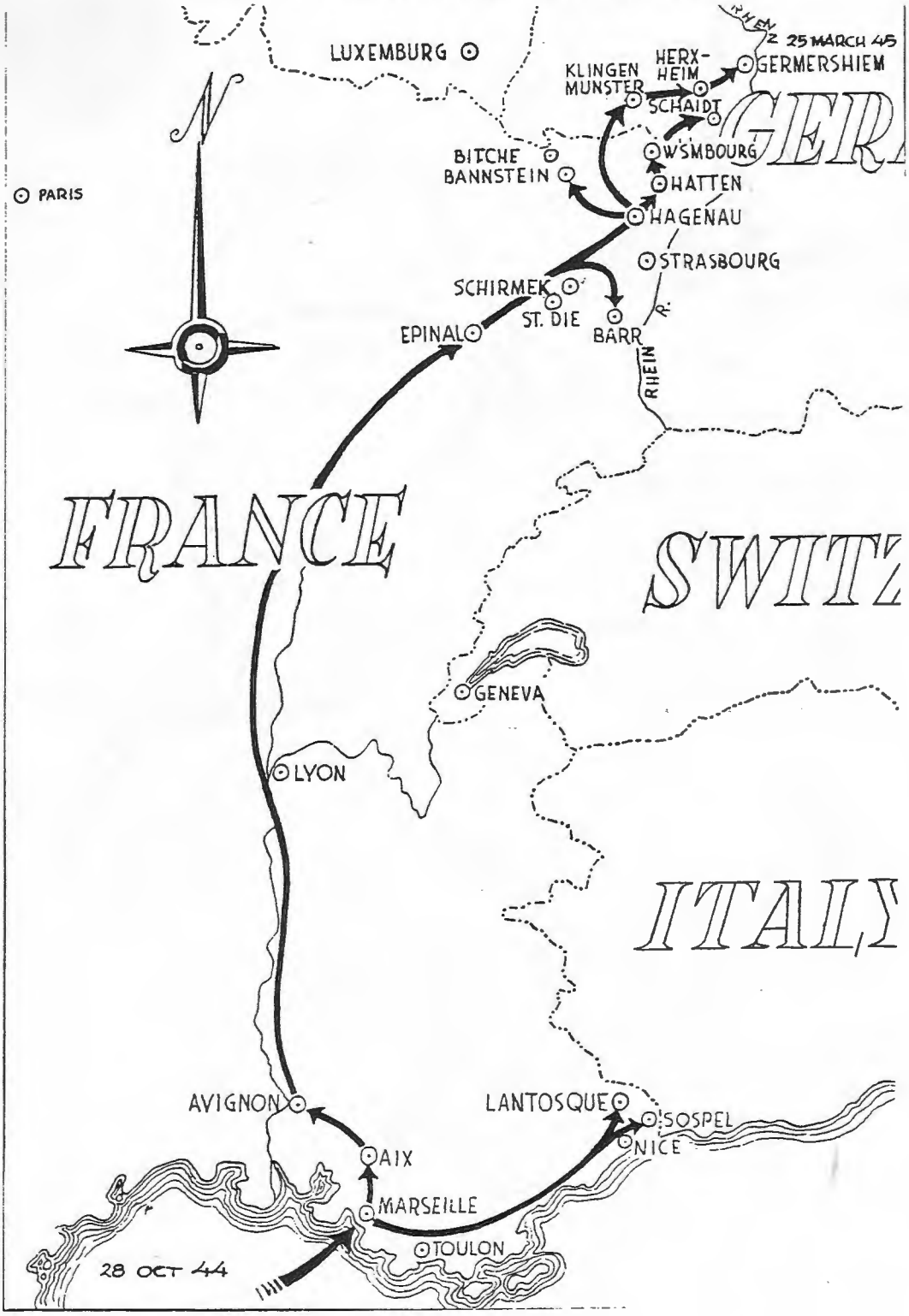
A concentration camp and three slave labor camps were overrun at Ampfing, and elements of the division accepted surrender of the enemy air wing controlling jet aircraft operations in Germany. The 14th established bridgeheads across the Inn River at Jettenbach and Muhldorf before being relieved on May 3 for occupation duties, which continued until the division returned home for inactivation in September of 1945.

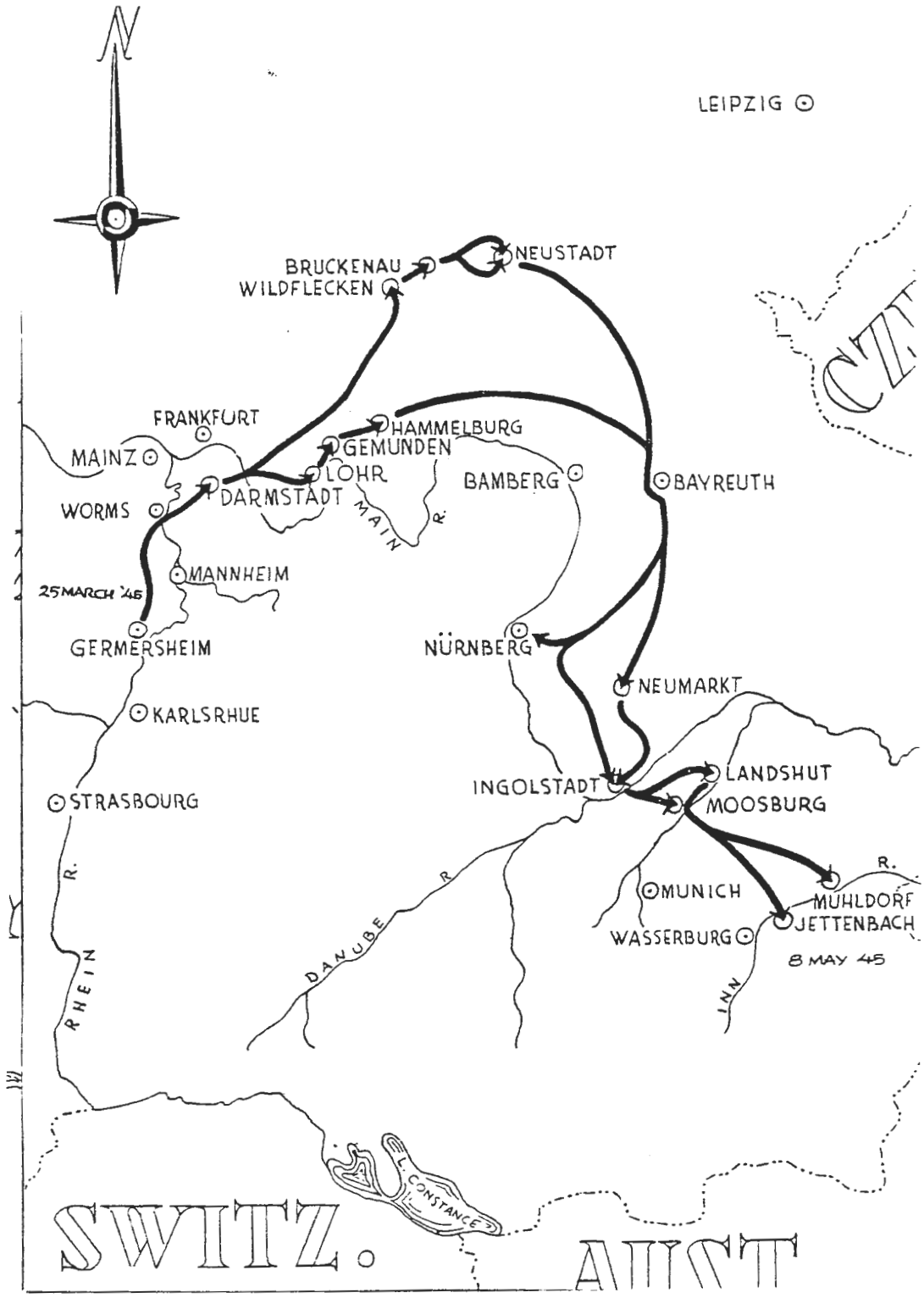
During two campaigns and 167 days of combat, the men of the Liberator Division had freed an estimated 200,000 Allied Prisoners Of War and an additional 250,000 slave laborers and displaced persons with a loss of 2,690 killed and wounded.

The 14th Armored Division's nickname as the Liberator Division was well-earned and appropriate.

Appendix C

INTO HELL AND OUT: TRACING THE ROUTE OF THE 14TH ARMORED DIVISION

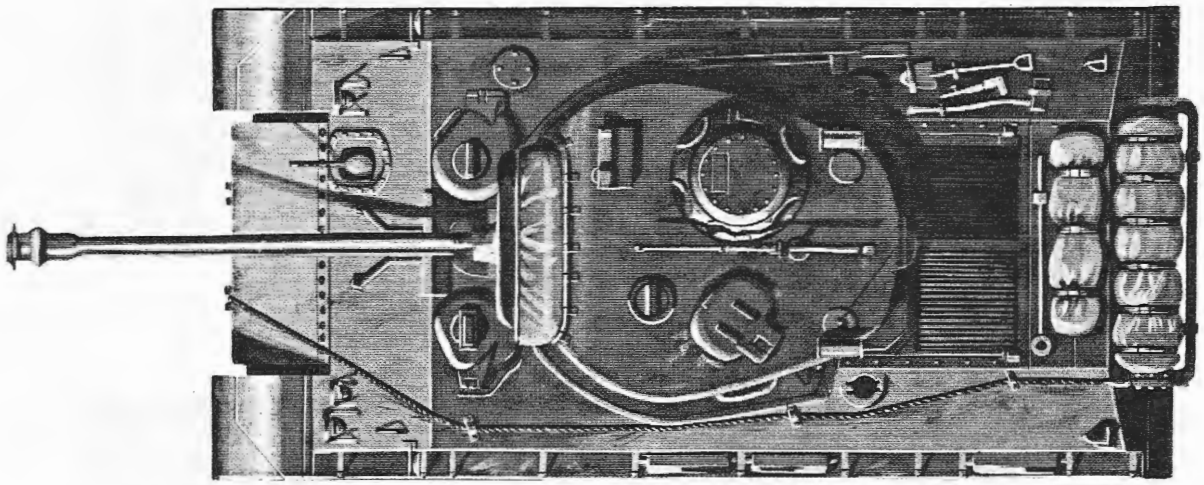


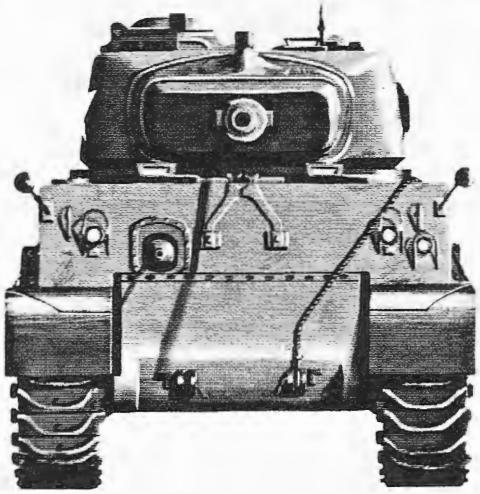

N
LEIPZIG
BRUCKENAU
WILDFLECKEN
NEUSTADT
FRANKFURT
HAMMELBURG
GEMUNDEN
MAINZ
LOHR
BAMBERG
BAYREUTH
WORMS
DARMSTADT
MAIN R.
MANNHEIM
25 MARCH '45
GERMERSHEIM
NÜRNBERG
NEUMARKT
KARLSRHUE
INGOLSTADT
LANDSHUT
MOOSBURG
STRASBOURG
R.
MUNICH
MÜHLDORF
JETTENBACH
WASSERBURG
8 MAY 45
DANUBE R.
RHEIN
INN
L. CONSTANCE
SWITZ.
AUST

Appendix D

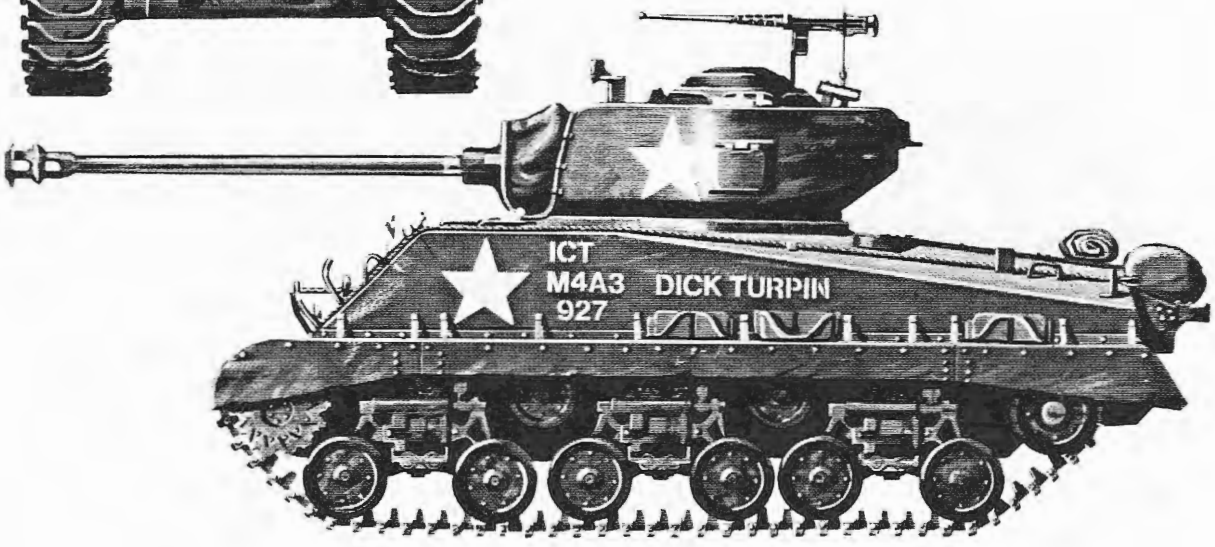
THE AMERICAN M4A3E8

SHERMAN MEDIUM TANK



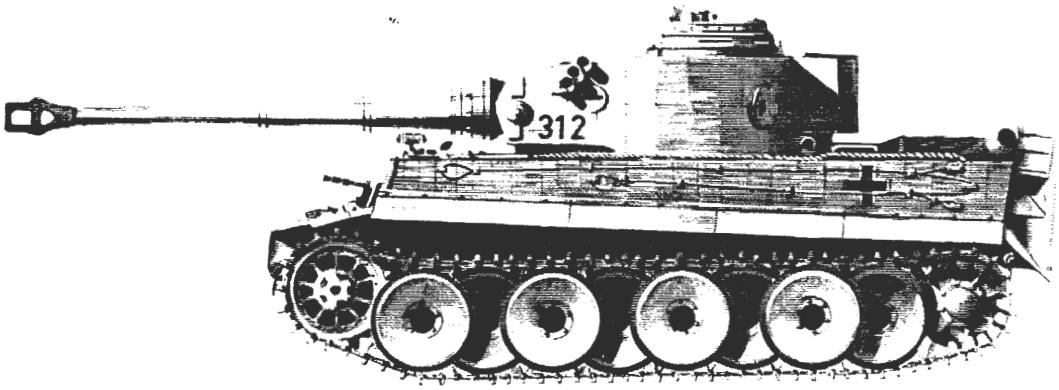


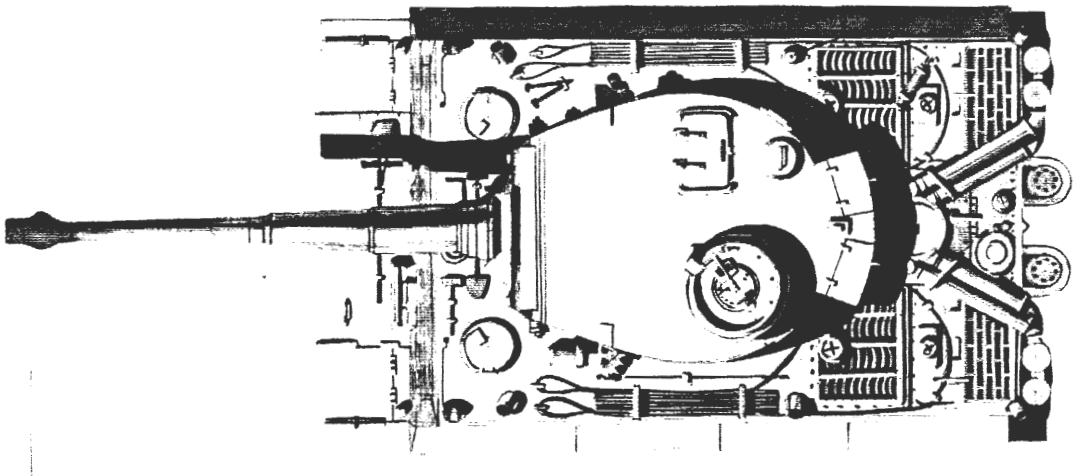
Weight: 32 tons.
Crew: 5.
Armament: one 76-mm M1A2 gun with 71 rounds, plus one .5-inch M2 and two .3-inch M1919A4 machine guns with 600 and 6,250 rounds respectively.
Armour: hull front 64-mm, sides and rear 38-mm, belly 25-mm, and decking 19-mm; turrent front and sides 64-mm and roof 25-mm.
Engine: one Ford GAA-III inline, 450-hp.
Speed: 30 mph.
Range: 100 miles.
Length: 24 feet 8 inches.
Width: 8 feet 9 inches.
Height: 11 feet $2\frac{7}{8}$ inches.

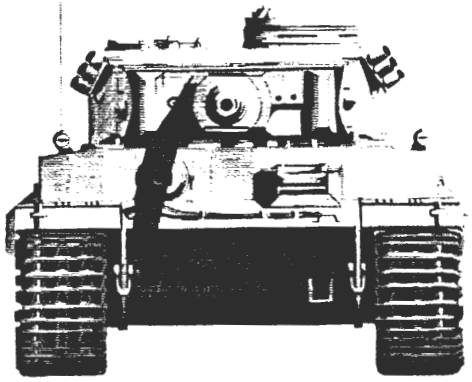


THE GERMAN PZKW VI TIGER 1

AUSFÜRUNG H HEAVY TANK







Weight: 56 tons.
Crew: 5.
Armament: one 8.8-cm KwK 36 gun with 92 rounds and two 7.92-mm MG 34 machine guns with 5,700 rounds.
Armour: hull nose 100-mm, front plate 100-mm, lower sides 60-mm, upper sides 80-mm, rear 82-mm, and top and bottom 26-mm; turret mantlet 110-mm, front 100-mm, sides 80-mm, back 80-mm, and roof 26-mm.
Engine: one Maybach HL 210 petrol motor, 650-hp.
Speed: 23 mph on roads, 12 mph cross country.
Range: 73 miles on roads, 42 miles cross country.
Length: 27 feet 9 inches.
Width: 12 feet 3 inches.
Height: 9 feet $4\frac{3}{4}$ inches.

Appendix E

CHRISTMAS EVE, 1944

by Albert William Kratzke

as printed in the *Liberator,* Volume 23, No. 1, spring, 1988,

beginning on page 6

I should like to share with our readers an interesting and poignant story. It begins on Christmas Eve, 1944, and continues to the present. In fact, it is still unfolding.

Those of you who have a copy of the memorial book that Mme. Lisa Pommois prepared for the fortieth anniversary of the Hatten-Rittershoffen battle may recall that in one of the articles Berthe Holtzmann recounts that 14th Armored Division soldiers billeted in her home shared Christmas Eve, 1944, with her and her three children. She says that some of the men even sang German carols. I was the one of the five in our tank crew who knew the German songs. Our story, Berthe's and mine, of what happened after Christmas Eve is recorded below.

We did indeed sing carols -- *Stille Nacht, O Tannenbaum,* etc. We also shared our Christmas treats. Berthe had some German cookies, which she brought out and served. The Christmas tree was sparsely decorated, but unlike many other households in the town, her family had one. It was lighted with real candles, probably a terrible fire hazard, and I remember that the children, two boys and a girl, wondered at the sight. We were comfortably quartered that night.

As we went about our mission, which included a return to Rittershoffen several weeks after Christmas, I often wondered what happened to the family. I only learned of their fate forty years later.

In June of 1985, my wife Ruth and I went to the Hatten-Rittershoffen fortieth anniversary observation. Ted Perkins graciously allowed us to join his tour group as 'tagalongs,' and on the Monday following the official ceremonies his group went to Rittershoffen. We followed in our rented car and visited sites with members of the group. When they left in mid-morning, Ruth and I remained in Rittershoffen to seek out the family with whom I spent Christmas Eve, 1944.

The only identification I could recall was the little girl's name: her mother and brothers called her *Annelies.* I asked an older man on the street if he knew anyone named Annelies who would be about forty-five years old. He and a lady who came onto the scene responded immediately that it had to be Annelies Holtzmann, sister of Otto and Alfred. They said she had married and now lived in another town.

News travels fast, and it did not take long for the mayor's secretary, who happened to be Otto's wife, to get onto the phone to let everyone know we were in town. Soon Berthe and Madeleine, Berthe's second daughter born after the War, appeared in the town hall square.

A happy reunion! Berthe remembered me for my blonde hair. (I am blonde still, even in my sixties, though I have less hair than I had the first time Berthe and I met!) Berthe said I hung a Christmas card onto her tree.

It was one happy extended family[1] who gathered around the Holtzmann kitchen table for a glass of Schnapps that day we came together. They offered us the rest of the bottle, and had we still been part of a group we may have accepted it. However, I had memories of home-made 'white lightning' and thought it best to decline.

We sang *Die Lorelei* and some other German songs. Before we left, Otto, a wood carver, insisted on giving us a miniature harvest fork and flail as present.[2] Later that day we purchased an Alsatian doll, which we named -- What else? -- Annelies. When we returned to Seattle, we sent Berthe's granddaughter Patty a Seattle T-shirt and the family some of my color photographs[3] of Northwest mountains and seashores. Patty wrote a note that began with a French *Merci ...* while her grandmother's acknowledgment started with a German *Danke schön.*

We still correspond. In one of my letters I asked Berthe what happened to her and her family during those bitter days of January, 1945, and from then until the end of the War. She responded with a letter that must have been difficult for her to write. I asked her if she would mind if I shared her letter with the readers of the *Liberator.* She agreed to have it printed, and my translation of her letter follows. In order to preserve the feelings expressed in Berthe's writing, I have made only a simple translation with no attempt to put her writing into colloquial English.

Dear Kratzke Family,

I received your kind letter with the good wishes. I am pleased that you have thought of me again. I wish you and yours the best in the New Year – happiness, health, and God's blessings. Many thanks for the pictures of your lovely grandchildren. In the summer we shall take pictures of us, too, so that you might learn to know our whole family. You have already met our Patricia Emmy Holtzmann. Otto's children are Freddy Otto, Cathy Caroline, and Christine Michele Holtzmann. Annelies' children are Remy Albert and Jackie Robert Stumpf. The

---

[1] Berthe, her son Alfred, Alfred's wife, Alfred's daughter Patricia, Otto's wife, Madeleine, and Ruth and I.

[2] Our daughter-in-law Nancy decorated them with dried flowers and ribbons, and they now hang in my study.

[3] I am a serious amateur photographer.

family lives in Roppenheim, a village on the Rhine. Madeleine's children are Erick Robert, Christopher Charles, and Sylvia Corine Graff.

I shall never forget Christmas of 1944. I did not know where my husband was. It was a sad time. We had no lights, and there were soldiers everywhere. I wanted to make things pleasant for the children, but unfortunately there were no gifts.

The night before the holiday I sat down at my sewing machine and sewed them some things. I set up a small carbide lamp and brought the machine up close. We surely did not know what lay before us. Constantly I thank God that we survived.

What I have written in the Memorial Book is not nearly all that we experienced. With half-frozen feet we wandered here and there and never knew where we were. We were often near death, even though we were away from the battle.

Once we were almost smothered when a truck with a trailer took us to Germany. Once we sat in an inn, where someone gave us something to eat. When the town was bombed, we were scarcely out on the street when the entire building fell in and the innkeeper lay dead under the ruins. At a collection point we were able to wash out our eyes, but we had very little water and only one pocket handkerchief for six people.

Then we were transported by railroad. The snow was fifty centimeters deep, and the train was full of snow and ice. The toilets were frozen. It was dreadful. We had to climb over a bank in order to find a clean place. Often the train stood still for a long time because the depots were being bombed. We didn't know where we were being taken. The train always moved in pitch-black night.

Finally, we arrived in Ulm. From there we went on to an encampment, where there was a long hall which was nice and warm. But it was so full that most of the people had to sit on the floor. Until then we had not wept – not even the children during the battles – because we were so numbed by fear, anxiety, and cold. Then the tears began to flow as a refined lady sang a German song to her

THANK YOU FOR YOUR CONTRIBUTION FOR THIS 25TH TANK BATTALION MEMORIAL WHICH IS LOCATED NEAR THE PATTON MUSEUM AT FORT KNOX, KY.

28 15 N N N-1 2

daughter. It was as if I were back in my homeland, that dear country. All the people in the hall cried and cried.

Then in a horse-drawn sled we came to a small farming town. Someone gave us a large room with two beds, and we could finally get clean again. It was the best time in our travels...The skin over our whole bodies was completely broken out from the dirt and cold. We did not know our own faces, and our hair was full of soot and dirt. The people brought us potatoes and apples and also warm clothes, which I then made over for us.

We helped the people by working and thus earned our bread. Alfred had to deliver milk from an old lady to the dairy, and thereby we received our milk for nothing. My mother knitted stockings from old wool remnants that were in tatters. Alfred went to school, and Otto went to kindergarten. 'Annelisle,' as the people called her, simply would not go with the strange children. She understood but would not speak. Instead, she went to an old lady, who would give her bread and butter and sometimes something sweet.

We were able to recover a little, but then the War came there. We had air raid alarms two or three times a day and also in the night. Again we sat in cellars and foxholes. We asked ourselves, "Must we experience yet another battle?" There were no more big battles, but we were still being fired upon. The town was occupied. It was plundered and the women violated. At that time the soldiers were not so decent to us as you were.

Once more we came away with our lives. Our guardian angel had not forsaken us. But then I became very ill with a gall bladder infection. The doctor could not help me because there was no medicine in the pharmacy. At that time the military situation was at a standstill, and we could not return home. I lay in bed and deteriorated.

We could first return home in early June. The trip was very difficult and full of obstacles. In Strasbourg we learned that my husband was already released from captivity, and that was a joy. Then we lived in wooden

barracks in Rittershoffen. There our Madeleine entered the world in 1947. We lived very frugally.

We had to start all over again. We had to buy a cow and beds and furniture. Nevertheless, we were lucky because we were all together. In 1951, we were able to move into our new house. Finally, we could live normal lives again. Thank God for that!

In the summer we took a beautiful trip along the Rhine, and when we passed the Lorelei Rock the music played Ich weiss nicht was soll es bedeuten. *Frau Ruth sang that song so beautifully in our kitchen.*

Now I shall close. Frau Ruth will need a great deal of patience to translate this long letter.

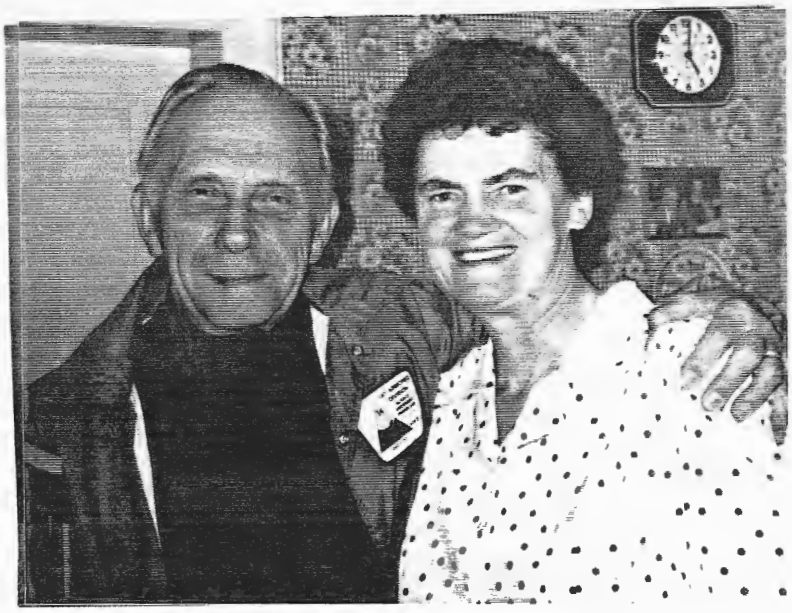
With heartfelt greetings to your whole family,

Berthe Holtzmann

While on occupation duty in Töging, Bavaria, we witnessed the plight of the Displaced Persons at a DP camp at the edge of town, but I never knew a DP personally.

If any other member of that Christmas Eve group happens to read this article, I should like to hear from him. Eddie Berg died of wounds sustained in April, 1945. The others in the crew were John Donges, Carl Phillips, and George Johnson.

For that matter, if anyone else from the 25th Tank Battalion is interested in these events, I hope he will contact me as well.



Bill, who was a soldier,

and

Annelise, who was just a little girl,

on

Christmas Eve in 1944



Berthe Holzmann,

lady of the house



The Groaning Board



Ruth and Berthe

Appendix F

SALZBURG MUSIC FESTIVAL PROGRAMS

SALZBURGER FESTSPIELE
1945

3.

SERENADE

*

DIRIGENT: DR. BERNHARD PAUMGARTNER
DAS MOZARTEUMORCHESTER

MONTAG DEN 20. AUGUST
20 UHR
IN DER FELSENREITSCHULE

The concert of the "Wiener Sängerknaben" has, for broadcast-technical reasons, to be postponed from August 22nd to August 25th 1900 h in the Mozarteum, Großer Saal. — The Oesterreichische Abend (songs by Martha Schlager-Haustein) is for the same reason moved from August 25th to August 22nd. — Admission-tickets issued for August 22nd (Wiener Sängerknaben) will pass for August 25th while those issued for August 25th (Austrian songs M. Schlager-Haustein) will be valid on August 22nd.

WOLFGANG AMADEUS MOZART
1756-1791
Marsch D-Dur, K. V. 335

WOLFGANG AMADEUS MOZART
Sinfonie A-Dur, K. V. 201
Allegro moderato
Andante-Menuetto
Allegro con spirito

JOSEPH HAYDN
1732-1809
Divertimento (Feldpartita) für 8-stimmigen Bläserchor
Allegro con spirito-Chorale St.-Antoni
Andante quasi Allegretto-Menuetto
Rondo-Allegretto

WOLFGANG AMADEUS MOZART
Sechs Deutsche Tänze, K. V. 571

*

Aus radiotechnischen Gründen muß das Konzert der Wiener Sängerknaben vom 22. August auf den 25. August, Mozarteum, Großer Saal, 19 Uhr, verlegt werden. — Der Österreichische Abend (Liederabend Martha Schlager-Haustein) wird aus den gleichen Gründen vom 25. August auf den 22. August vorverlegt. Es gelten daher die für den 22. August (Wiener Sängerknaben) ausgegebenen Karten für den 25. August, die für den 25. August (Liederabend M. Schlager-Haustein) behalten ihre Gültigkeit für den 22. August.

Salzburger Druckerei und Verlag

SALZBURGER FESTSPIELE 1945

Dienstag, den 21. August, 19 Uhr

FESTSPIELHAUS

3. Orchester-Konzert

DIRIGENT:
EUGEN JOCHUM / HAMBURG

SOLIST:
GILBERT SCHUCHTER, KLAVIER

Konzertflügel: Steinway & Sons
Alleinvertretung:
Fa. Heinrich Katholnigg, Siegmund-Haffner-Gasse 16

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN
(1770—1827)
„Egmont"-Ouvertüre

WOLFGANG AMADEUS MOZART
(1756—1791)
Klavierkonzert Nr. 24 in c-moll, K.-V. 491
Allegro
Larghetto
Allegretto

In rascher Aufeinanderfolge schrieb Mozart für seine während der Fastenzeit 1786 geplanten Subskriptions-Akademien die drei Klavierkonzerte in Es-dur, A-dur und c-moll, von denen letzteres am 24. März (einige Tage vor der Vollendung der „Figaro"-Partitur) fertiggestellt und kurz darauf durch ihn selber als Pianist und Dirigent erfolgreich uraufgeführt wurde. Es ist das hervorragendste Zeugnis seines langjährigen Ringens um die Instrumentalkonzertform und bedeutet nicht nur Krönung seiner unermüdlichen Versuche auf diesem Gebiet, sondern zugleich Überwindung eines übernommenen Schemas und Vorstoß in romantische Bezirke auf durchaus persönliche Art. Noch immer im Gewande virtuosen Spieles, das der gesellschaftlichen Unterhaltung dient, läßt das herrliche Werk in wunderbaren Klangvisionen dennoch Mozarts wahren Seelenzustand mit aller Eindringlichkeit offenbar werden. Tonart und Instrumentation (Klarinetten, tiefer Streicherklang), sprunghafte Thematik, häufige Unisoni und starke Chromatik charakterisieren das Partiturbild aller drei Sätze, von denen die freie Variationenfolge des Finales besonders kühn gestaltet ist. Was an diesem Werk immer wieder erschüttert, ist der auffallende Gegensatz zu soviel heiteren Eingebungen seines Genius, der hier in der zwischen unabwendbarer Tragik, Trost und wehmütiger Resignation schwankenden Zwiesprache von Soloinstrument und Orchester das tiefe Bekenntnis eines einsamen Herzens ergreifend zum Ausdruck bringt.

Dr. Ernst Reichert

PAUSE

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN
(1770—1827)
Symphonie Nr. 7 in A-dur, op. 92
Poco sostenuto — Vivace
Allegretto
Presto — Assai meno presto
Allegro con brio

Eine ähnliche Gegenüberstellung wie beim gleichzeitigen Entwurf der fünften und sechsten beherrscht fünf Jahre später (1812) die Arbeiten an der siebenten und achten Symphonie. In beiden Fällen zeigt sich zwischen den Polen Beethovenschen Empfindungsvermögens, zwischen Heroik und Idyllik, mit aller Deutlichkeit die ganze Skala seiner tondichterischen Ausdruckskraft. Wie die „Pastorale", so gibt sich die ausgeglichene „Achte" leichter als ihre jeweilige Vorgängerin. War bei der Fünften heldischer Kampf und Sieg die Grundidee, die in der Friedenssehnsucht der „Pastorale" ihren Ausgleich fand, so ist es bei der Siebenten die wieder mit neuen Impulsen begonnene und von Leidenschaft getragene Auseinandersetzung mit dem Leben vor der weisen Heiterkeit der achten Symphonie. Erst die „Neunte" faßt alle Gegensätze in lapidarer Geschlossenheit zusammen: von schicksalhafter Tragik durch übermenschliche Kraft zur letzten Lebensbejahung des Freudenhymnus.

Die von Richard Wagner als „Apotheose des Tanzes" bezeichnete siebente Symphonie erhält ihr Profil durch den Rhythmus: Triole und Punktierung beherrschen nach der breitgeschwungen aufwärtsstrebenden Einleitung sogleich den lebenssprühenden, von dynamischen Spannungen erfüllten ersten Satz. Nach dem marschartigen und zu ungewöhnlicher Tonfülle gesteigerten, später fugiert wiederholten Hauptthema des zweiten Satzes erscheint in einem den Holzbläsern zugedachten Mittelteil von tiefinniger Melodik wieder der Triolenrhythmus, der in geistvollen Abwandlungen auch das stürmische Scherzo und dessen ruhigeres, aus einer altösterreichischen Pilgerliedmelodie entwickelte Trio bestimmt. Dieser noch aus gebändigter Kraft gestalteten Formenwelt gibt das mit ungeheurem Elan losbrechende und in tobendem Furioso ungezügelter Leidenschaft durchgeführte Finale seinen dionysisch entfesselten Abschluß.

Aus radiotechnischen Gründen muß das Konzert der Wiener Sängerknaben vom 22. August auf den 23. August, Mozarteum, Großer Saal, 19 Uhr, verlegt werden. — Der Österreichische Abend (Liederabend Martha Schlager-Haustein) wird aus den gleichen Gründen vom 25. August auf den 22. August vorverlegt. Es gelten daher die für den 22. August (Wiener Sängerknaben) ausgegebenen Karten für den 25. August, die für den 25. August (Liederabend M. Schlager-Haustein) behalten ihre Gültigkeit für den 22. August.

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN
(1770—1827)
„Egmont"-Ouvertüre

WOLFGANG AMADEUS MOZART
(1756—1791)
Concert for Pianoforte and orchestra
C-minor (K. V. 491)
Allegro
Larghetto
Allegretto

In quick succession Mozart composed three concerts for pianoforte in Es-major, A-major and C-minor, which were intended for the "Subscription-Academies" during the Lent of 1786. The last of these concerts he finished on March 24th, a few days before he did the last stroke of pen on the "Figaro"-score. At the first performance a short time afterwards, he achieved great success with this work, but also as a pianist and conductor. It is the result of his long artistic struggling for a new form of instrumental Concert, and the crowning of his indefatigable searching in this sphere. But by this work a traditional model was overcome and an advance was undertaken into new romantic reaches, in a personal style. Although much value is laid on virtuosity a concession made to the taste of the society of that time, this splendid work of wonderful visions of sound reveals Mozart's inmost soul. At first sight, the score of the three subjects is characterized as for key and scoring (clarinets and low tone of the strings) by the quick change of the themes, frequent unisoni and application of the chromatic scale, and the Finale shows an especially daring sequence of free variations.

There is a striking contrast: This work reveals the masters knowledge of the tragic inevitability of fate, his mood of resignation, but also consolation, which finds its expression in the dialogue of solo-instrument and orchestra. Listening to this music we experience the other trait, the tragical, of this great genius, who has made us happy with so many inspirations of greatest serenity. We are deeply moved by the confession of a lonely feeling heart, which speaks to us through this work.

INTERMISSION

The concert of the "Wiener Sängerknaben" has, for broadcast-technical reasons, to be postponed from August 22nd to August 23th 1900 h in the Mozarteum, Großer Saal. — The Oesterreichische Abend (songs by Martha Schlager-Haustein) is for the same reason moved from August 25th to August 22nd. — Admission-tickets issued for August 22nd (Wiener Sängerknaben) will pass for August 25th while those issued for August 25th (Austrian songs M. Schlager-Haustein) will be valid on August 22nd.

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN
(1770—1827)
Symphony Number 7
A-major op. 92
Poco sostenuto — Vivace
Allegretto
Presto — Assai meno presto
Allegro con brio

The draft of the Fifth and Sixth Symphony show a similar polarity as those of the Seventh and Eighth, five years later (1812). In both examples the whole largeness of Beethoven's feeling is revealed, the whole scale of his creative power, from the heroic to the idyllic. From this point of view the Eighth symphony with its balanced and comparatively light mood may be compared with the "Pastorale". In the Fifth symphony heroic struggle and victory was the leading idea which finds its equalization in the deep longing for peace of the Pastorale. The Seventh Symphony reveals a new conception of life, with new impulse and passion, but the Eighth is full of wise serenity. It is the Ninth in which all these conflicts are forced together to a sublime totality of life, from the tragic fate by superhuman effort to the unreserved affirmation of life in the "Hymne to Joy."

The feature of the Seventh Symphony, which Richard Wagner has called "Apotheosis of Dancing" is rhythm. Thus the first subject with the broad movement and the climax of its introduction is governed by triplets and full of sparkling joy of life and dynamic tension. The march-like main-theme of the second subject, extraordinarily full in tune and afterwards repeated in fugues is followed by a center-part of a melody full of feeling. This part in which the wood-winds are leading shows again the triplet-rhythm, which is also prevailing in the impetuous Scherzo and the somewhat more tranquil Trio, based on a melody of an Old Austrian pilgrim's-song.

Whereas this foregoing part of the symphony is shaped with restrained vigour the Finale with its Furioso is a Dionysic outbreak of unchecked passion and ardent impetuosity.

Appendix G

CITATIONS, RIBBONS, AND MEDALS



By rows from the top. Left to right in each row.

Row 1: 20th Corps Patch, picture, 14th Armored Division Patch

Row 2: Discharge Lapel Pin (Ruptured Duck)

Row 3: Chevrons, Silver Star Medal for valor at Altenfelden, Bronze Star Medal for valor at Gertwiller, Purple Heart Medal for wounds sustained at Rittershoffen, Good Conduct Medal, Chevrons.

Row 4: American Campaign Medal, European-African-Middle East Service Medal with Rhineland and Central Europe Battle Stars, WWII Victory Medal, World War II Occupation Medal, Overseas Service Bars.

Row 5: Expert Shooting Insignia -- Sub-Machine Gun, Sharpshooter Shooting Insignia--Carbine, Marksman Shooting Insignia -- M1 Rifle.

Appendix H

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

OF PRESIDENT HARRY S TRUMAN



ALBERT W KRATZKE

To you who answered the call of your country and served in its Armed Forces to bring about the total defeat of the enemy, I extend the heartfelt thanks of a grateful Nation. As one of the Nation's finest, you undertook the most severe task one can be called upon to perform. Because you demonstrated the fortitude, resourcefulness and calm judgment necessary to carry out that task, we now look to you for leadership and example in further exalting our country in peace.

Harry Truman

THE WHITE HOUSE

Appendix I

HONORABLE DISCHARGE DOCUMENT



Honorable Discharge

This is to certify that

ALBERT W. KRATZKE, 37 561 564, TECHNICIAN FOURTH GRADE

HEADQUARTERS COMPANY, 25TH TANK BATTALION

Army of the United States

is hereby Honorably Discharged from the military service of the United States of America.

This certificate is awarded as a testimonial of Honest and Faithful Service to this country.

Given at SEPARATION CENTER
CAMP MC COY, WISCONSIN

Date 26 FEBRUARY 1946

P.O 92936

Filed for record March 6 1946
at 10 o'clock A M., and recorded
in Book 7 of Discharges page 403
Reuben C. Eide Reg. of Deeds
Pope County, Minnesota. ✓

Thomas B. Hammond

THOMAS B. HAMMOND
MAJOR AGD

Appendix J

SEPARATION QUALIFICATION RECORD

Army of the United States

SEPARATION QUALIFICATION RECORD

SAVE THIS FORM. IT WILL NOT BE REPLACED IF LOST

BJS

This record of job assignments and special training received in the Army is furnished to the soldier when he leaves the service. In its preparation, information is taken from available Army records and supplemented by personal interview. The information about civilian education and work experience is based on the individual's own statements. The veteran may present this document to former employers, prospective employers, representatives of schools or colleges, or use it in any other way that may prove beneficial to him.

1. LAST NAME—FIRST NAME—MIDDLE INITIAL		
KRATZKE, ALBERT W		
2. ARMY SERIAL No.	3. GRADE	4. SOCIAL SECURITY No.
37 561 564	Tec-4	474-20-4377

5. PERMANENT MAILING ADDRESS (*Street, City, County, State*)
Box 11
Villard Polk County Minnesota

6. DATE OF ENTRY INTO ACTIVE SERVICE	7. DATE OF SEPARATION	8. DATE OF BIRTH
17 May 1943	26 Feb 1946	17 Sep 1923

9. PLACE OF SEPARATION
SEPARATION CENTER, CAMP McCOY, WIS.

MILITARY OCCUPATIONAL ASSIGNMENTS

10. MONTHS	11. GRADE	12. MILITARY OCCUPATIONAL SPECIALTY
2	Pvt	Medical basic 657
12	Tec-4	Artillery mechanic 802
15	Tec-4	Tank commander 2736

SUMMARY OF MILITARY OCCUPATIONS

13. TITLE—DESCRIPTION—RELATED CIVILIAN OCCUPATION

TANK COMMANDER: (2736) Was responsible for control, coordination, and tactical employment of the tank and crew assigned to him under combat conditions.

24. SIGNATURE OF PERSON BEING SEPARATED	25. SIGNATURE OF SEPARATION CLASSIFICATION OFFICER	26. NAME OF OFFICER (*Typed or Stamped*)
Albert W. Kratzke	[illegible]	I ECHT 2nd LT F A

Appendix K

LETTER OF BRIGADIER GENERAL JOHN K. RICE



ARMY SERVICE FORCES
SIXTH SERVICE COMMAND
HEADQUARTERS CAMP McCOY AND WAR
DEPARTMENT PERSONNEL CENTER
OFFICE OF THE COMMANDING GENERAL



Camp McCoy, Wisconsin

To those being separated from the Military Service:

Congratulations upon completion of your military mission. And our appreciation for any part — combat or otherwise — that you may have played in fulfillment of your obligation as a citizen of the United States in this greatest of war efforts.

I hope our counsellors and other Separation Center personnel may have helped in some way toward your success and happiness as a civilian.

May I offer this for your future thought. It is quoted from the Stars and Stripes and appeals to me as the finest expression of a soldier's creed that I have ever seen.

"IF YOU KEEP FAITH

If you keep faith with me you need not weep
If I am killed, for I will not complain
Of any death if by it others gain
The things I think are worth my life to keep;
The right to have, to know, to love, to speak.
If all win these, I will endure my pain
And on the battlefront, where I have lain,
Will find an honored place in which to sleep.
But if when peace returns to you once more
You break the word you gave humanity
By keeping not the pledge to which you swore,
Then carve in stone this epitaph for me:
'Here lies a fool who placed his hope in war
And gave his faith to insincerity'."

(Lieut. Jack E. Spear, Inf. 3rd Army
KIA Dec. 1944 in the Ardennes)

God speed — best of luck — and again many thanks for all that you have accomplished for our common benefit.

John K. Rice

JOHN K. RICE
Brigadier General, U. S. A.
Commanding

Appendix L

ADDRESS OF BRIGADIER GENERAL JOHN K. RICE

Resume of final address as delivered in the name of Brigadier General John K. Rice, Commanding General of Camp McCoy, to each group of soldiers as they were separated from the military service:

On this occasion, your last formation as members of the Armed Forces, it is fitting that you should receive the following message from the commanding general of this separation center.

You are being discharged from the Army today -- from your Army. It is your Army because your skill and your patriotism, your labor and courage and devotion have been some of the factors which make it great. You have been a member of the finest military team in history. You have accomplished miracles in battle and supply. Your country is proud of you, and you have every right to be proud of yourselves.

You have seen, in the lands where you worked and fought and where many of your comrades died, what happens when the people of a nation lose interest in their government. You have seen what happens when they follow false leaders. You have seen what happens when a nation accepts hate and intolerance.

We all are determined that what happened in Europe and in Asia must not happen to our country. Back in civilian life you will find that your generation will be called upon to guide our country's destiny. Opportunity for leadership is yours. The responsibility is yours. The nation which depended on your courage and stamina to protect it from its enemies now expects you as individuals to claim your right of leadership, a right which you earned honorably and which is well deserved.

Start being a leader as soon as you put on your civilian clothes. If you see intolerance and hate, speak out against them. Make your individual voices heard, not for selfish things, but for honor and decency among men, for the rights of all people

Remember, too, that no American can afford to be disinterested in any part of his government, whether it is county, city, state, or nation.

Choose your leaders wisely -- that is the way to keep ours the country for which you fought. Make sure that those leaders are determined to maintain peace throughout the world. You know what war is. You know that we must not have another. As individuals you can prevent it if you give to the task which lies ahead the same spirit which you displayed in uniform.

Accept that trust and the challenge which it carries. I know that the people of America are counting on you. I know that you will not let them down

Good-bye to each and every one of you, and to each and every one of you, good luck!

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Bonn, Keith E. When the Odds were Even -- The Vosges Mountain Campaign. Novato, California: Presdio Press, 1994. 294 p.

Cardinal, Ralph. History of the 25th Tank Battalion. 1945.

Cole, Hugh M. The History of the European Theater of Operations. The Ardennes: Battle of the Bulge. Government Printing Office, Washington, D.C.: Office of the Chief of Military History Dept. of the Army.

Colley, David. "Operation Northwind," Veterans of Foreign Wars Magazine, January, 1995.

MacDonald, Charles B. The History of The European Theater of Operations. The Siegfried Line Campaign. Government Printing Office, Washington, D.C.: Office of the Chief of Military History Dept. of the Army, 1963.

MacDonald, Charles B. The History of the European Theater of Operations, The Last Offensive. Government Printing Office, Washington, D.C.: Office of the Chief of Military History Dept. of the Army, 1973.

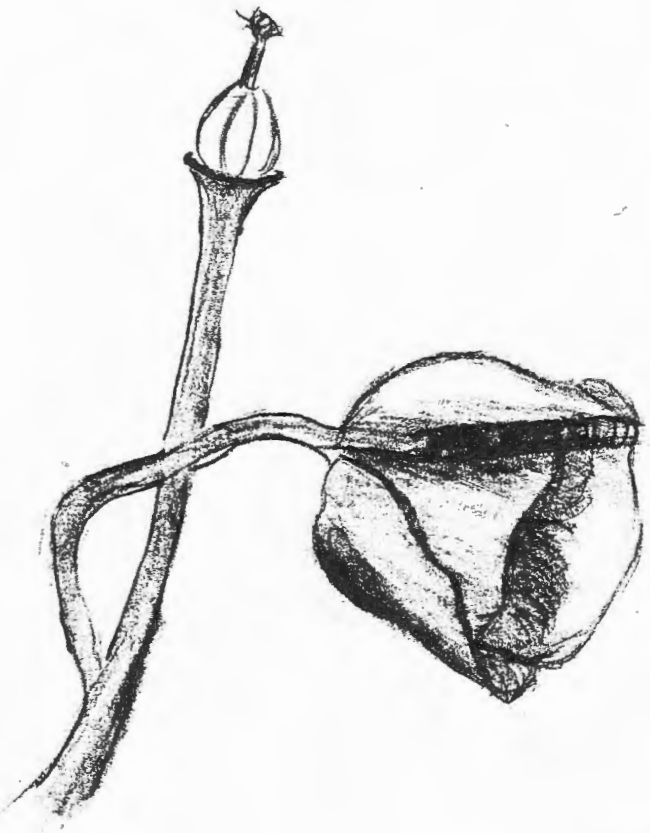
MacDonald, Charles B. A Time for Trumpets. New York: William Morrow and Co., 1985. 712 p.

Whiting, Charles. The Other Battle of the Bulge -- Operation Northwind. Chelsea, MI: Scarborough House. 198 p.

A poppy --

that we

may remember!



— Jessica Hagedorn
'77

CHRISTMAS EVE 1944



I should like to share with our readers an interesting and poignant story. It begins on Christmas Eve, 1944 and continues to the present, in fact it is still unfolding.

Those of you who have a copy of the memorial book that Mme. Pommois prepared for the fortieth anniversary of the Hatten-Rittershoffen battle may recall that in the book one Berthe Holzmann recounts how those members of the 14th Armored billetted in her home shared Christmas Eve, 1944, with her and her family and notes that some of the soldiers even sang some German Carols. I was the one of our group (fiveof us, i.e., one tank crew) who knew the German songs. My story (actually our story—Berthe's and mine) from that Christmas Eve to the present is recorded below.

We did, indeed sing Carols — *Stille Nacht, O Tannenbaum,* etc. We also shared our Christmas treats. Berthe had some German Christmas cookies which she brought out. The Christmas tree was kind of sparse, but she had one, unlike many other families in the town. The candles were real and probably a terrible fire hazard. I remember that there were two little boys and a little girl. I also remember that we were comfortably quartered that night. But what I remember most was how I wondered what the fate of that family was when we returned several weeks afterward, I learned forty years later.

In June of 1985 my wife, Ruth and I went to the Hatten-Rittershoffen fortieth anniversary observation. Ted Perkins graciously allowed us to join his tour group as 'tag-alongs' and on the Monday following the official ceremonies his group went to Rittershoffen. We followed in our rented car and visited sites with them. They left in mid-morning and Ruth and I remained in Rittershoffen.

Then began the search for the family with which I had stayed on Christmas Eve forty years earlier. The only identification I could recall was that the little girl's name was AnneLies. (We had not yet read the memorial book for if we had we would have known the name of the family.) I asked a man on the street if he knew anyone named AnneLies that was about forty-five years old. He and another lady that came on the scene responded immediately that it had to be AnneLies Holzmann. We were informed that she was married and lived in another town.

However, the mayor's secretary was Berthe's daughter-in-law (Otto's wife. Otto and Alfred were the boys I remembered.) and she immediately got on the phone. Soon Berthe and Madeleine, another daughter, born after the war, appeared in the Town Hall Square.

A happy reunion! Berthe remembered me. (I happen to be quite blonde and even in my sixties I may have less hair but it is still blonde. Berthe said that was one of the identifying features.) She said that she remembered that I had hung a Christmas Card on her tree. Soon my wife and I were gathered around the Holzmann kitchen table with Berthe, her son Alfred, Alfred's wife, Otto's wife, daughter Patricia and Madeleine. Of course, the *Schnapps* was brought out. They offered to have us take the bottle with us and if the group had still been together I surely would have accepted. (Most of you readers remember the home made 'white lightning.')

We sang *Die Lorelei* and some other German songs. Before we left Otto insisted that we accept a gift. He is a wood carver, and he gave us a miniature harvest fork and flail that now graces our dining room wall. Later that day we purchased an Alsatian doll which we named — what else? — AnneLies. When we returned home we sent Berthe's granddaughter, Patty, a Seattle T-shirt and sent the family some 16 x 20 color photos of typical mountain and seashore scenes from the Northwest. (I am a serious amateur photographer.)

The subsequent exchange of thank-you notes began a correspondance that has continued to the present. In one of my letters I asked Berthe what happened to her and her family during those bitter days of January, 1945, and also to the end of the war. She responded with a letter that must have been difficult for her to write. I later asked her if she would mind if I shared that letter with the readers of the **Liberator**. She agreed and the letter follows. My translation is quite literal, and I've made no attempt to put the letter into colloquial English. I think the feelings evoked by Berthe's descriptions are better preserved this way.

Dear Kratzke Family,

I received your kind letter with the good wishes. I am pleased that you again have thought of me. I wish you and yours the best in the New Year—happiness, health, and God's Blessings. Many thanks for the pictures of your lovely grandchildren. In the summer we shall take pictures of us, too, so that you might learn our whole family. You have already met our Patricia-Emmy Holzmann. Then comes Otto's children: Freddy-Otto, Cathy-Caroline and Christine-Michele Holzmann. AnneLies' children: Remy-Albert and Jacky-Robert Stumpf in Roppenheim (a village on the Rhine). Then Madeleine's children: Erick-Robert, Christopher-Charles, and Sylvie-Corine Graff.

I shall never forget the Christmas of 1944. I didn't know where my husband was, it was a sad time, we had no lights, and there were soldiers everywhere. I wanted to make things pleasant for the children, but unfortunately, there were no gifts.

The night before the holiday I sat down at sewing machine and sewed them some things, I set up a small carbide lamp on the stove and brought the machine up close. We surely did not know what lay before us.

Constantly, I have to thank God that we survived.

What I have written in the Memorial Book is not nearly all that we experienced, With half-frozen feet we wandered here and there and didn't know where we were. We were often near death although we were away from the battle. Once we were almost smothered when a truck with a trailer took us to Germany. Once we sat in an inn where someone gave us something to eat. When that town was bombed we were scarcely out on the street when the entire building fell in and the innkeeper lay dead under the ruins. At a collection point we were able to wash out our eyes but with very little water and one pocket handkerchief for six people.

Then we were transported by railroad. The snow was fifty centimeters deep and the train was full of snow and ice. The toilets were frozen. It was dreadful. We had to climb over a bank in order to find a clean place. Often the train stood at one place for a long time because the depots were being bombed. We didn't know where we were or where we were going. The train always moved in the pitch-black night.

Finally, we arrived in Ulm. From there we again went farther in an encampment where there was a long hall which was nice and warm but it was so full that most of the people had to sit on the floor. Until then we had not wept, not even the children during the battles because we were so numbed by fear, anxiety, and cold. Then the tears flowed when a refined lady sang a German song with her daughter. It went, "Again I would to the homeland, the dear country to greet." The whole hall cried, cried, cried.

Then in a horse-drawn sled we came to a small farming town. Someone gave us a large room with two beds and we could finally get clean again. It was the best time in our travels. The skin over our whole bodies was completely broken out from the dirt and the cold. We did not know our own faces and our hair was full of soot and dirt. The people brought us potatoes and apples. Also, worn clothes, which then I made over for us.

We helped the people by working and thus earned our bread. Alfred had to deliver milk from an old lady to the dairy and thereby received our milk for nothing. My mother knitted stockings from old wool remnants that were in tatters Alfred went to school, Otto to kindergarten, 'Annelisle' (the people called her that) simply would not go with the strange children. She understood but would not speak. Instead, she went to an old lady and there she would get bread and butter and something sweet.

We were able to recover a little but then the war also came there. We had air raid alarms two or there times a day and also in the night. Again, we sat in the cellars and foxholes. We asked ourselves,"Must we experience yet another battle?" There was no more big battle but we were still being fired upon. The town was occupied, it was plundered, and the women violated. At that time the soldiers were not so decent to us as you were.

Once more we came away with our lives. Our guardian angel had not forsaken us. But then I became very ill with a gall bladder infection. The doctor could not help since there was no more medicine in the pharmacy. At that time the military situation was at a standstill and we could not return home. I lay in bed and deteriorated.

We could first return home in early June. The trip home was very difficult and full of obstacles. In Strassburg we learned that my husband was already released from captivity and that was a joy. Then we lived in wooden barracks in Rittershoffen. There our Madeleine entered the world in 1947. We lived very frugally.

We had to start all over again. We had to buy a cow but also beds and furniture. But nevertheless we were lucky because we were all together again. In 1951 we were able to move into our new house. Finally, we could again live normal lives. Thank God for that.

Now I shall close. Frau Ruth will need a great deal of patience to translate this long letter.

With heartfelt greetings,
Also greetings to your
whole family,
Berthe Holzmann

In the summer we took a beautiful trip along the Rhine and when we passed by the Lorelei Rock the music played *"Ich weiss nicht was soll es bedeuten."* Frau Ruth sang that song so beautifully in our kitchen.

While on occupation duty in Töging, Bavaria we witnessed the plight of the displaced persons since there was a DP camp at the edge of town. However, I had never known a DP personally. Berthe's letter gives some indication of the anguish and worry they experienced.

If any other member of that Christmas Eve group reads this, I'd be pleased if you would correspond with me. Eddie Berg died of wounds sustained in April, 1945, but the others were John Donges, Carl Phillips, and George Johnson. For that matter, if anyone else from the 25th Tank Battalion is interested in these events, please contact me.

Bill Kratzke
Headquarters Company
25th Tank Battalion



COMING REUNIONS OF THE 14th ARMORED DIVISION

24th ANNUAL REUNION OF THE 14th ARMORED DIV. ASSN.
September 14 - 18, 1988
Town & Country Motel
San Diego, CA.
Morris Wax, National President

25th ANNUAL REUNION OF THE 14th ARMORED DIV. ASSN.
September 7 - 10, 1989
Marriott Hotel
New Orleans, LA.
John Copes III

26th ANNUAL REUNION OF THE 14th ARMORED DIV. ASSN.
September 6 - 9, 1990
Marriott Hotel?
St. Louis, MO.
William Thompson

27th ANNUAL REUNION OF THE 14th ARMORED DIV. ASSN.
September 5 - 8, 1991
Columbus or Cincinnati, Ohio
Robert Gerstacker

★ Mail Call Cont. ★

OBELISK FOR THE 47TH TANK BN.

In the last issue of the **Liberator** I made an appeal for donations to erect an OBELISK for our Battalion. This OBELISK will be erected in the Memorial Park West of the Patton Museum, definitely a place fo honor for those who served in the 47th Bn. and those who gave their lives in Defense of our Country.

Please send your donation $20.00 or whatever you wsh or can afford to send to:
Ken Clapper Custodion 47th Fund
43Lakeshore Dr.
Danville IL 61832

Sincerely,
H. H. Kiehne
927 Milson Ct.
LaCrosse, WI 54601

Continued on page 9


TO HONOR, FOR ETERNITY,
THOSE GALLANT SOLDIERS,
WHO SERVED, FOUGHT, AND
DIED, TO PRESERVE DEMOCRACY.
25TH TANK BATTALION
LT. COL ERNEST C. WATSON, CMDG.
VOSGES MTS.-ALSACE (RITTERSHOFFEN) -BITCHE
SALIENT-SIEGFREID LINE (STEINFELD) -BAVARIA